BARBARA HARLOW

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for my mother and father
Lucille and Francis Foley

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Abbreviations in citations

ANF	Molefe Pheto, *And Night Fell*
AS	Julio Cortazar, "Apocalypse at Solentiname"
BOANYB	Ayi Kwei Armah, *The Beautyful Ones are Not Yet Born*
BPSA	Tom Lodge, *Black Politics in South Africa*
BS	Basil Davidson, *Black Star*
CCD	Armand Mattelart, *La Culture contre la démocratie*
CNG	Keith Ellis, *Cuba's Nicolás Guillén*
CT	Bessie Head, *The Collector of Treasures*
D	Ngugi wa Thiong'o, *Detained*
Days	Ruth First, *117 Days*
DN	M. M. Bakhtin, "Discourse in the novel," in *The Dialogic Imagination*
DP	Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish*
DW	Mu'in Basisu, *Descent into the Water*
ENS	Sabri Hafez, "The Egyptian novel in the sixties," in Issa J. Boullata (ed.), *Critical Perspectives on Modern Arabic Literature*
EOC	Ariel Dorfman, *The Empire's Old Clothes*
EPH	Eric Wolf, *Europe and the People without History*
FFM	Omar Cabezas, *Fire from the Mountains*
HF	Tahar Ben Jelloun, *Hospitalité française*
IAF	Ismail-Sabri Abdalla *et al.* (eds), *Images of the Arab Future*
IAS	Selig Harrison, *In Afghanistan's Shadow*

INR	Doris Tijerino, *Inside the Nicaraguan Revolution*
IR	Manuel Maldonado Denis, "The intellectual's role in Puerto Rico today"
IRM	Rigoberta Menchu, *I . . . Rigoberta Menchu*
JP	Nadine Gordimer, *July's People*
LD	Hugo Blanco, *Land or Death*
LM	Elias Khouri, *The Lost Memory*
LMS	Domitila Barrios de Chungara, *Let Me Speak*
LROP	Ghassan Kanafani, *Literature of Resistance in Occupied Palestine*
MPSL	Leila Khaled, *My People Shall Live*
NAKA	Robert Fraser, *The Novels of Ayi Kwei Armah*
NGR	C. L. R. James, *Nkrumah and the Ghana Revolution*
NR	Bridget Aldaraca *et al.* (eds), *Nicaragua in Revolution*
ODL	Manlio Argueta, *One Day of Life*
PB	Ngugi wa Thiong'o, *Petals of Blood*
PC	Ghassan Kanafani, *Palestine's Children*
POU	Barbara Goodwin and Keith Taylor, *The Politics of Utopia*
PP	Barry Feinberg (ed.), *Poets to the People*
PTS	Sarah Graham-Brown, *Palestinians and Their Society*
PU	Frederic Jameson, *The Political Unconscious*
PW	A. M. Elmessiri (ed.), *The Palestinian Wedding*
RI	Indres Naidoo, *Robben Island*
RS	Amilcar Cabral, *Return to the Source*
RSA	Margaret Randall, *Risking a Somersault in the Air*
RW	Sipho Sepamla, *A Ride on the Whirlwind*
S	Akhtar Baluch, "'Sister, are you still here?'"
SD	Margaret Randall, *Sandino's Daughters*
SH	Chris Searle (ed.), *Sunflower of Hope*
SI	Sonallah Ibrahim, *The Smell of It*
SMR	Etel Adnan, *Sitt Marie Rose*
SMW	Julio Cortazar, "Something more than words," in George Theiner (ed.), *They Shoot Writers, Don't They?*
TBOF	Sergio Ramirez, *To Bury Our Fathers*
TCAT	Breyten Breytenbach, *The True Confessions of an Albino Terrorist*
TE	Amnesty International, *Torture in the Eighties*

TFA	Chinua Achebe, *Things Fall Apart*
TH	Mehdi Charef, *Le Thé au harem d'Archi Ahmed*
TM	Maina wa Kinyatti (ed.), *Thunder from the Mountains*
TO	Elias Khouri, *Time of Occupation*
TTW	Armand Mattelart, *Transnationals and the Third World*
URSP	Mike Davis, "Urban renaissance and the spirit of postmodernism"
US	Amilcar Cabral, *Unity and Struggle*
WBBF	Margaret Dickinson (ed.), *When Bullets Begin to Flower*
WE	Frantz Fanon, *The Wretched of the Earth*
WNLM	Stephanie Urdang, "Women in national liberation movements," in Margaret Jean Hay and Sharon Stichter (eds), *African Women South of the Sahara*
WP	Ngugi wa Thiong'o, *Writers in Politics*
WPZ	Nawal al-Saadawi, *Woman at Point Zero*

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Preface

In Chinua Achebe's first novel, *Things Fall Apart*,[1] written in Nigeria in 1958, a story or folktale is told by the Igbo villagers, passed on from mother to daughter, which explains how the tortoise came to have a cracked shell. According to the legend, the hungry tortoise, who was known for his cunning, his "sweet tongue" and volubility, persuaded the birds to take him with them to visit their hosts in the sky. Once they had agreed to the tortoise's proposal, each of the birds provided the tortoise with a feather and agreed to his plan that they all should take new names for the occasion. Tortoise took the name "All of you," and through this linguistic manipulation succeeded in getting for himself the best part of the food and palm wine served at the feast in the sky. The angry birds then took back their feathers, leaving the tortoise stranded high above the earth. The parrot, however, agreed to deliver a message from the tortoise to his wife telling her to provide a soft landing place for her husband. Parrot in turn altered the message and the tortoise landed in a pile of "hoes, matchets, spears, guns and even his cannon" which were taken from his home. The medicine man in the village had to stick back together all the bits and pieces of the tortoise's shell. And, according to the Igbo story, "that is why the tortoise's shell is not smooth."

In the context of Achebe's novel, written two years before Nigerian independence and set in the early days of European colonization, this folktale, which purports to explain a natural

phenomenon of the village world, takes on a political significance and becomes an allegory for an African strategy for independence. Tortoise, in such an allegory, represents colonial power. He is articulate and succeeds through his ability to manipulate language in controlling and subjugating the birds. The possessions in his house are shown to be largely weapons: spears, guns, and a cannon. The birds are at his mercy and remain his victims until they in turn learn to use the very weapons which tortoise has wielded against them. The tortoise shell is shattered by the matchets and guns. More importantly, this happens because the parrot, legendary for his proclivity to repeat just what he has heard, has overcome this stereotypical image and learned to use language to his and the birds' own ends. He has altered the tortoise's message to his wife. The folk wisdom in this fable turns out in fact to be ideologically sophisticated and Achebe's message is clear: the language skills of rhetoric together with armed struggle are essential to an oppressed people's resistance to domination and oppression and to an organized liberation movement.

Chinua Achebe is a novelist, but his works, although as novels they derive from a European genre and tradition, nonetheless challenge the formal criteria of those generic conventions. The tale of the tortoise and the birds from *Things Fall Apart* is but one example of this literary challenge. The same novel in its entirety, which tells the story of Okonkwo and his village of Umuofia, can be seen as an African/Nigerian/Igbo response to the study announced in the novel by the European district commissioner and which the commissioner describes on the last page of Achebe's work.

> As [the commissioner] walked back to the court he thought about that book. Every day brought him some new material. The story of this man who had killed a messenger and hanged himself would make interesting reading. One could almost write a whole chapter on him. Perhaps not a whole chapter but a reasonable paragraph, at any rate. There was so much else to include, and one must be firm in cutting out details. He had already chosen the title of the book, after much thought: *The Pacification of the Primitive Tribes of the Lower Niger.* (TFA, 187)

The struggle for national liberation and independence, particularly in the twentieth century, on the part of colonized peoples in those areas of the world over which Western Europe and North America have sought socio-economic control and cultural dominion has produced a significant corpus of literary writing, both narrative and poetic, as well as a broad spectrum of theoretical analyses of the political, ideological, and cultural parameters of this struggle. This literature, like the resistance and national liberation movements which it reflects and in which it can be said to participate, not only demands recognition of its independent status and existence as literary production, but as such also presents a serious challenge to the codes and canons of both the theory and the practice of literature and its criticism as these have been developed in the West.

The present study of "resistance literature" is intended as an examination of certain representative aspects of that literature, which until now has been largely excluded or ignored not only in traditional departments of literature organized according to "national" criteria (English, American, German, French: it is significant too that most French departments, for example, do not include in their curriculum the francophone literatures of sub-Saharan Africa, North Africa, Vietnam, etc., in the same way that African or Caribbean literature written in English is not part of the required reading for an English major, and Central American or South American texts are excluded from the programs of American Studies), but even in comparative literature, which tends to restrict itself to the more northern parts of the globe when seeking material for comparison. Given, furthermore, the current intensity of the debate and the rapid developments in contemporary literary critical theory in the West (structuralism, deconstruction, psychoanalysis, Marxism, etc.), it is important to examine the applicability of these theoretical structures and modalities outside the cultural tradition which produced them. Can they be deployed in analyzing the literary output of geopolitical areas which stand in opposition to the very social and political organization within which the theories are located and to which they respond? Is there, to take just one example – that suggested by the Moroccan writer Abdelkebir Khatibi in his book *Maghreb pluriel* – more than chronological coincidence to connect "deconstruction"

and "decolonization?"[2] Khatibi, at any rate, claims ideological affinities for the two movements and sees critical potential in developing their association. Are the structures manipulated by structural anthropologists and literary critics alike assimilable finally, except perhaps in the way the parrot assimilates the tortoise's machinations, by the literary developments in Kenya, Peru, or Palestine?

Such theoretical questions underlie the basic project of this study which proposes to investigate a particular category of literature that emerged significantly as part of the organized national liberation struggles and resistance movements in Africa, Latin America, and the Middle East, and which may be called *resistance literature*. Part of the task will, of course, be to attempt to define the term "resistance literature" and its application. This definition will be undertaken largely through a reading of the literary material itself, together with critical essays and studies, both by the writers themselves and from the ideologues and theoreticians of the revolution who have articulated a role for literature and poets within the struggle alongside the gun, the pamphlet, and the diplomatic delegation.

While it is hoped that the many works and writers treated here represent as extensively as possible the diversity and scope of resistance literature, the selection is in no way intended as either exhaustive or definitive. In some cases, the inclusion of certain writers will seem arbitrary, as will the absence of many others. This is due in obvious part to the material limitations of this one study, preliminary and explorative as it is. Each writer, not to mention each resistance movement, warrants further independent treatment too. In another way, however, the apparent arbitrariness is also a consequence of the institutions of publication and distribution in both the "first" and "third" worlds where various forms of censorship or neglect have imposed real restrictions on the availability of this literary production. Much of the writing circulates in ephemeral forms, broadsheets, newspapers, typescripts, and cassettes. Given too that a publisher in New York may decide that translations of Palestinian literature are not "marketable," or that a government censor in Argentina or Lebanon may confiscate the entire printing of a collection of short stories because one of the stories is considered "objectionable,"

resistance literature continues to wage a struggle for liberation on many levels and in many arenas. This ongoing struggle is part of its political and cultural agenda.

Although a considerable amount of the literature of resistance has been written in English (the language of one colonial power), much of it has not and is in French, Portuguese, or Spanish (representing the influence of other colonial powers), or in the native language of the area, such as Arabic, Gikuyu (Kenya), South American Indian dialects, etc. The very choice of the language in which to compose is itself a political statement on the part of the writer and will need to be considered in each case, from author to author, country to country. The debate on language is crucial to a discussion of resistance literature, involving as it does questions of writer and background as well as issues of readership and audience. After independence, for example, Mozambique, Angola, and Guinea-Bissau retained Portuguese as the official language. This was done in the interest both of transcending tribal and linguistic differences within the national boundaries and of maintaining communication and solidarity with the Portuguese working classes who had supported the 1974 army coup in Portugal which preceded and made possible the final liberation of Portugal's African colonies. In Algeria, on the other hand, the question of "Arabization" still remains a priority on the national agenda. This study, however, will be concerned for the most part with the resistance literature which is available in English, whether through translation or because it was originally written in English (although where necessary for purposes of analysis, reference will be made to the original language). The decision to work, whenever possible, with material in English is conditioned by one of the purposes of the study, which is to introduce this literature to the western reader and critic. Hopefully it will encourage too the translation of further works from the literature of resistance.

The study is divided into five chapters: 1) the theoretical–historical context; 2) resistance poetry; 3) narratives of resistance; 4) prison memoirs of political detainees; 5) commitment to the future: utopia, dystopia, and post-independence developments; and an epilogue. The organization of the chapters according to formal, rather than national or linguistic, criteria, for example,

reflects the debate raised by resistance literature around the national categorization of literatures employed by western literary criticism. Such an organization also raises other questions such as that of "acculturated forms," western genres like the novel or autobiography which have been adopted or adapted by writers in colonized cultures. In any event, the strictly generic classification collapses in the later chapters on prison memoirs and utopian/dystopian fictions as social and political issues emerge in such a way as to redefine the formal criteria and codifications. One important disadvantage, however, to the generic organization, even loosely construed, is the loss of a certain historical depth and continuity to the analyses. In the best of circumstances, future work will redress such loss; it is, in the words of Dennis Brutus, "the much/that still needs to be done." In the meantime, whatever the framework, a certain flexibility and tentativeness is desirable since the struggle is not yet over and new material continues to be made available. This condition, apparently circumstantial, is itself part of the challenge posed by resistance literature and its theoretical implications.

There are many people who must be thanked for the ways in which they contributed to this book. The study itself has evolved out of my own training in comparative literature in the western academic context, which was followed by six years in the Department of English and Comparative Literature at the American University in Cairo. A great deal is owed to my friends, students, and colleagues in Egypt, who introduced me not only to the Arabic language and its literary history, but more importantly still to the political consciousness which attaches to a certain practice of Arabic literature today. That original interest, which resulted in a volume of translations of Palestinian stories by Ghassan Kanafani, involved me as well in the history of the Palestinian resistance movement. Here again, I am indebted to those friends involved in that movement who shared with me their larger historical vision. The work on Kanafani led to an expanded interest in resistance organizations in other parts of the world. Many thus are the individuals who have contributed to this volume, with ideas, quarrels, materials, support, criticism, and a shared commitment to the visions and ideals of these resistance movements. I only hope I have not abused them in my presentation of the literature of

a collective resistance. In particular, I want to mention with gratitude some of the many who have read and discussed this material with me: Edward Said and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak for their support and example; Ferial Ghazoul, Ceza Kassem Draz, and Hasna Reda of Cairo; and Lee Quinby and Derek Linton at Hobart and William Smith Colleges. The anonymous readers of the manuscript also were helpful in their criticism and suggestions. Janice Price of Methuen provided continuing encouragement as did Merrilyn Julian. Mary Ahl and Olga Vrana typed the final version of the manuscript. I want also to thank Jonathan Culler, Philip Bohlman, Uday Mehta, and the other fellows at the Society for the Humanities at Cornell University in 1985–6 when the topic which brought us together and this book to completion was "non-European traditions in western civilization." The tradition of resistance may not be a uniquely "non-European" one, but it has a special and urgent role to play in today's challenge on the part of the "Third World" to another European and United States tradition, that of political and cultural hegemony and domination. Finally, I want to acknowledge not only the support and ruthless editorial criticism of my husband, David Konstan, but his own contribution to thinking and working our way through to new possibilities of individual and collective solidarity.

i

The theoretical–historical context

A profound break in history, that is, a rearrangement of classes in society, shakes up individuality, establishes the perception of the fundamental problems of lyric poetry from a new angle, and so saves art from eternal repetition.

Leon Trotsky – *Literature and Revolution*

That was when he began writing on the walls
in his own handwriting
on fences and buildings
and on the giant billboards.
The change was no small thing
quite the contrary
in the beginning
he fell into a deep creative slump.

It's just that sonnets don't look good on walls
and phrases he was mad about before, like
"oh abysmal sandalwood, honey of moss"
looked like a big joke on peeling walls.

Roque Dalton – "History of a poetic"

I would have liked to tell you
the story of a nightingale who died

I would have liked to tell you
the story . . .
Had they not slit my lips.

Samih al-Qassim – "Slit lips"

Cultural resistance

The term "resistance" (*muqāwamah*) was first applied in a description of Palestinian literature in 1966 by the Palestinian writer and critic Ghassan Kanafani in his study *Literature of Resistance in Occupied Palestine: 1948–1966*.[1] Kanafani's critical essay was, significantly, written in 1966, before the June War of 1967 whose culmination in the defeat of the Egyptian and Jordanian armies by the Israeli forces resulted in the Israeli occupation of the West Bank of the Jordan River and the Gaza Strip and the opening of the border between these territories, now referred to as the "Occupied Territories," and Israel. As such, it proposes an important distinction between literature which has been written "under occupation" (*taht al-ihtilāl*) and "exile" (*manfa*) literature. Such a distinction presupposes a people's collective relationship to a common land, a common identity, or a common cause on the basis of which it becomes possible to articulate the difference between the two modes of historical and political existence, between, that is, "occupation" and "exile." The distinction presupposes furthermore an "occupying power" which has either exiled or subjugated, in this case both exiled and subjugated, a given population and has in addition significantly intervened in the literary and cultural development of the people it has dispossessed and whose land it has occupied. Literature, in other words, is presented by the critic as an arena of *struggle*.

In 1966, when Kanafani wrote his study, the literature of occupied Palestine (Israel) was, because of official repression and censorship inside Israel and studied neglect within the Arab world, largely unknown outside the borders of the then 18-year-old state of Israel. Much of Kanafani's research and work is thus concerned with documenting the existence and material conditions of production of Palestinian literature under Israeli

occupation, in the face of what he designates as a "cultural siege" (*hisār thaqāfi*). The same political conditions, furthermore, which determined Palestinian literary production under Israeli occupation played a no less significant role in defining the parameters and approach available to the Palestinian literary critic writing in exile. Kanafani problematizes these conditions by opening his literary critical study with an apparent disclaimer, stating that "this study is wanting in one of the basic elements on which an essential part of the results of research generally depends, and that is an abundance of sources." (LROP, 11)

The very conditions of research into the literature of occupied Palestine in 1966, however, like the conditions of production of that literature, provide the basis for a re-examination of literary critical methodologies and the definitions whereby a literary corpus is established. Kanafani's opening disclaimer is in fact a theoretical statement, one which summons attention not only to Palestinian resistance literature but to the critic's own ideological approach and historical disposition with regard to this literature. According to Kanafani:

> The attempts at a history of the resistance literature of a given people are usually, for reasons that are self-evident, accomplished after liberation. With respect to the literature of resistance in occupied Palestine, however, it is necessary that the Arab reader in general and the Palestinian emigrant in particular study its persistent continuation, because it is fundamentally to be found in the language itself and speech of the Arabs of occupied Palestine. The resistance springs from these linguistic initiatives, working together with the rigidity of the conditions of the situation. (LROP, 11)

Furthermore, the critic goes on, "No research of this kind can be complete unless the researcher is located within the resistance movement itself inside the occupied land, taking his testimony from the place in which it is born, lives and is propagated: the lips of the people." (LROP, 12) Kanafani not only disclaims any pretense to "academic objectivity" or "scientific dispassion," he rejects too the very relevance in a study of resistance literature of such critical stances or poses. In this, the Palestinian writer

reiterates the contention of other critics of a literature of resistance such as the Puerto Rican Manuel Maldonado Denis. In an essay written in 1965 and entitled "The intellectual's role in Puerto Rico today," Denis contested the presumed detachment of some Puerto Rican intellectuals: "Isolation itself," he wrote, "is already a posture."[2]

Ghassan Kanafani, in referring to Palestinian literature as "resistance literature," is writing within a specific historical context, a context which may be most immediately situated within the contemporary national liberation struggles and resistance movements against Western imperialist domination of Africa, Central and South America, and the Middle and Far East. The very immediacy and specificity of the historical context reveal, however, the broader role to be played by resistance literature in particular, but more generally too by what has come to be referred to as "Third World literature." The French anthropologist of North Africa, Jacques Berque, for example, has maintained that contemporary history will of necessity unfold as the history of decolonization.[3] Eric Wolf, the historian of peasant wars, has in turn claimed as the basis of his historiography that European history must be rewritten to include the "people without history." In the introduction to *Europe and the People without History*, Wolf reminds the Western student of history that "neither ancient Greece, Rome, Christian Europe, the Renaissance, the Enlightenment, the industrial revolution, democracy, nor even the United States was ever a thing propelled toward its unfolding goal by some immanent driving spring, but rather a temporally and spatially changing and changeable set of relationships, or relationships among sets of relationships."[4] Within the discipline of literature, current political movements and trends, especially in the "Third World," are likewise imposing a review of what is understood by "literature" and "literary studies."

The term "Third World," however, has become a problematic one and seems now to possess more rhetorical power than analytic precision. As Eric Wolf goes on in his introduction to point out:

> It becomes easy to sort the world into differently colored [billiard] balls, to declare that "East is East, and West is West, and never the twain shall meet." In this way a quintessential West

> is counterposed to an equally quintessential East, where life was cheap and slavish multitudes groveled under a variety of despotisms. Later, as peoples in other climes began to assert their political and economic independence from both West and East, we assigned these new applicants for historical status to a Third World of underdevelopment – a residual category of conceptual billiard balls – as contrasted with the developed West and the developing East. Inevitably, perhaps, these reified categories became intellectual instruments in the prosecution of the Cold War. (EPH, 6–7)

The history of the Third World has thus been variously defined. For some historians, that history is coincident with the history of colonialism. According to L. S. Stavrianos, in *Global Rift*, for example, it began with the emergence of commercial capitalism between 1400 and 1770. Third World historiography remains nonetheless implicated in the conditions which produce it and Peter Worsley has pointed to some of the discrepancies which these differing conditions have engendered:

> The colonial relationship was a relationship between societies, each of which had its own distinctive social institutions and its own internal social differences, its own culture and subcultures. Despite the political power of the conqueror, each colony was the product of a dialectic, a synthesis, not just a simple imposition, in which the social institutions and cultural values of the conquered was one of the terms of the dialectic. Histories of colonialism written by imperialists ignore one of these terms: history is the story of what the White man did. Nationalist historiography has developed a contrary myth: a legend of "national" resistance which omits the uncomfortable fact of collaboration.[5]

The term "Third World" was itself first used in August 1952 when Alfred Sauvy, a French demographer, wrote in *France Observateur*:

> We speak all too willingly of two worlds and their possible wars, their co-existence, etc., often forgetting that there exists a

> third, more important, world, one which, in terms of chronology, comes first . . . this Third World, ignored, scorned, exploited, as was the Third Estate, also wants to say something.

Such an appeal on the part of the French social scientist, which called attention to the distorted access to power of various geopolitical regions of the globe, was challenged two decades later by Régis Debray, the Frenchman who fought with Che Guevara in the independence struggles of Cuba and South America. For Debray, writing in *Critique des armes*, this "questionable concept of 'third world'" was a "shapeless sack into which one could simply dump peoples, classes, races, civilizations and continents so that they might more easily disappear."[6] The term found perhaps its most vital and coherent political expression in 1955 at the Bandung Conference, under the sponsorship of India's Prime Minister Nehru, which organized into a collective political body the "non-aligned nations" of the world.

With the Bandung conference as its point of reference, the same article in *Le Monde diplomatique* which cites Sauvy and Debray goes on to articulate the history of the Third World in three major phases. The first period, which marks the beginnings of struggle, extends from the Vietnamese victory against the French in 1954 to Algerian independence in 1962 and is punctuated by such events as the 1956 "Suez Canal crisis." The different ways of referring to this incident, which is known in the Arab world as the "tripartite aggression" (of France, Great Britain, and Israel), only emphasize the different and contending versions of history which are at stake. The second period of Third World history then bears witness to the success of a number of national liberation movements, beginning with the Cuban revolution in 1959 and culminating in 1975 with the fall of Saigon. The successes also included the independence of many African nations such as Nigeria (1960), Kenya (1963), Mozambique (1975), Angola (1975), and Guinea-Bissau (1974). In the meantime, however, the Bay of Pigs invasion occurred in 1961 and the June War was fought between Israel and Egypt/Jordan in 1967, the same year that Che Guevara was captured and killed in the mountains of Bolivia. The Arab–Israeli October War of 1973 and the fall of Beirut to Israeli forces in 1982 frame the third period, which

testifies to the effects on the Third World of the international political scene. During this period, for example, PLO chairman Yasser Arafat visited the United Nations in 1974, Egyptian president Anwar Sadat made his separate peace with Israel at Camp David in 1979, and, again in 1979, the Soviet Union invaded Afghanistan. It is within this historical context and its contemporary consequences that Samir Amin, the Egyptian economist, was led to ask: "Is the Third World a reality or is it breaking up?"[7]

The historical struggle against colonialism and imperialism of such resistance movements as the PLO (Palestine), the FLN (Algeria), the FLN (Vietnam), Mau Mau (Kenya), FRELIMO (Mozambique), PAIGC (Guinea-Bissau), MPLA (Angola), BPLF (Baluchistan), the ANC (South Africa), FREITLIN (East Timor), the FMLN (El Salvador), or the Sandinista FSLN (Nicaragua), and whether successful in their struggle as yet or not, is waged at the same time as a struggle over the historical and cultural record. One of the first targets, for example, of the Israeli Defense Forces when they entered the Lebanese capital of Beirut in the fall of 1982 was the PLO Research Center and its archives containing the documentary and cultural history of the Palestinian people. Similarly the United States police squadron which in August 1985 arrested in San Juan, Puerto Rico, eleven Puerto Rican *independentistas* on charges of bank robbery and violation of interstate commerce laws also entered the offices of the journal *Pensamiento crítico* where they confiscated the journal's archival resources as well as its copier and typewriter.

The struggle over the historical record is seen from all sides as no less crucial than the armed struggle. Even in the pages of the *Times Literary Supplement*, the cultural terrain is disputed. The reviewer Roland Oliver, for example, began his critique of the recently published seventh volume of the UNESCO-sponsored *General History of Africa*, which deals with "Africa under colonial domination," by asking, "Are they treating our memory better or worse than we treat that of the Romans?" The fault the critic finds with the work, which is edited by A. Adu Boahen and consists of thirty articles, twenty-one of which are written by African writers, is that:

> The very design of this volume reveals a view of the colonial period which could hardly have emanated from anywhere

> outside Africa. For example, one whole third of it is devoted to the theme of resistance to colonial occupation, and, whether intentionally or not, the impression is created that hardly anything else happened in Africa between 1880 and 1914.[8]

Okonkwo too, who was allotted only a paragraph in the district commissioner's study *The Pacification of the Primitive Tribes of the Lower Niger*, figured quite differently in Achebe's novel *Things Fall Apart*.

Whereas Kanafani had differentiated between literature written under occupation and exile literature, Ngugi wa Thiong'o, the Kenyan writer and academic who was much influenced by the Mau Mau movement and who is now in exile in London, proposed a different set of categories. Ngugi (1981) maintained, in an article entitled "Literature in schools," that "in literature there have been two opposing aesthetics: the aesthetic of oppression and exploitation and of acquiescence with imperialism; and that of human struggle for total liberation."[9] Ngugi's article was written as part of a violent debate in Kenya's press which followed the publication of a report by the working committee which had been appointed in 1973 to re-examine the literature syllabus in Kenyan schools. His concern with that syllabus parallels Roland Oliver's own preoccupation with the pedagogical implications of the new *General History of Africa*. For the latter:

> Much more interesting in the long run is what African historians, mostly trained in the Western tradition of historical scholarship, are telling the present generation of African schoolteachers, and, through them, the next generation of African politicians and military men, about the history of the colonial period.

It is at this point that Oliver asks, "Are they treating our memory better or worse than we treat that of the Romans?"

Ngugi's discussion in 1976 focused on the question of the "literary diet now being ladled out to our children," and addressed four main issues confronting the Kenyan educational system. Ngugi designates these issues as: 1) the relevance and adequacy

of the present educational system; 2) the decision-making personnel; 3) the teaching staff and 4) approaches to literature. Despite the article's immediate and direct relevance to the political and cultural situation in contemporary post-colonial Kenya, the position which it articulates poses important questions for literary criticism in the West, both as it has been traditionally, or canonically, practiced and in terms of current theoretical and iconoclastic trends. Ngugi's division of literature into two kinds, that of oppression and that of the struggle for liberation, contests the ascendancy of sets of analytic categories and formal conventions, whether generic, such as novel, sonnet, tragedy, etc.; national–linguistic as in French, German, or English literature; literary–historical; or even so simple a distinction as that which is still conventionally maintained between fiction and non-fiction. These conventions, which have been elaborated by Western critics of literature, have often also been adopted by literati and local pedagogues in cultures which have not themselves been part of Western literature and its idiosyncratic development. The Kenyan writer, in this essay, proposes instead a different organization of literary categories, one which is "participatory" in the historical processes of hegemony and resistance to domination, rather than formal or analytic.

Already in the 1920s the Peruvian critic José Carlos Mariátegui had insisted on the need for a different historical periodization of the literature of Peru from that generally formulated to account for the development of the European literary tradition. In his essay "Literature on trial" in which he examines the political responsibility of the Peruvian writer, Mariátegui claims that, "because of the special character of Peruvian literature, it cannot be studied within the framework of classicism, romanticism or modernism; nor of ancient, medieval and modern; nor of popular and literary poetry, etc." That "special character" of Peruvian literature which Mariátegui points to, its development under colonial auspices, produces different literary historical criteria. The writer goes on:

> A literary, not sociological, theory divides the literature of a country into three periods: colonial, cosmopolitan and national. In the first period, the country, in a literary sense, is a colony

> dependent on the metropolis. In the second period, it simultaneously assimilates the elements of various foreign literatures. In the third period, it shapes and expresses its own personality and feelings.[10]

These various challenges, each in its own way specific to the particular needs of a given historical moment, by Kanafani, Ngugi, and Mariátegui, suggest nonetheless the general parameters of a collective opposition and concerted resistance to the programmatic cultural imperialism which accompanied western economic, military, and political domination of the Third World. An extreme, even anarchic, expression of this movement which Armand Mattelart has referred to as "national struggles of cultural liberation"[11] is proffered by the Nigerian writer, dramatist and cultural critic Wole Soyinka in his book *Myth, Literature and the African World*, when he writes, perhaps critically, that "the [African] writer is far more preoccupied with visionary projections of society than with speculative projections of the nature of literature or of any other medium of expression."[12] Soyinka's disavowal notwithstanding, it remains the case that the writers and critics writing within the context of organized resistance movements comprehend the role of culture and cultural resistance as part of the larger struggle for liberation.

Amilcar Cabral, the leader of the Guinea-Bissau liberation movement and a major theoretician of African resistance and liberation struggles, claimed in a speech delivered in 1970 in honor of the assassinated FRELIMO leader, Eduardo Mondlane, that "the armed struggle for liberation, in the concrete conditions of life of African peoples, confronted with the imperialist challenge, is an act of insemination upon history – the major expression of our culture and of our African essence."[13] Ghassan Kanafani too, in his second study of the literature of occupied Palestine, which was written two years after his preliminary investigation, and which took advantage of the newly opened borders between Israel and the occupied West Bank, asserts the integral relationship between armed resistance and resistance literature. Like Cabral, who insisted that "culture plunges its roots into the physical reality of the environmental humus in which it develops," (RS, 42) Kanafani too claimed that "armed

resistance is not just the husk, but the very fruit of cultivation forcing its roots deep into the land." Both thinkers of the resistance also locate the historical specificity of the resistance movement within the larger collective struggle throughout the world. Kanafani thus goes on to assert the significance of the particular forms of cultural resistance in determining the general strategies of the resistance organization: "If resistance springs from the barrel of a gun, the gun itself issues from the desire for liberation and that desire for liberation is nothing but the natural, logical and necessary product of resistance in its broadest sense: as refusal and as a firm grasp of roots and situations." For Kanafani, the "extreme importance of the cultural form of resistance is no less valuable than armed resistance itself."[14]

Both Kanafani and Cabral were assassinated by the representatives of the imperialism they were struggling against. Their deaths signal the importance attached even by the enemy to the efficacy of cultural resistance. Kanafani's obituary in the *Daily Star*, a Beirut English-language newspaper, described him as the "commando who never fired a gun" and went on to say that "his weapon was a ballpoint pen and his arena newspaper pages. And he hurt the enemy more than a column of commandos."[15] Two years before he himself was assassinated, Cabral had concluded his speech in honor of Mondlane with the words:

> One might say that Eduardo Mondlane was *savagely* assassinated because he was capable of identifying with the culture of his people, with their deepest aspirations, through and against all attempts or temptations for the alienation of his personality as an African and a Mozambican. Because he had forged a new culture in the struggle, he fell as a combatant.[16]

For both Cabral and Kanafani the resistance movement and the armed struggle for national liberation were to accomplish the political and economic liberation of the people from the thrall of imperialism. But they were also expected to bring about, in that process, a revolutionary transformation of existing social structures. Whether in liberating women from traditional tasks, organizing democratic processes of decision-making and counsel, building schools or training cadres of peasants and workers, the

"armed liberation struggle," as Cabral says, "is not only a product of culture, but a *determinant of culture.*" (RS, 55)

Resistance literature and western criticism

Hugo Blanco was a prominent organizer among the Quechua Indians and peasants of Peru. His account of the mobilization of the peasants, *Land or Death: the Peasant Struggle in Peru*, written while he was serving a 25-year prison sentence for his activities with the Indians, describes at one point the role of the press and propaganda in political work. According to Blanco, "Much can be accomplished in press and propaganda work even in such a predominantly illiterate milieu as the peasant movement."[17] The press and propaganda can themselves become a means in the hands of the resistance which will wrest back from the repressive authorities the control over cultural production. Blanco formulates this "expropriation" in terms of the Peruvian peasants' own traditional relationship to scriptural authority:

> It is necessary to understand that for centuries the oppressors of the peasants made them regard paper as a god. Paper became a fetish: Arrest orders are paper. By means of papers they crush the Indian in the courts. The peasant sees papers in the offices of the governor, the parish priest, the judge, the notary – wherever there is power; the landowner, too, keeps accounts on paper. All the reckonings you have made, all your logical arguments, they refute by showing you a paper; the paper supersedes logic, it defeats it.
>
> There is a famous saying: *Qelqan riman* (What is written is what is heard). We fight this fetishism to the death. And one of the ways to fight it is precisely to show the peasant that, just as the enemy has *his* papers, so we have *our* papers. To the paper that contradicts the reason and logic of the peasant, we counterpose the paper that bears that reason and logic.
>
> This by itself is already a marvel for the illiterate peasant. The existence of papers that speak in his behalf, that speak his truth, is already the beginning of his triumph. He views them with respect and affection. (LD, 84–5)

The peasants, Blanco goes on to report, then used these leaflets in the traditional way to paper the walls of their homes, only this time making them available for readings by children and visitors with the necessary literacy skills. Such a strategic evaluation as Blanco's of the role of press and propaganda is conditioned in his case by his commitment to the "Transitional Program" of Trotskyism, whereby the people are educated by and in the process of their actions. The vital importance of literacy and education, however, as part of the political agenda of the resistance organization is everywhere evident, from the "self-help" schools and work brigades of Serowe studied by Bessie Head in the Botswanan village where she lived[18] to the massive literacy campaign undertaken by the Sandinista government of Nicaragua during the first year of its rule.

In his preface to *Crisis in the Philippines*, E. San Juan insists on the urgency of such cultural activity and its immediate relevance to the political struggle in the Third World theater when he points out "the integral, organic rootedness of Third World activists/thinkers in the political–cultural struggles in their milieu: the heterogeneous, decentered structure of Third World formations."[19] Terry Eagleton, by contrast, writing for a First World audience, concluded his study, *Literary Theory: an Introduction*, with a reminder to "those who work in the cultural practices [that they] are unlikely to mistake their activity as utterly central." He does, however, distinguish four areas of endeavor where such cultural practices do become "newly relevant," singling out for this relevance working-class writing, the "culture industry," the women's movement, and "those nations struggling for their independence from imperialism."[20]

In a similar gesture, Frederic Jameson turns at the end of his recent essay on "Postmodernism, or the cultural logic of late capitalism" to an appeal for a new "pedagogical political culture." Jameson defines this culture as an "aesthetic of cognitive mapping . . . which seeks to endow the individual subject with some new heightened sense of its place in the global system."[21] No less than the multinational corporations which Jameson sees as the characteristic feature of what he designates as the "postmodern" period or the age of "late capitalism," however, the cultural institutions and academies of higher learning which

define and process information and cultural production participate not only in the dissemination of specific and hegemonic forms of social organization but also in determining the content of cultural commodities. As Armand Mattelart points out in his study *Transnationals and the Third World: the Struggle for Culture*, it is the university scholars and academicians who serve as market researchers, whether in matters of birth control or with regard to "advanced systems for communications and education in national development,"[22] for transnational firms.

Not just anthropologists, economists, and political scientists, but students of literature too, with their theories of discourse, rhetoric, and textual criticism, provide the necessary information and tools of analysis for the propagation of cultural and even military domination. One of the appendices, for example, to the CIA *Manual on Psychological Operations in Guerrilla Warfare* contains a program for political oratory which might well have its place in a college composition or rhetoric course. Certainly the section on figures of speech provides useful and practical definitions of such rhetorical devices as prolepsis, concession, anaphora, antithesis, amplification, commination, etc. For such reasons, "one must start," according to Mattelart, "by questioning the conceptual apparatus allowing transnational firms to reproduce the conditions of their survival and legitimacy and to judge or even criticize their actions themselves in order to put right mistakes and excesses without questioning an instant their own nature and function." (TTW, 2)

It has become again necessary to challenge the presuppositions and premises of the academic enterprise and the activities which it enjoins and which are used to sustain an internationalization of the issues of development according to western-specific models or patterns. The challenge is raised already in those areas, geographical and ideological, where there is at work what Gramsci termed a "counter-hegemonic ideological production." Literature and literary studies themselves, as part of the academic enterprise, are being contested by the cultural and ideological expressions of resistance, armed struggle, liberation, and social revolution in those geopolitical regions referred to as the "Third World."

Although prominent radical critics such as Eagleton and Jameson do gesture significantly towards the political relevance

and even urgency of new forms and strategies of cultural resistance, these forms themselves have yet to alter in any manifest way the organization and discipline of literary studies in western institutions. In a critical response to Jameson's article on "postmodernism," the labor historian Mike Davis pointed to the failure of Jameson's analysis to acknowledge the political alignments which are really at stake in the postmodern manipulation of architectural space. Davis's article, "Urban renaissance and the spirit of postmodernism," insists not on the fragmentation of the individual's relation to his or her psychic and social living space as characteristic of the postmodern experience but on the "decisive role of urban counter-insurgency in defining the essential terms of the contemporary built environment."[23] He concludes his critique with the claim that it is a "Haussmannian logic of social control" which is the "real *Zeitgeist* of postmodernism." According to Davis, "these current designs for fortified skyscrapers indicate a vogue for battlements not seen since the great armoury boom that followed the Labour Rebellion of 1877. In so doing, they also signal the coercive intent of postmodernist architecture in its ambition, not to hegemonize the city in the fashion of the great modernist buildings, but rather to polarize it into radically antagonistic spaces." (URSP, 113)

On the periphery of these fantastic architectural structures of United States capitalism, surrounding them, if not actually laying siege to them, is a "Third World city" of Hispanics, Asians, blacks, and other minority populations and it is against them that these edifices have been constructed. What is seen by Jameson as a radical transformation of cultural form is interpreted differently by Davis as a calculated retrenchment of forces in capitalist design. In much the same way, the title to the popular rock song of 1985, "We are the world," produced in order to raise famine relief funds for Ethiopia, might be reread as an emblematic statement of United States imperialism in the last decades: "We are the world."

The political function of the poet, more so even than that of the literary critic, has been much contested amongst writers. The longstanding tradition of that debate, one which is not unique to western literary schools of thought, does find there a particularly coherent historical formulation, one which is expressed in

Stendhal's statement that "Politics in a work of literature is like a pistol shot in the middle of a concert, something loud and vulgar and yet a thing to which it is not possible to refuse one's attention."[24] Such debates as practiced in Western academies resonate too amongst the strategists of cultural resistance in the national liberation movements. To his compatriots and colleagues, for example, who advocated aesthetic, if not objective, criteria, transcending historical circumstance, in the study of literary works, the Puerto Rican critic Maldonado Denis answers: "In my view the Puerto Rican intellectual must take as departure point for any analysis of our society the most radical and profound fact about here-and-now Puerto Rico: its character as colony of the United States." (IR, 291)

This controversial insistence on the "here-and-now" of historical reality and its conditions of possibility underwrites much of the project of resistance literature and the internal debate which surrounds that literature. It likewise arouses the objections of "First World" critics generally to the literature of partisanship. Ghassan Kanafani, for example, who worked in the last years of his life as a journalist and then as editor of *al-Hadaf* (*The Aim*), the weekly newspaper of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP), was criticized and taken to task by a younger writer Fadl al-Naqib for what was seen as Kanafani's excessive attention to the immediate exigencies and pressing concerns of the contemporary political situation. Like Proust's Marcel, the young writer aspired to the rewards of posterity and posthumous recognition and acclaim, a "distant future wrapped in dreams." Kanafani was rebuked by the acolyte for composing for tomorrow's editorial column.[25] It is to this same critical reluctance, such as that exhibited in Rene Wellek and Austin Warren's now classic *Theory of Literature*, to associate literature "with manufactures made with a narrow aim at the market" or the refusal to take it as a "document or case history, as – what for its own purposes of illusion it sometimes professes to be – a confession, a true story, a history of a life and its times,"[26] that the critic and novelist Ngugi objects in his essay on "Writers in politics." "Haven't we heard," he writes, "critics who demand of African writers that they stop writing about colonialism, race, colour, exploitation, and simply write about human beings? Such an attitude to society is often the

basis of some European writers' mania for man without history – solitary and free – with unexplainable despair and anguish and death as the ultimate truth about the human condition."[27]

This demand on the part of critics and readers, against historical necessity, and through an appeal to universality, posterity and the human condition, is among those "strategies of containment" that Jameson examined in his work *The Political Unconscious*, "the 'local' ways in which [interpretive codes] construct their objects of study and . . . project the illusion that their readings are somehow complete and self-sufficient."[28] Such a "strategy of containment" is evident, for example, in Sartre's dehistoricizing and existentializing reading of Camus's novel about settler-colonialism. Speaking of the novel when it was first published in Paris in 1942 after the novelist had left Algeria, Sartre sees in it only "chance, death, the irreducible pluralism of life and truth, the unintelligibility of the real – all these are the extremes of the absurd."[29] No less "local" is the introduction to E. M. Forster's work provided by Frank Kermode and John Hollander in their anthology of modern British literature where *A Passage to India* is described: "While ostensibly about the relations of the British with the native populations of India, it is fundamentally a highly organized work of art, a limited world commenting on the tragedies and mitigations of the larger one."[30] Forster and Camus, no less than the Indians and the Algerians (represented by Aziz and the unnamed Arab in their novels), are thus denied by the literary critics a historical role of anything but peripheral consequence.

Masao Miyoshi, in his reading of twentieth century Japanese novels, "Against the native grain," warned against the dangers of either "domestication" or "neutralization" in the study in the West of non-western literary works. Whereas the danger of "domestication" is that it renders all too familiar, and thus subjugates through assimilation, the challenge posed by the unfamiliar, the alternative of "neutralization," which categorically rejects and isolates the unfamiliar as finally irrelevant, is no less a threat.[31] These alternatives, promulgated by a hegemonic cultural imperative and which Cabral had earlier rendered as "assimilation" and "apartheid," (RS, 40) also function in the conflicting theoretical efforts to comprehend the political and ideological

consequences of popular, but organized, resistance movements. As John Walton indicates in *Reluctant Rebels*, his study of three such movements, the Huk rebellion in the Philippines, La Violencia in Colombia, and Kenya's Mau Mau movement, "Contemporary revolutionary activities that resonate with the popular imagination seem to escape our theoretical grasp, to become lost somewhere between scholarly treatment of great transformations such as the French Revolution and historically denatured instances of riot and coup."[32]

The question of national culture

According to Frantz Fanon, in his essay "On national culture" in *The Wretched of the Earth*:

> Colonialism is not satisfied merely with holding a people in its grip and emptying the native's head of all form and content. By a kind of perverted logic, it turns to the past of the oppressed people, and distorts, disfigures and destroys it. This work of devaluing pre-colonial history takes on a dialectical significance today.[33]

For the Arab writer in general, and for the Palestinian writer in particular, a radical disruption occurred in 1948 when the state of Israel was created. The year has been described in Arab historiography as the year of the "disaster" (*nakbah*) whose consequences for Arab cultural production are described by Edward Said in his introduction to Halim Barakat's novel of the 1967 war, *Days of Dust*:

> Not only did 1948 put forth unprecedented challenges to a collectivity already undergoing the political evolution of several European centuries compressed into a few decades: this after all was mainly a difference of detail between the Arab East and all other Third World countries, since the end of colonialism meant the beginning and the travail of uncertain national selfhood. But 1948 put forward a monumental enigma, an existential mutation for which Arab history was unprepared.[34]

The solutions of the past, of identity and tradition, no longer sufficed to provide a sense of continuous history and active agency in the unfolding of that history.

As with African experimentations with the philosophies of Negritude and political programs of pan-Africanism, even the promise contained in the efforts to evolve an effective ideology of pan-Arabism collided eventually with conflicting spheres of regional and personal interest. Certainly any attempt to participate in the "universal" culture of the colonizer and conqueror was predetermined for failure, but so too was the effort criticized by Fanon to fashion a "national culture" according to European designs:

> There was therefore at the bottom of this decision the anxiety to be present at the universal trysting place fully armed, with a culture springing from the very heart of the African continent. Now, this [Universal Cultural] Society will very quickly show its inability to shoulder these different tasks, and will limit itself to exhibitionist demonstrations, while the habitual behaviour of the members of this Society will be confined to showing Europeans that such a thing as African culture exists, and opposing their ideas to those of ostentatious and narcissistic Europeans. (WE, 173)

The relationship to the inherited past and its cultural legacy has been rendered problematic by the violent interference of colonial and imperial history. Just as Fanon warns against the fetishization of traditional culture which transforms that culture into museum pieces and archaeological artefacts, (WE, 178) Cabral too admonishes against too literal an interpretation of the ideal of a "return to the source."

That the debate over the elaboration of a national culture remains urgent within the context of the continuing cultural domination by the West is evidenced, for example, in the recent creation in Egypt, following the Camp David Accords and the official policy of a "normalization of relations" between Egypt and Israel, of an oppositional "Committee in the Defense of National Culture." In the pages of its journal, *al-Muwājahah*, are included translations of Fanon, Cabral and Gramsci as well as

documentation of the current "cultural invasion" in its new form. Egyptian writers, intellectuals, artists, and university professors are opposing an institutionalized program which demands their public participation in the exchange of visits between university delegations from the two countries, joint publishing ventures, the establishment of Israeli research institutes in Egypt and similar gestures betokening the commitment of Egyptian and Israeli scholars to a "common cause." Under Anwar Sadat those intellectuals who refused to cooperate were liable to arrest, demotion, or dismissal from their positions.

The concept of national culture is being redefined continuously in the course of these political confrontations. In this debate over the definition and role of national culture, both in the liberation struggle of colonized countries and later in their participation in global politics after independence, it is necessary to transform the dichotomous alternatives of what Mattelart has referred to as either a "scorched earth politics" or a "rhetoric of nostalgia." (CCD, 48) The struggle is one which engages the traditional past as well as the present circumstances of western hegemony in order to determine future coordinates of social and political formations and strategic alliances. From British imperialism's selective educational system in India and the French colonial obliteration of Arab-language schools in North Africa, to the world-wide distribution, through the channels of multinational corporations, of *Sesame Street* and *Dallas*, the issue of cultural imperialism and resistance to it has remained an increasingly critical part of geo-political strategy and confrontation. Ariel Dorfman reminded the reader in his study of colonizing myths entitled *The Empire's Old Clothes*, or "What the Lone Ranger, Babar, and other innocent heroes do to our minds," that "There may be no better way for a country to know itself than to examine the myths and popular symbols that it exports to its economic and military dominions."[35]

Beyond even the myths, however, is the hegemonic control of distribution networks and chains. At the 1985 meeting in Geneva, for example, of the World Administrative Radio Conference on the Use of Geostationary Satellite Orbits, as the *New York Times* put it, "The competition for the available positions and frequencies in space . . . caused resentment on earth, mainly between the industrialized countries and the third world." The

article, "Third world seeks its place in space," went on to describe the sources of that resentment:

> Although some developing countries have satellites, many in the third world fear that, by the time they have the resources to launch one, the geostationary orbit, where a satellite travels at the same rotational speed as the earth and is a fixed target for radio signals, will be crowded.[36]

The theoretical and practical debate over national culture, its production and distribution, has not necessarily been superseded by these technological developments in the field of communications, but it has acquired a new dimension and a new urgency. For Dorfman what is called for is "the elaboration which would reject authoritarian and competitive models and provoke doubts, questions, dialogue, real participation, and, eventually, a breakthrough in popular art." (EOC, 7)

"Les Mots canins"

In his contribution, entitled "Les Mots canins," to the conference on bilingualism, held in Rabat in 1981, the Moroccan writer Abdelfattah Kilito retold a fable from the *Book of the Animals* by the ninth century Arab writer al-Jahiz. Kilito begins his fable-telling with a riddle: What did the Arab of ancient times do when he became lost at night and unable to find his way?[37] The answer given is that the lost Arab would begin to bark like a dog, *istanabaha*. The idea, according to the writer, is that, in barking like a dog, the wanderer in the desert would provoke the barking of any other dogs in the area, dogs which would be collected around a campsite or human settlement toward which the human animal might then orient his steps. Kilito comments, of course, on the paradox that it is only by way of a passage through bestiality that the stranger can find his way to a return to human contact, but he goes on to examine the various forms that such a return might take. In addition to the possibility of a reunion of the lost traveler with his own kind, it could also happen that the campsite dogs who respond to his imitation barking do so because they guard the fires of a tribe that is inimical to strangers and have been

trained to bark in order to ward off alien encroachments. Or, again, it might transpire that the dogs of a nearby campsite do not bark at all in response to the wanderer's canine appeal, this time because they belong to a most hospitable people who have taught their animals not to bark so as not to frighten off strangers seeking welcome and refuge at their fires.

Al-Jahiz's fable, in its retelling by Abdelfattah Kilito, raises allegorically a number of questions relevant to resistance literature: access to history for those peoples who have been historically denied an active role in the arena of world politics; the problem of contested terrain, whether cultural, geographical, or political; and the social and political transformation from a genealogy of "filiation" based on ties of kinship, ethnicity, race, or religion to an "affiliative" secular order.[38] Such an agenda must attempt a reconstruction of the history of the relations of power between those regions or arenas, which have been variously designated as First and Third Worlds, metropolis and periphery, etc., in such a way as to redress, on the cultural as well as on the political and economic levels, the exploitative and repressive nature of those relations.

France, for example, occupied North Africa for more than 130 years, from its first military incursions in 1830 to Algerian independence following a protracted and bloody struggle for national independence in 1962. An important consequence of French settler-colonialism in Algeria was, however, its effective suppression of an indigenous Arabic literary production through its replacement of Arab-language schools with the French educational system and its selective training of what were deemed the "most promising" young North Africans.

> French was the language of command, of management, and of theoretical knowledge, and it also relegated Arabic to the language of the dominated, of those at the bottom of the ladder. . . . The law encouraged this domination, too, by declaring Arabic foreign to Algeria in 1923; educationalists also helped by claiming that the Latin alphabet was better suited to modern needs than the Arabic one.[39]

When Algeria did finally achieve independence in 1962, a critical part of its national program was thus a process of "Arabization"

in all spheres of public and institutional activity. Nonetheless, many of North Africa's most prominent writers and intellectuals, such as Khatibi and Kilito, continue to produce their works in French, whether because French is the language in which they were educated, or because, as in the case of the Moroccan writer Mohamed Choukri, their books are banned in Arabic. Choukri's autobiography, *Le Pain nu*, or *Al-Khubz al-hāfī* as it was originally entitled, appeared in Tahar Ben Jelloun's French translation in Paris before the author could find a publisher for the Arabic original.[40] For Khatibi, however, there is a certain calculated irony in the francophony of North African writers.

> Irony might not only have been a kind of displaced revenge on the part of the oppressed colonized seduced by the west, but would have also allowed the francophone North African writer to take his own distance on the language by inverting it, destroying it and presenting new structures to the point where the French reader would feel a stranger in his own language.[41]

In the case of Mohamed Choukri, the irony is complicated still again when the French translation of his autobiography subverts the post-colonial authoritarian manipulation by the Moroccan censor of an Arabic "national culture" in North Africa. In 1984 Mohamed Choukri's books were again banned in his native Morocco.

In his essay "Democracy and modern despotism," written in 1978, the Lebanese critic and novelist Elias Khouri criticizes the tendency of the Arab bourgeoisie and bureaucratic élite to "transform the people into folklore and tourism."[42] That critique finds a further development in Khouri's later article, "'Arabization' and intimidation," which appeared as part of the writer's series published over almost two years, from January 1983 to November 1984, in the Lebanese newspaper *al-Safīr*. The series, entitled *Time of Occupation* (*Zaman al-ihtilāl*)[43] was begun in response to the Israeli occupation of Lebanon following their invasion in June 1982 and the departure of the PLO fedayeen from Beirut in September of that year. "'Arabization' and intimidation" appeared in May 1983, at a moment when the Phalange government's censorship of literary and intellectual production in Lebanon was

especially intense in the wake of the controversial agreement negotiated by US Secretary of State George Shultz between Israel and the Christian Lebanese government. Because of this highly contested treaty arrangement (which eventually collapsed), the Lebanese regime of Amin Gemayel was particularly interested in maintaining the political and, more importantly perhaps, financial support of its "sister Arab states."

Although the Christian population in Lebanon had historically insisted on their genealogy as "Phoenician" rather than "Arab," "Arabization" in the cultural sphere now became part of the government program. This "Arabization" was, however, according to Khouri, construed in such a way as to satisfy the more conservative Arab oil-regimes. Whereas Beirut had once served as the center for the dissemination of radical Arab thought, what was now to be exported was the traditional Arab cultural heritage, the classical *turāth*, "leather-bound books with their titles embossed in gilt." (TO, 69) In the name of "Arabization," furthermore, there began what Khouri describes as a "purification of the Lebanese University of those professors who had imported ideas. Although 'we,'" as the critic writes with a certain irony, "are capable of economic openness and readiness to import commodities even from New Zealand in order to re-export them to our sister states, we are not yet ready to receive western-imported ideas. Ideas must be 100% local manufacture." (TO, 68) Khouri ends his article of 27 May 1983 by indicating that, in the face of such pressures from within and without, only two choices are available: the first, "isolationism," he rejects despite its apparent historical ascendancy of the moment. The second option, he insists, is the only lasting one, even given the difficulties it entails, the option of resistance. The word for resistance used here, *mu'āradah*, translates the term *muqāwamah* conventionally used in Arabic to suggest popular, organized resistance to colonial occupation or imperialist oppression and gives a literary-critical implication to the idea of resistance. *Mu'āradah*, while it does have the literal meaning of confrontation, opposition, or resistance, is also the designation given to a classical Arabic literary form, according to which one person will write a poem and another will retaliate by writing along the same lines, but reversing the meaning. This translation into Arabic of the Arabic word

for resistance also suggests a larger and collective political agenda to the linguistic task of the literary translator.

Le Thé au harem d'Archi Ahmed might be considered as an example of such a contestatory practice, of *mu'āradah*, a literary, historical, and political challenge to the cultural ascendancy of western letters and the persistent economic and cultural hegemony of France over her former North African colonies. When *Le Thé au harem d'Archi Ahmed*[44] by the young Algerian novelist Mehdi Charef appeared in Paris in 1983 it provoked significant critical attention. A year later it was made into a film, with the slightly altered title *Le Thé au harem d'Archimède*, directed by the writer and produced by Costa Gavras. Charef's novel represents an important intervention into the urgent political debate, often erupting in violence, which is taking place in contemporary French society. Identified variously as the Le Pen phenomenon, the neo-conservative politics of the National Front party or simply as "Français/immigrés,"[45] the controversial question of France's relationship to its immigrant population is manifest in political discussion, personal vendettas, and public graffiti.

Le Thé au harem tells the story of the friendship between Pat, a young Frenchman, and Madjid, an Algerian of the "nouvelle génération," both members of an informal gang of youths living in one of the *HLMs* (*habitations loyer modere*) of the Parisian *banlieues*. The novel sees the two adolescents through various escapades of petty theft, vandalism, sex, drugs, and family problems, until finally Madjid is apprehended by the police while his cohorts escape. It concludes with Pat voluntarily joining his friend in the police van, telling the officers, "J'étais avec lui." (TH, 183) Pat's statement is a variation on still another description of the racial issue in France today. "Ne touche pas à mon pôte" (Hands off my pal) is the rallying slogan of a group of young people who have organized themselves against the current virulent antagonism directed against France's immigrant, and especially Arab, population.

Critics of contemporary French politics have suggested that the aggressive tension between France and the North African immigrants living and working in that country is in many ways a historical continuation of France's Algerian war and point to such evidence as the fact that it is North African Arabs who have been

singled out amongst the immigrant population in France for this negative attention as well as to the coincidence of electoral support for the National Front in those areas with a large concentration of *pieds noirs*.[46] *Le Thé au harem*, whose title comes from the miscomprehension by one of the young Algerians of the school teacher's reference to "le théorème d'Archimède," can likewise be located in the literary history of the French colonization of North Africa, a history in which Camus's *L'Étranger* occupies a crucial position.

Camus wrote *L'Étranger* in Algeria in 1939 but published it only in 1942 in Paris. Unlike Meursault, the novel's protagonist, who refused a position in the metropolis, Camus left Algeria in 1940 to settle in Paris. He returned to Algeria only once, during the Algerian war, for a visit. Camus and *L'Étranger*, however, were well received in France. Sartre, for example, applauded the novel as a masterpiece of the absurd and *L'Étranger* continues to be cited as a classic of existentialism, as if the very limpidity and clarity of its language had spellbound its readers into a blindness to its political context, the Frenchman Raymond's violation of the Arab woman and his friend Meursault's murder of the woman's brother, the unnamed Arab of the novel. Like Mohamed Choukri's autobiography, *L'Étranger* was written in North Africa and published in Paris. But, whereas *Le Pain nu*'s linguistic trajectory opened up a political space of cultural resistance, Camus's novel, dispossessed of its historical background with the "real" rendered "unintelligible," was assimilated into a dehistoricizing project of silence and the absurd.

Algerians, however, for whom Camus had once played an exemplary role, reread his early novel in a more critical light when the writer visited Algeria in the 1950s, only to speak out there against the Algerian struggle for independence and in favor of federation with France. In an open letter to Camus in 1959, Ahmed Taleb, imprisoned at the time in France for activities connected with events in Algeria, wrote:

> Ten years ago we were a handful of young Algerians, seated at our school desks and imbued with your work. And, even if you were not our spiritual inspiration, you at least provided for us a model of writing. . . . Ten years have now elapsed and our

disillusion with you is as great as our hopes once were. Much water has flowed under the bridges. Let us say rather much blood. And how many tears have fallen on the Algerian land that once inspired pages of such beauty from you.[47]

The "model for writing" which Camus had offered has been seriously challenged in the ensuing years by francophone writers of the Maghreb. This linguistic struggle on the cultural terrain is part of the larger history of France's relations with her former North African colonies. Since Algerian independence in 1962, North African immigration to France has followed various cycles, alternately increasing and decreasing according to the pressures of demand as well as to government restrictions or encouragement. In the last several decades, however, many of those workers who had arrived alone and who lived in comparative isolation from French society have been joined by their relatives and have established families of their own in France. Whereas Driss Chraibi's *Les Boucs*, published in 1955, describes the largely male community of North African workers, or Rachid Boudjedra's *Topographie idéale pour une agression caractérisée* (1975) depicts the alienation of a lone Arab toting his worldly belongings through the corridors of the Paris metro, *Le Thé au harem*, whose author is himself a member of the "nouvelle génération," focuses on both the community of adolescents and their familial situations within the French social order.[48]

Le Thé au harem is dedicated to the author's mother: "Pour Mebarka, même si elle ne sait pas lire," and indeed it is Malika, Madjid's mother in the novel, who sustains her own family in addition to providing support and recourse for her neighbors. Whether in intervening to prevent Levesque from brutalizing his wife, or by taking Stéphane, the young son of Josette, while his divorced mother looks for work, Malika contributes to the establishment of communal ties among the inhabitants of the *HLM*, ties which then bind family to family, nationality to nationality. Camus's Meursault was condemned by the French judicial system as much for failing to cry at his mother's funeral as for killing an Arab. Malika, by contrast, augurs, even in her role as mother, the eventual transition to a social order beyond alliances of genealogy, religion, or ethnicity. Madjid, her son, stands

ambiguously within that transition. Although contemptuous of his parents' failure to succeed in French life, he loyally if begrudgingly escorts his father to and from the bistro where he spends his days. The old man, injured in a work-related accident and no longer able to take care of himself, much less his family, symbolizes the impotence of the traditional Arab culture.

The "nouvelle génération," dismissed in popular French rhetoric as "delinquent," has been described by Tahar Ben Jelloun as a "generation destined for cultural orphanhood and ontological fragility." (HF, 116) *Le Thé au harem* dramatizes this precarious "orphanhood" of the young North African in France in its narrative exposé of Madjid's tortured relationship to his Arab family and to the French state. Meursault's murder of the Arab resonates in the violent attacks on North African Arabs in France today. The cultural strategy of *Le Thé au harem d'Archi Ahmed* is to respond by deploying stereotypes in such a way as to undermine their power and by manipulating language, Arabic, argot, and accent, to challenge the sway of classical conventions. Meursault's failure to realize any social or intimate relationships is reworked in the space of Charef's novel where Madjid and Pat speak the language of "Touche pas à mon pôte," the language not of folk culture, nor even of national culture, but a popular language of collective resistance.

The politics of theory

According to Armand Mattelart "The very notion of theory does not escape the contingency of the criteria of relevance which each culture elaborates for it, nor the blind spots which it cultivates." What is crucial, he goes on, is the need to "restore to the cultural interplay of international relations their sociological and historical weight." (CCD, 10–12) Not only for Mattelart, but for the writers of resistance literature and the theorists of the resistance struggle, cultural production plays a decisive and critical role in the activation of what Edward Said has referred to as a "repressed or resistant history."[49] Resistance literature calls attention to itself, and to literature in general, as a political and politicized activity. The literature of resistance sees itself furthermore as immediately and directly involved in a struggle against

ascendant or dominant forms of ideological and cultural production.

One danger, however, no less threatening than the external oppression resulting from policies of imperialism, colonialism and underdevelopment with which the resistance movements contend, is that of a failure to acknowledge the limitations of their own historical role. As Maxime Rodinson warned in his introduction to *People without a Country: the Kurds and Kurdistan*:

> Ideology always goes for the simplest solutions. It does not argue that an oppressed people is to be defended because it is oppressed and to the exact extent to which it is oppressed. On the contrary, the oppressed are sanctified and every aspect of their actions, their culture, their past, present and future behaviour is presented as admirable. Direct or indirect narcissism takes over and the fact that the oppressed are oppressed becomes less important than the admirable way they are themselves. The slightest criticism is seen as criminal sacrilege. In particular, it becomes quite inconceivable that the oppressed might themselves be oppressing others. In an ideological conception, such an admission would imply that the object of admiration was flawed and hence in some sense deserving of past or present oppression.[50]

Resistance organizations and national liberation movements represent a collective and concerted struggle against hegemonic domination and oppression. They are not, however, without their own internal contradictions and debates, as Rodinson points out in signalling the dangers of too monolithic or uncritical an image of such movements and struggles. But it is precisely these self-critical controversies that sustain the movements' active agency in the historical arena of world politics and the struggle for culture which need to be theoretically elaborated and given their full "historical and sociological weight."

While it is urgent that the contemporary resistance movements and national liberation organizations assume their full role in the historical arena of decolonization, it is likewise important that they not be confined by the First World imagination to what Gayatri Spivak has criticized as mere representative allegories of

"correct political practice."[51] The dynamics of debate in which the cultural politics of resistance are engaged challenge both the monolithic historiographical practices of domination and the unidimensional responses of dogma to them.

Amilcar Cabral, wielding the "weapon of theory," wrote that "The national liberation of a people is the regaining of the historical personality of that people, it is their return to history through the destruction of the imperialist domination to which they have been subjected." (US, 130) Whereas the social and the personal have tended to displace the political in western literary and cultural studies, the emphasis in the literature of resistance is on the political as the power to change the world. The theory of resistance literature is in its politics.

ii

Resistance poetry

Poetry
Forgive me for having helped you understand
you're not made of words alone.

Roque Dalton – "El Salvador"

Poetry and resistance

Nicolás Guillén is one of Cuba's most important contemporary poets and director of the National Association of Cuban Writers. As a poet, Guillén, who was born in 1902, participated in the early stages of Cuba's national liberation in this century, then in the Cuban revolution, and continues to act in the councils and government of post-revolutionary Cuba.[1] As a poet too, he has consistently presented his readers with the challenge to assert the viability of their own Cuban and Latin American culture and its historical past. In a poem entitled "Problems of underdevelopment," published in 1972, Guillén wrote:

Monsieur Dupont calls you uneducated
because you don't know which was
the favorite grandchild of Victor Hugo.

Herr Müller has started shouting
because you don't know the day
(the exact one) when Bismarck died.

Your friend Mr. Smith,
English or Yankee, I don't know,
becomes incensed when you write *Shell.*
(It seems that you hold back an "l"
and that besides you pronounce it *chel.*)

O.K. So what?
When it's your turn,
have them say *cacarajicara,*
and where is the Aconcagua
and who was Sucré,
and where on this planet
did Martí die.

And please:
make them always talk to you in Spanish.[2]

The title to Guillén's poem, "Problems of underdevelopment," posits from the outset the necessary connection between politics, economics and culture. The term "underdevelopment," taken from economic theory and the analysis of the historical relation within the world capitalist system between the First and the Third Worlds, invokes the kind of dependency theory proposed by Andre Gunder Frank and other analysts and critics of global dynamics, as well as such studies as that by Walter Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa.*[3] There is furthermore an ideological strategy implicit in the poem itself in the trivializing sequence of representatives of European and United States political culture which the poet invokes: Victor Hugo and the French Revolution, Bismarck and the Berlin Conference of 1885 at which Europe divided Africa amongst its various member nations, and finally Shell and the multinational corporations of US imperialism. Against these figures of hegemonic domination, their symbolic stature diminished here through association with the minutiae of their very human life, Guillén asserts the significance of Latin American history and tradition. *Cacarajicara,* a word evoking African and native Indian sounds, is a Cuban place name now used as an exclamation of approval. (CNG, 178) The Aconcagua, part of the Andes in Argentina, is the highest mountain in the Americas. Antonio José Sucré, the Venezuelan independence

leader who liberated Ecuador and Peru, was assassinated in 1830. And Jose Martí, the nineteenth century Cuban poet and revolutionary, died, after years of exile in the United States and Spanish America, in his native Cuba in 1895. The Cuban Biblioteca Nacional 'Jose Martí', named after him, remains an intellectual center for the poets, writers, and scholars of the Cuban revolution.

Poetry is capable not only of serving as a means for the expression of personal identity or even nationalist sentiment. Poetry, as a part of the cultural institutions and historical existence of a people, is itself an arena of struggle. That struggle, as it is taking place, culturally as well as politically and militarily, today in various of the countries of the Third World, from East Timor in Indonesia to Central American El Salvador, has been dramatically conditioned by the modern history of colonialism and the imperialist project of the west, of Europe and the United States. The current circumstances of the latest phase of decolonization and post-colonialism have in many instances only exacerbated the conditions of struggle and outside domination which have long characterized Third World societies. An important consequence of the First World's military, economic, and political intervention in the Third World, especially in the last 150 years and no less urgently today, has been the catastrophic disruption of Third World peoples' cultural and literary traditions. These traditions constitute in an important way their means of identifying themselves as a group, as a people, no less than as a nation, with a historicity of their own and a claim to an autonomous, self-determining role on the contemporary staging grounds of history.

The poets, like the guerilla leaders of the resistance movements, consider it necessary to wrest that expropriated historicity back, reappropriate it for themselves in order to reconstruct a new world-historical order. As Pablo Neruda, the Chilean poet, writes in his "Epic," commemorating the assassination in 1934 of the Nicaraguan popular leader Augusto Sandino which was carried out by Somozan forces backed by the United States government:

For the sake of peace one sad night
General Sandino took up the invitation
to celebrate his brave resistance

with the Ambassador from "America"
(Because like pirates, they confiscated
the name of the whole continent.)[4]

Ernesto Cardenal, currently the Minister of Culture in Nicaragua's Government of National Reconstruction, pointed in one of his "Epigrams" to a similar hegemonic confiscation of cultural property, when he wrote:

Haven't you read in *Novedades*,* my love:
WATCHMEN OF PEACE, GENIUS OF LABOR
PALADIN OF DEMOCRACY IN AMERICA
DEFENDER OF CATHOLICISM IN AMERICA
THE PROTECTOR OF THE PEOPLE
THE BENEFACTOR . . .?
They plunder the people's language
and falsify the people's words.
(Just like the people's money.)
That's why we poets polish our poems so much.
That's why my love poems are important. (NR, 85)

The role of poetry in the liberation struggle itself has thus been a crucial one, both as a force for mobilizing a collective response to occupation and domination and as a repository for popular memory and consciousness. According to Elias Khouri, the Lebanese novelist and critic, writing in his article, "The world of meanings in Palestinian poetry,"

> Language is the very framework of steadfastness (*sumūd*) . . . Language is the repository of the collective memory. It is the basic national value which must be preserved. The role of poetry is therefore a major one, not only because it is more powerful than other forms of writing as a means of political mobilization, but also because it sustains, within the popular memory, national continuity.[5]

In pursuing similar issues, Maina wa Kinyatti, the Kenyan historian who edited and translated *Thunder from the Mountains*,

* The magazine, *Novedades*, was a major apologist for the Somoza family.

a collection of Mau Mau patriotic songs, published in 1980, nearly two decades after Kenyan independence, describes his enterprise in producing this collection: "The main objective in translating these songs is to let them answer the anti-Mau Mau Kenyan intellectuals and their imperialist masters who, until now, continue to deny the Movement's national character."[6] According to Maina, who worked on his anthology with former members of the Mau Mau movement,

> Besides being an expression of anti-colonial culture, these songs constitute an important pool of information, a kind of archive, on the Mau Mau Movement, which enables us to probe deeper into Mau Mau history and really understand its political objectives and methods. For us today these songs are an echo, a record, of our people's determination to liberate their country from foreign domination. (TM, 3)

As Edward Dorn and Gordon Brotherston point out, however, in the introduction to their 1968 anthology of Latin American resistance poetry, *Our Word: Guerrilla Poems from Latin America*, these poems, significant as they are to the "popular memory" of peoples struggling for their national liberation and important as they might be in mobilizing collective resistance, are not always "easy to get hold of. There may be, probably are, many more poets we should have wanted to include had work by them been available."[7] Nearly two decades later, these poems, the poetry written in the context of national liberation organizations and resistance movements, remain singularly unavailable to the literary institutions of the west. Nor do they conform to the conventional and canonical criteria of poetic inspiration and composition applied by the Western critics and practitioners of poetry. Neither concerned with the contemporary theories of the "pleasure of the text" nor invoking the Romantic tradition of "recollection in tranquillity," the poems of resistance, often composed on the battlefield or commemorating its casualties, the losses to the community, challenge instead the bourgeois institutions of power which often limit such luxuries to the economically privileged and leisured classes of a world readership. For the resistance poets, like Balach Khan of Baluchistan, a member of

the Baluch People's Liberation Front, there is neither pleasure nor tranquillity in the recollection of emotions. In Balach Khan's poem, "I have no way of saying this gently," the poet-messenger returns from the battlefield of the liberation struggle bearing the news of a fallen comrade. "Sister," he says to the girl, the man's wife,

> I have no other way of
> saying this gently – your husband
> killed in battle – your brother lost.
> Freedom's hunger claimed them
> and their love for this soil, these rocks.

The poet shares the woman's grief at the death of their fellow, at once husband and guerrilla.

> O woman mutilated by the absence
> of so many, your broken dreams
> like the jagged pieces of
> the moon, now pierce me.[8]

"It is possible," however, as the Chilean writer Ariel Dorfman reminds the Western reader of *The Empire's Old Clothes*, an analysis of the forms of cultural imperialism and their impact on the minds of the First as well as the Third World,

> it is possible that a society undergoing rebirth, that is painfully casting off the habits of domination and tradition which before went unquestioned, could be able with more vigor, more rage, more insight, to criticize the patterns and structures which, as their own champions vigorously proclaim, have been standardized and uniformly spread throughout the planet.
>
> (EOC, 8–9)

The poems of resistance, produced by, as well as being productive of, resistance movements throughout the Third World, participate in a radical critique of what Dorfman has called the "standard, uniform patterns" of culture, patterns, that is, of western ideological domination which are currently disseminated,

whether through the conventions of literary genre and protocol or by means of the structures of educational institutions, on an international scale. Ngugi wa Thiong'o, the Kenyan writer and novelist, found, for example, that Wordsworth's daffodils had little meaning for his young son whose post-colonial Kenyan education was still largely determined by the residual curricular standards and restrictions of the General Certificate of Education (GCE) conferred by the British school system. Ngugi's son, the writer relates, thought upon examination that perhaps daffodils were something like "little fish in a lake." (WP, 4) Like Ngugi, the resistance poets articulate the aggressive demand for another poetry, "a different poem," as the Cape Verdean writer Onesimo Silveira entitles his own composition, with neither English daffodils nor "mouths in need of bread."

The people of the islands want a different poem
For the people of the islands
A poem without exiles complaining
In the calm of their existence;
A poem without children nourished
On the black milk of aborted time
A poem without mothers gazing
At the vision of their sons, motherless.
. . . . . .
A poem without words choked
By the harrows of silence.[9]

The title to Silveira's poem refers not only to the poem demanded, however, but to the poem itself which raises the demand. The resistance poems actively engage in the historical process of struggle against the cultural oppression of imperialism, and assert thereby their own polemical historicity. The progressive tension between title and artefact evidenced in "A different poem" is a tension which is already essential to the dynamics and agenda of the resistance movement which must contend with the immediate exigencies of past and present in order to elaborate its vision of the future. It is rendered manifest again in "A poem yet to be written" by Jorge Rebelo, a member

of the Mozambican national liberation organization FRELIMO, when he wrote:

I should like
to be able
to write a poem
which was so beautiful, so rapturous
inspiring and profound
like the People's victory
. . . . . .
A poem which explains
the reason why we won:
it was the People who fought—
the whole People, guided
by the correct line
. . . . . .
Somebody's going to write it some day,
this life that already exists
before it is a poem.[10]

As Leroy Vail and Landeg White maintain in their article, "Forms of resistance: songs and perceptions of power in colonial Mozambique," poetry and poetic expression in Africa were "welcomed as a major channel of communication between powerless and powerful, the client and the patron, the ruled and the ruler."[11] Resistance poems, however, attempt furthermore to transform these relationships of power. The "poem yet to be written" is, as Jorge Rebelo demands, to be

the absolute
denial
of exploitation.

The texts of what have thus been called "resistance poems" have been written by poets from those areas of the world, now classified, however arbitrarily, as the "Third World," from Africa, Central and South America, Asia, and the Arab Middle East. Many of these poets, like the Nicaraguan Tomas Borge,

Dennis Brutus of South Africa, or Mahmud Darwish from Palestine, have suffered long periods of detention and torture in the prisons of the colonizer. They have also, as in the case of Balach Khan, carried guns on the battlefield as active partisans in the national liberation fronts. Some poet-guerrillas too, like Ernesto Cardenal of Nicaragua or Angola's Agostinho Neto, have gone on to become ministers in the new governments formed following the resistance movement's successful struggle against the tyranny of the colonizing power or the oppressive comprador regime. Nor has administration terminated their poetic activity any more than their political commitments, although it has posed new problems for the poet's role in society, problems which the Sandinista writers discuss with Margaret Randall in *Risking a Somersault in the Air*.[12] In those countries, such as Palestine and South Africa, where the liberation struggle is not yet over, poetry continues to play its critically active role in the liberation movement. Poetry is part of the struggle. It is one of the arenas in which that struggle is waged. As the resistance poet from El Salvador, Roque Dalton, wrote in his poem on poetry:

> Poetry
> Forgive me for having helped you understand
> you're not made of words alone.

Roque Dalton was assassinated in 1974, apparently by militaristic members of the People's Revolutionary Army (ERP), the resistance organization to which he himself belonged, who disagreed with his analysis of the historical and political situation in El Salvador and Central America and the strategy which such an analysis entailed. His poetry, "not made of words alone," was part of his guerrilla activity and that activity placed the poet within a struggle for the liberation and self-determination of oppressed peoples that cost him his own life. "To be revolutionary," as Dalton wrote in his essay *Poetry and Militancy in Latin America*,

> when the revolution has eliminated its enemies and has in every sense consolidated itself can be, no doubt about it, more or less glorious and heroic. But to be so when the condition of

> being revolutionary is usually rewarded with death, that is truly the dignity of poetry. The poet takes then the poetry of his or her generation and gives it over to history.[13]

Resistance poems, Dalton's as well as those of other resistance and Third World poets, are part of a historical process, one which requires "taking sides." According to Armand Mattelart, however, "To tackle the problem of the ideological apparatuses of imperialism is already to take sides. It is to recognize as a field of class struggle a domain which many of the actors in this struggle cover up with a show of neutrality."[14] Neither the self-satisfaction of aestheticism, of a belief in art for art's sake, nor theoretical claims to scientific or academic objectivity can account adequately for the historical challenge posed by the literature of resistance to the cultural hegemony of the west. Within this historical conjuncture, the inherited notion of literature in the west as objective, aesthetic, representing universal human values is either compelled to redefine its criteria or is destined inevitably to participate in the First World's post-colonial project of cultural imperialism.

This cultural imperialism is, however, to be found often as much in post-colonial regimes as in colonized countries. In contemporary neo-colonial Kenya, for example, as in Portuguese Mozambique until independence in 1975, writers, artists, and intellectuals have been subjected to the repressive control of the state apparatus. Ngugi wa Thiong'o, in one instance, spent a year in prison in 1977 under Jomo Kenyatta for his successful collective theatrical project in a Gikuyu village which effectively mobilized the entire local population in building the popular dramatic production and theater complex at Kamiriithu.[15] In El Salvador too, Roque Dalton was part of a resistance movement opposed to the comprador authoritarian regime supported by the western powers, and most especially the United States. Similarly minority populations such as the Kurds in Iran and Iraq, or the Sindh and the Baluch in Pakistan, have organized in popular resistance movements to oppose the neo-colonial ethnic regimes which dominate those countries.

The case of the Baluch

In describing the drama of contemporary Pakistan, Eqbal Ahmad sets a "sense of sadness" against the buoyant tradition of the

people. "What you find very striking now," he writes, "is that a sense of extreme sadness pervades Pakistan today. You feel that the energy of these people is sapped by some sort of grief." For Ahmad, such sadness has replaced the former "intensity, the obvious dynamism of Pakistani streetlife, the Pakistani social life, the fast traffic, the frequency with which people break out into laughter or singing or prancing in the streets, the intense nervous energy with which you will find workers working."[16] In 1980, when these comments were made, the people of Pakistan were still recovering from the *coup d'état* of 1977 in which Zia ul-Haq overthrew the Bhutto regime and the execution two years later of former president Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto. Thus the sadness in the streets is seen by Eqbal Ahmad as located in the people's "feeling of guilt, perhaps of shame, a sense of responsibility for what happened."

A sadness echoes too in the Baluch poems of Balach Khan, a sadness, however, not of shame or guilt, but rather the sadness of "children who dream of more light/than the sun can spare." ("Quetta") It is a sadness engendered by an ongoing struggle, a struggle not yet consummated. The series of poems by Balach Khan[17] recount the poet's participation in the 1973–7 insurgency in Baluchistan as a result of which he himself lived several years in exile in London, returning to Pakistan only several years later under a general amnesty. The poet's personal itinerary is located in a historical process.

Since it was created as a separate Muslim state in 1947 with the end of the British raj's direct influence in the Indian subcontinent, Pakistan's successive regimes, controlled largely by the Punjabis who are a majority in the country, have failed to unify the several populations living within its national boundaries. Following the secession of Bengali East Pakistan in 1971 and the creation of Bangladesh, the minority peoples of Pakistan, in Sindh, the Northwest Frontier Province, and Baluchistan, have variously contended for equal rights and/or an autonomous state.[18] The Baluchistan insurgency of 1973–7 was the latest of the Baluch uprisings against Islamabad, which, for its part, has alternately ignored and suppressed their demands for representation and independence, demands which are greatly complicated by the fact that the territory of the Baluch homeland is divided

among Pakistan, Iran, and Afghanistan. Although nearly half the Baluch population, for reasons of employment, politics, or need, now lives outside of Baluchistan, their desire for the wild, rugged terrain of the homeland is rooted deep in their traditions.

This commitment to the homeland echoes in sixteenth-century war ballads which sing that "the lofty heights are our comrades/the pathless gorges our friends" no less than in contemporary patriotic songs commemorating former national heroes such as Nasir Khan:

> Pleasant as the homeland of another may be,
> Populous and affluent and great of name,
> Streams of honey may run there.
> But for Nasir
> The "dry wood of the homeland" is better than all the world.[19]

Balach Khan's poem "Quetta" also laments the present fate of one of Baluchistan's most important cities, the former gateway to India, where it now happens that "police and soldiers in a dozen/ different uniforms, tramp the roadsides,/and children hug the shopfronts,/eyes down, terrified of being stopped." Like the ancestral ballads, "the epic poems of Baluch chivalry" ("Voices of dawn"), and the modern anthems of Baluchistan, the verses of Balach Khan memorialize his land and his people's past and their present struggle, for, as the poet maintains, "from the tragedy of beautiful places/the Baluch will write their own history." ("Passing a graveyard at night")

Balach Khan's poems also contain a lyrical examination of the role of the poet himself in the liberation struggle and the challenges to poetry which come from the resistance movement. A number of the poems, like "The singer" written for Mayara Noor, or again like "The language of stones" composed for "an Urdu poetess after reading her poem on the Baluch struggle," are dedicated to other writers. In this last poem, the poet who fights his way across the Baluch mountains reflects not only on the changed circumstances of poetic composition, but on the very sources of what has long been venerated as poetic inspiration:

> I am altogether overwhelmed.
> How do you write or pass

the time of day? Where do you sit,
on a chair, desk, bed, the floor?
I do all my thinking on these endless marches and sometimes
in the red-eyed dawn, a poem
settles itself like a leaf
on a clean white page.

Although the Baluch resistance poet's task is perhaps still governed by the twofold Horatian requirement of "entertainment and instruction," these two injunctions are given a new urgency by the contemporary struggle against a history of oppression. In his poem "But being an only son" Balach Khan describes the young shepherd who daily provided the guerillas with fresh milk from his goats, but who, "being an only son," was not allowed to participate in active combat.

He would hang around me and touch
the radio, typewriter with far away fingers
like objects he did not understand,
but would handle my rifle as if he knew.

In Pakistani Baluchistan, the country's poorest province where the literacy rate in 1976 was only 6–9 percent as compared to a national average of 16 percent, (IAS, 161) the need for education, the poet demonstrates, is as imperative as the necessity of armed struggle. And yet the poet is aware too, in his unrelenting examination of poetry, that the writer who would teach has in turn much to learn from his comrades. "Most fighters," as he writes, "have never seen/the sea/i describe it and fail/they imagine it to be/like the sky." ("The sea") The poet's poems stop just short of instruction and instead are able only to point the way. The same poem indeed leads to the sea, and concludes: "once i took a comrade/to the beach/he was too stunned to speak/i could not reach/him for a soundless hour."

That Balach Khan's poems are written in English can perhaps be taken as a significant measure of the educational and cultural exigencies which face the Baluch people in their struggle. Baluch self-determination and independence and an access to history require popular archives as well as arsenals and these poems

themselves contribute to the elaboration of such archives. The issue of readership nonetheless poses inevitably crucial questions. Until 150 years ago, when Baluch scholars began to transcribe the Baluch language in Urdu or Persian script, the Baluch oral tradition and cultural heritage had gone largely unrecorded. More recently a Baluch script called Nastaliq, which resembles Arabic, has been developed by the intellectuals of Baluch nationalism. Given the tribalism which still characterizes Baluch society, however, "one of the most significant indicators of Baluch nationalism," according to Selig Harrison,

> is likely to be the extent to which the Baluch are able to develop a standardized language in a commonly accepted script. Although a lively literature has developed as an adjunct of the nationalist movement, Baluchi books, magazines and newspapers reflect a widespread linguistic confusion. (IAS, 185)

And yet, as the Baluch poet says, acknowledging this dilemma and composing even in English, "I am writing letters in the dust,/ tracing lines of communication/with a stick." ("Poems of absence III")

The sadness of the poems, "when the young die," and of "children [who] dream of more light/than the sun can spare," is given meaning by the struggle not only for liberation but also for communication. The collection includes love poems as well as resistance poems, poems for G., for Dahli, for Mayara Noor, for the Urdu poetess, for Hoaran Marri. Indeed the resistance poems can be read as love poems and vice versa, collapsing categories and elaborating new strategies of expression. These poems, whether read collectively or taken individually, poems in which "Mercedes three tonners carry commandos" across the children's playgrounds ("Children's playground") and the "whack-whack of heliblades" accompanies "the sun [as it] rolls over the horizon/at dawn," carry an enormous burden, the burden, according to the poet, "of those unable to complete the history/of their own bodies, disappearing in/the opposite direction to their journey." ("It is when the young die")

The body divided

Writing in his *Memoirs* toward the end of his life, Pablo Neruda notes,

> There is an old theme, a "body divided," that recurs in the folk poetry of all countries. The popular singer imagines his feet in one place, his kidneys somewhere else, and goes on to describe his whole body, which he has left behind, scattered in countrysides and cities. That's how I felt in those days.[20]

Those days to which the poet refers were in Chile in the 1940s, when Neruda was finishing his long epic poem, "*Canto general*," moving from house to house, in hiding from the government authorities, but received by the people who offered him refuge. The dismemberment of the poetic identity is reconstructed in ties of solidarity with the people themselves. That dismemberment, part of imperialism's strategy, conditions, however, the new literary and cultural agenda of the poets of the resistance movements and national liberation organizations. Responding to the crisis articulated by Neruda in his later poem "Central America,"

> Land as slim as a whip,
> hot as torture,
> your step in Honduras, your blood
> in Santo Domingo, at night,
> your eyes in Nicaragua
> touch, call, grip me,
> and throughout American lands
> I knock on doors to speak,
> I tap on tongues that are tied,
> I raise curtains, plunge
> my hands into blood:
> Sorrows
> of my land, death rattle of
> the great established silence,
> long-suffering people,
> slender waist of tears. (NR, 21)

the resistance poets have produced a new and vital corpus of literary and poetic work. That corpus is remarkable not only for

its coherence and magnitude, but also for the developed character of its challenge both to western literary convention and to the sway of traditional values from within their own cultures.

The resistance movements, within the context of which the poets write, are organized political and guerrilla movements which had and continue to have as their aim the liberation of the land and the people through armed struggle from the forces of outside oppression, from the political, military, and cultural hegemony and domination by imperialist and colonialist countries. In 1956, the MPLA, the People's Movement for the Liberation of Angola, was founded in Portuguese Angola. Fourteen years after its first armed action in Luanda in 1961, an independent Angolan republic was proclaimed on 11 November 1975. In that same year, 1975, Portuguese Mozambique was liberated following a fourteen-year struggle carried out by FRELIMO, the Mozambique Liberation Front. Similarly successful in its liberation struggle was Nicaragua's FSLN, the Sandinista National Liberation Front, founded in 1961 and named after Augusto C. Sandino, the early hero of Nicaraguan resistance. The FSLN removed the Somoza regime from power in July 1979. Nelson Mandela, however, leader of South Africa's African National Congress (ANC), remains in prison in South Africa, while the movement continues its struggle against the white apartheid regime in that country. So too the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), formed as an independent Palestinian movement in 1968, continues to fight for Palestinian self-determination and an independent autonomous Palestinian state.

Out of these resistance movements and their struggle on political, military, and cultural fronts, a new pantheon of letters is emerging, one forged in the battle against imperialism and exploitation. The poets, adherents and partisans of given organizations with national identities, manifest in their poems a consciousness of the larger arena within which they write. Chile's Neruda, like Cuba's Guillēn, composes poems in honor of Augusto Sandino of Nicaragua. Angolan Viriato da Cruz, in his poem "Black mother," honors the struggle on three continents:

Voices from the cane plantations,
from paddy fields, the coffee farms,

the silk works, the
cotton fields
Voices from plantations in Virginia
from farms in the Carolinas
Alabama
Cuba
Brazil
Voices from Brazilian sugar plants
from the tonga drums, from the
pampas, from factories,
Voices from Harlem District South,
voices from slum locations
Voices wailing blues going up the
Mississippi, echoing from rail road wagons.
Voices weeping with Carrother's voice
"Lord God what will have we done"
Voices of all voices in the proud voice
of Langston
in the beautiful voice of Guillén. (WBBF, 53–4)

Poetess Noémia de Sousa represents the Mozambican João:

he suffered with the passivity of the peasant women
he felt the sun piercing like a thorn in the Arabs' midday
he bargained on bazaar benches with the Chinese
he sold tired green vegetables with the Asian traders
he howled spirituals from Harlem with Marion Anderson
he swayed to the Chope marimbas on a Sunday
he cried out with the rebels their cry of blood. (WBBF, 71)

Nelson Mandela's imprisonment in South Africa provokes José Craveirinha to write in Mozambique his poem entitled "Since my friend Nelson Mandela went to live on Robben Island" (SH, 134–6). And in Baluchistan Balach Khan remembers in his poem "But being an only son:"

I shift from rock
to rock, hearing the Palestinians
are fighting and dying in Lebanon,
their obstinate blood flows in my bones.

Nonetheless, for each of these movements, the ANC, FRELIMO, MPLA, the PLO, and the FSLN, as for others – like the Vietnamese, the Kurdish, the Cuban, or the Algerian – the questions of national culture and poetry have been crucially important as well. The challenge was raised already by Amilcar Cabral when he wrote, "The national liberation of a people is the regaining of the historical personality of that people, it is their return to history through the destruction of the imperialist domination to which they have been subjected." This complex role of poetry within the liberation struggle is part of the poems themselves.

A. N. C. Kumalo is a South African poet currently living in exile in London. His name, A. N. C. Kumalo, which is a pseudonym, bespeaks the strength of his identification of his own poetic identity with that of the African National Congress (ANC) and its ongoing struggle against South Africa's white racist government. The ANC, which was formed in 1912 and formally inaugurated in 1948, began a campaign of passive resistance and labor strikes in the early 1950s. Only later, and after considerable internal debate, in 1961, was the decision taken to engage in revolutionary activity and wage an armed struggle in order to liberate South Africa and its people from the white Afrikaner regime and its repressive system of apartheid.[21] Kumalo's poem "Red our colour" identifies further the role of poetry with the guerrilla activity carried out by the resistance organization:

Let's have poems
blood-red in colour
ringing like damn bells.

Poems
that tear at the oppressor's face
and smash his grip.

Poems that awaken man:
Life not death
Hope not despair
Dawn not dusk
New not old
Struggle not submission.

Poet
let the people know
that dreams can become
reality.

Talk of freedom
and let the plutocrat
decorate his parlour walls
with the perfumed scrawls of dilettantes.

Talk of freedom
and touch people's eyes
with the knowledge of the power
of multitudes
that twists prison bars like grass
and flattens granite walls like putty.

Poet
find the people
help forge the key
before the decade
eats the decade
eats the decade.[22]

"Red our colour" demands that the reader, like Roque Dalton's poem, recognize that poetry is "not made of words alone." Poetry, Kumalo demands, should be "blood-red" and "ringing." It should "tear at the oppressor's face" and "smash his grip," leaving to the oppressor and his well-appointed interiors and parlour walls that other poetry, "the perfumed scrawls of dilettantes." Unadorned with the elegant and figurative accoutrements of aestheticism, Kumalo's poem asserts a brutally aggressive sparseness, a call to revolution in poetry.

FRELIMO, in introducing a collection of the movement's resistance poems, *Poems of Combat*, in 1971, had claimed that

> our poetry is also a slogan. Like a slogan it is born out of necessity, out of reality. While in colonialism and capitalism, culture and poetry were amusements of the rich, our poetry of today is a necessity, a song which goes out of our heart to raise our

spirit, guide our will, reinforce our determination and broaden our perspective.[23]

The polemical quality of Kumalo's poem, like that of many resistance poems where the very bareness of the language is part of the offensive, represents a critical dimension of the poems' attack on certain forms of cultural imperialism. As Keith Ellis pointed out in his study of the Cuban poet Guillén, the tendency to dismiss much of Third World poetry as "propaganda" or "pamphleteering" derives in fact from the attempted universal legislation of what is a very local or regionally-based definition of poetry, one which, following Aristotle's script in the *Poetics* and the *Rhetoric*, sees in metaphor the essential ingredient of poetic language. "In fact," Ellis writes, "metaphor has achieved so much prestige among certain groups in our century as to prompt a tendency among those groups to regard as 'anti-poetry' manifestations of poetry in which its suzerainty is not apparent." (CNG, 48) In Kumalo's poem, "Red our colour," the only metaphors, or rather in this case similes, are those which envisage the revolutionary transformation of social reality and the destruction of repressive state apparatuses: poems, that is, "ringing like bells" that will "twist prison bars like grass" and "flatten granite walls like putty."

The institutions of the state order and its authoritarian control are the target of the resistance poems just as much as of the resistance movement's military and political operations. Many of the poets involved in the struggle have experienced intimately the oppressive force of these institutions, from within which they seek to redefine through their poetry the possibilities of a new, revised social order. "Today in prison" was written by Dennis Brutus for the occasion of South African Freedom Day, 26 June 1967. Brutus, a South African poet now teaching in the United States, is also president of the South African Non-Racial Olympic Committee. He left South Africa in 1966 following eighteen months of hard labor on Robben Island and a subsequent year of house arrest. "Today in prison" assaults from within the prison walls the very existence of the state which maintains the prison structure:

Today in prison
by tacit agreement

they will sing just one song:
Nkosi Sikelela;*
slowly and solemnly
with suppressed passion
and pent up feeling:
the voices strong and steady
but with tears close and sharp
behind the eyes
and the mind ranging
wildly as a strayed bird
seeking some names to settle on
and deeds being done
and those who will do the much
that still needs to be done. (PP, 21)

Like "Red our colour," the poem by Dennis Brutus is linguistically and figuratively stark, with only one simile, that of "the mind ranging/wildly as a strayed bird." The poem itself sings the importance of the ANC anthem, Nkosi Sikelela Afrika, in uniting the prisoners in one of South Africa's notorious prisons through the prospects of a new solidarity. That solidarity, based on collective resistance, is commemorated in a visionary appeal through the "strayed bird," harbinger of the future: "names to settle on/ and deeds being done," the combined forces of poetry and armed struggle.

In signaling the communal function of poetry, Benedict Anderson has emphasized the special importance of the national anthem in identifying the social formation and constitution of nationalisms, what he terms "imagined communities:"

> There is a special kind of contemporaneous community which language alone suggests – above all in the form of poetry and songs. Take national anthems, for example, sung on national holidays. No matter how banal the words and mediocre the tunes, there is in this singing an experience of simultaneity. At precisely such moments, people wholly unknown to each other utter the same verses to the same melody. The image: unisonance. Singing the Marseillaise, Waltzing Matilda and Indonesia Raya provide

* Nkosi Sikelela Afrika = God Save Africa: the anthem of the ANC.

occasions for unisonality, for the echoed physical realization of the imagined community.[24]

Nkosi Sikelela Afrika, however, though it may indeed be the anthem of an "imagined community" in Anderson's terms, nonetheless is not yet a national anthem. It is an anthem which does more than commemorate the historical accomplishments of a people or group. It also animates the historical struggle of the present and the future: "deeds being done/and those who will do the much/that still needs to be done."

In "Surprisingly singing," by Barry Feinberg, a South African writer, journalist and poet likewise living in exile, it is the solidarity of black men singing, however surprisingly, which sustains the poem and transforms it into the national banner of the resistance movement: green, gold, and black, the colors of the African National Congress.

While whites
on sabbath greens
slowly bowling,
on weekdays
growing gold
back home
black men
break backs,
surprisingly
singing.

(PP, 37)

The poem itself is a standard, the poet a standard bearer of the struggle for liberation. The poet's songs incorporate anew the anthems of the community even as they produce the animating slogans and verses for the resistance movement and its people. Thus A. N. C. Kumalo's "Poem of vengeance" both memorializes the martyred members of the ANC hanged in the Pretoria prison in November 1964 and reactivates their freedom songs:

How did Mini and my brothers die
in that secret hanging place?
You may ask – please let me tell you –
I know.

Singing? Yes – but how they sing!
Big firm Mini
not smiling on this day
a smile at the lips perhaps
but the eyes grim
always grim
when facing the enemy.

Heads high they walk
strong united together
singing Mini's own song*
"Naants' indod' emnyama Verwoerd"
– Watch out Verwoerd the black man will get you –
"Watch out Verwoerd"
the people have taken up this song
"Watch out Verwoerd"
the world sings with Mini. (PP, 37)

Like the parrot in Achebe's fable in *Things Fall Apart*, the poets of the resistance movements are engaging in what Umberto Eco has called a kind of "semiotic guerrilla warfare," a "*tactic* of decoding where the message as expression does not change but the addressee discovers his *freedom of decoding*."[25] The guerrilla warfare of the poems involves both the mobilization of the fighters and the challenge to the existing order, as in "We shall not mourn the dead," by the Angolan poet and member of the MPLA, Helder Neto. The poem concludes defiantly: MPLA AVAAAAANCAAA! (WBBF, 115) "To point a moral to a comrade" by Marcelino dos Santos, a FRELIMO partisan who became Minister of Economic Planning in the Mozambican government, makes another use of the pamphlet genre. Divided into four parts, or "pamphlets," the poem is regularly disrupted by FRELIMO slogans such as:

REALISE THE PROGRAMME OF FRELIMO
COMPLETE NATIONAL INDEPENDENCE
AN END OF EXPLOITATION MAN BY MAN (WBBF, 117)

* Vuyusile Mini was the composer of many freedom songs.

It concludes:

> WE ARE FRELIMO SOLDIERS
> ACCOMPLISHING THE PARTY'S TASK
> DIGGING THE BASIC SOIL OF REVOLUTION
> FOR AN END OF EXPLOITATION MAN BY MAN
> TO BUILD COMPLETE NATIONAL INDEPENDENCE. (WBBF, 127)

In describing the resistance poetry of Mozambique, Russell Hamilton referred to it as "committed poetry," claiming that such poetry "has its own aesthetic code predicated on its social functionality." According to Hamilton,

> At the height of the armed struggle, in liberated zones, Mozambicans from different regions of the territory learned each other's songs and dances, and thereby contributed to a spirit of national unity that helped obliterate divisive ethnic distinctions. In the camps of these liberated areas some soldiers wrote poetry to express their experiences, their hopes and their resolve. As a didactic tool poetry's mnemonic function frequently served to teach not only moral lessons but also Mozambican history and geography. In effect, poetry recaptured the social function that cultural expression served in pre-colonial times, except that under the aegis of the revolution this new poetry encouraged change as much as it transmitted history and traditions.[26]

The poetic disposition displayed in these resistance poems is radically different from, indeed it is opposed to, the cult of *bienséances* or even academic objectivity traditionally cultivated in western literary or academic establishments, which are most concerned to deny to poetry and culture any political role or access to political power. Literary production must, for the most part, be either domesticated or else disacknowledged as "literature." It is easier, for example, to read *Things Fall Apart* according to Aristotelian precepts of tragedy with Okonkwo as the tragically flawed hero, than to attempt to come to terms with it as an act of resistance against white, European imperialist aggression. Third World writers, however, are raising a different set of

standards. Culture, then, and language are critical as an arena of struggle, no less than as a part of that struggle, as one of the weapons – like the guns, the spear, and the cannon that gave the tortoise his broken shell in Ezinma's fable in *Things Fall Apart*. The use of language is crucial, both as challenge to the antagonist and in redefining the identity of the protagonist, to the strategy of any resistance movement. As in the case of the parrot, however, it is necessary for the people to learn the language, to become practiced in its use.

The education of poetry

In his poem, "Letter from a contract worker," written originally in Portuguese and anthologized in the collection *When Bullets Begin to Flower*, the Angolan poet Antonio Jacinto portrays the frustration and anguish of a society whose traditional fabric has been rent asunder by foreign influence but which is at the same time denied access to the means of renovating its own social organization.

I wanted to write you a letter
my love
a letter to tell
of this longing
to see you
and this fear
of losing you
of this thing which deeper than I want, I feel
a nameless pain which pursues me
a sorrow wrapped about my life.

I wanted to write you a letter
my love
a letter of intimate secrets
a letter of memories of you
of you
your lips as red as the tacula fruit
your eyes gentle as the macongue
your breasts hard as young mobaque fruit

your light walk
your caresses
better than any that I find down here.

I wanted to write you a letter
my love
to bring back our days together in our secret haunts
nights lost in the long grass
to bring back the shadow of your legs
and the moonlight filtering through the endless
palms,
to bring back the madness of our passion
and the bitterness of separation

I wanted to write you a letter
my love
which you could not read without crying
which you would hide from your father Bombo
and conceal from your mother Kieza
which you would read without the indifference
of forgetfulness,
a letter which would make any other
in all Kilombo worthless.

I wanted to write you a letter
my love
a letter which the passing wind would take
a letter which the cashew and the coffee trees,
the hyenas and the buffalo,
the caymans and the river fish
could hear
the plants and the animals
pitying our sharp sorrow
from song to song
lament to lament
breath to caught breath
would leave to you, pure and hot,
the burning
the sorrowful words of the letter
I wanted to write you

I wanted to write you a letter
But my love, I don't know why it is,
why, why, why it is, my love,
but you can't read
and I – oh the hopelessness – I can't write. (WBBF, 51–3)

Jacinto's poem presents itself as the unwritten love-letter from a contract worker to the beloved he has left behind in the village. Contract workers were native Africans who hired out to employers for a fixed time at exploitative wages, a practice almost of forced labor known as *chibalo*. It was often the case that the men had been forced by taxation to leave the traditional land in order to find work to pay the required tax to the colonial power.[27] Here the young worker is shown as suffering from the intense desire to write to his love and each stanza begins with the cry of despair: "I wanted to write you a letter/my love." The poem, stanza by stanza, then develops all the passion and intensity of feeling which would have gone into an expression of such a love, only to conclude with the simple statement as to why the letter cannot be written: "you can't read/and I – oh the hopelessness – I can't write."

In Portugal's African colonies, only 2 per cent of the Africans ever learned to read. The poem, then, which is on one level an articulation of the problem of the disparity between intellectuals and the people, between the poet and the contract worker, is also a dramatic statement of the subjugated condition of the colonized under imperialist hegemony. Each stanza addresses a particular feature of that oppressive control and suggests possible responses to it. Stanza 1 presents the conventional lines of an amatory epistle, but in stanza 2 the introduction of African words already suggests the conflict and tension which is now embedded in the social situation. In the third stanza the poet/narrator invokes the nostalgic images of a past now lost, yet stanza 4, which refers to the beloved's father and mother and their probable disapproval, implies as well a critique of the traditional mores. The penultimate stanza goes on to propose a solidarity between the lovers and the land which cooperates in their love affair. The poem itself enacts thus the dissolution of the very genre of love poem through its subtle exposure of the politics of repression at work in

western culture and its domination in the Third World. Not only love, but letters are denied to the colonized by the colonial master. The poem's conclusion points outward, beyond the poem, to the conditions of its production, exploding thereby not only the criteria of closure and autonomy in a literary work, but the privatized and romantic ideology of love dominant in the western tradition. The love affair between the contract worker and his beloved requires for its consummation a radical social transformation.

According to Keith Ellis, the Russian socialist Plekhanov's critique of the art-for-art's-sake movement and its relationship to the bourgeoisie in nineteenth century France finds little applicability in Spanish America:

> The sort of sustained disdain and contempt for the bourgeoisie noted by Plekhanov in the French writers of the nineteenth century (e.g. art for art's sake) would be out of place in Spanish America where such a defined, stable class of readers does not exist. And rare is the writer who is capable of contempt for people in general. (CNG, 36)

That same contempt and disdain for a popular readership which is a hallmark of certain modes of artistic expression is similarly irrelevant in Africa and other parts of the Third World struggling for political and cultural independence. Jacinto's poem, "Letter from a contract worker," written prior to Angola's independence, not only represents a certain historical moment in the evolution of the liberation struggle and resistance strategy, it looks ahead as well, as a continuing challenge to the generalized assessments of western specialists on the Third World. According to Jacques Loup, a former World Bank economist, writing in 1980,

> The rapid progress in education [in the Third World] should not make us forget the numerous problems which plague this sector in the Third World. Faced with a rapid increase in the size of classes, these countries have substantially enlarged their teaching staff. Nevertheless, the number of pupils per teacher still remains high even today (more than one and a half times

what it is in the developed countries); it has in fact hardly varied since 1960. Equally important are the drop-out rates, which have improved only very slowly: even at the end of the sixties nearly half the pupils left school before they had reached the fourth grade.[28]

Jacinto, less interested than the World Bank in statistics, insists on the historical specificity of the question of illiteracy, on "how," as Walter Rodney phrases it, "Europe under-developed Africa."

That underdevelopment in the realm of education is reformulated in the poem by Sergio Vieira of Mozambique, "Four parts for a poem on education left incomplete, because education is for all of us to build:"

We were like the blind
stumbling on the stones of ignorance,
comrades!
that's how they wanted us
the bishops
the companies
the mineowners!
heads of blacks
empty
and shoulders ready to carry a mountain.
ignorant
looking at written words
when in them
our price was written! (SH, 73)

Education requires the resistance struggle no less than it is necessary for the resistance movement to include education as crucial to its agenda of liberation. Clearly though the poet of "Letter from a contract worker" has been privileged with learning how to read. He is conscious too, however, as evidenced in the irony of the poem's enunciation, of his own problematic but critical role as "educator" of the people, acting and writing as one who will both restore and construct the social integrity of the nation. This construction, as Jacinto's poem implies, must take

place on a new level, a program different from even the traditional one represented by the woman's own father and mother, themselves disapproving of their daughter's thwarted relationship. In the same way that Achebe does not represent the Igbo past as an idyllic Edenic garden, a lost paradise which the Igbo people must recapture, "put back together," in order to secure their future salvation, so these poets of resistance are attempting to elaborate out of their specific experience new methods and cultural priorities for confronting their historical situation. In another of Jacinto's poems, written subsequent to "Letter from a contract worker," the enforced separation between man and woman is cast in very different terms. Here, as in Balach Khan's "I have no way of saying this gently," the separation is required by the exigencies of the resistance struggle:

Kaianga's wife is weeping

Kaianga has gone to war, Kaianga has gone to war

In the solitary township
lights and shadows play silently between the huts
children sleep
old people dream
dogs sit panting
flies buzz round the dunghill
and from the roofs, threads of water drip
– life affected by the absence of men – (WBBF, 93)

It is these, the guerrillas and comrades of the liberation organization, who in part two of Vieira's poem, "Four parts for a poem on education," become the educators:

And there came comrades,
    those who cried out strongly
        stronger than all the words
            which we ignored
and the words brought spears of fire
    and we were gunpowder
the words explained the weight of the company
    the company which bent
            our backs

the words were the whips
    tearing our blindness
and in the words we understood. (SH, 77)

The education is such that a new social order is inaugurated, overturning the traditional hierarchies of authority:

they were children
    under the bullets
    teaching adults
        you were thirteen years
            and your eyes were opened
with signs that you made on the floor
    . . . . . .
    we learned how to read and write.
we made mistakes in our words
    we didn't know perfectly
        when to put an "s"
            or a "c" with a cedilla,
but we all knew how to write
    war
        and school
            and co-operative
                and culture
and our machine guns
    spelled Freedom (SH, 78–9)

Thus, as Jorge Rebelo, the Mozambican poet of FRELIMO, writes in his "Poem,"

Come, tell me all this, my brother.

And later I will forge simple words
which even the children can understand
words which will enter every house
like the wind
and fall like red hot embers
on our people's souls

In our land
Bullets are beginning to flower. (WBBF, 129)

The new words are necessary because, as Ernesto Cardenal wrote in his "Epigram," the people's language has been plundered, the people's words falsified. The education of resistance is projected to lead to what Vieira went on to call, in the fourth part of his poem on education, a

> Tomorrow,
> when
> colonialism and imperialism
> are only words which are found
> in a dictionary of archaic terms. (SH, 81)

The poems that speak to the necessity of education also implicate their poets in the educational process. It is the resistance poet, like Nicaraguan Joaquin Pasos, celebrated by Cardenal in his "Epitaph for Joaquin Pasos," who has

> purified, in his poems, the language of the people
> in which trade agreements, the Constitution, love letters
> and decrees will one day be written. (NR, 87)

Poetic language is not envisaged here as a rarefied or transcendent means of expression, detached from the political reality of struggle, but rather it is considered an integral part of the ideological foundations of the new social order, personal as well as public, the language of decrees no less than of love letters. The new language, the language made from the combined forces of resistance and poetry, is still to be forged. Neither armed struggle alone, nor cultural resistance by itself, can provide the necessary resources. Poetry, furthermore, must contend not only with the outsider, the invader or aggressor, and the regressive effects of colonialism, but with the burden of its own past as well. Thus Mahmud Darwish, the Palestinian poet now living in exile, examines the twofold struggle of the resistance and its poets in his poem "The roses and the dictionary:"

> Be that as it may,
> I must . . .
> The poet must have a new toast
> And new anthems.

Traversing a tunnel of incense
And pepper and ancient summer,
I carry the key to legends and ruined monuments of slaves.
I see history an old man
Tossing dice and gathering the stars.

Be that as it may,
I must refuse death
Even though my legends die.
In the rubble I rummage for light and new poetry,
Did you realize before today, my love,
That a letter in the dictionary is dull?
How do they live, all these words?
How do they grow? How do they spread?
We still water them with the tears of memories
And metaphors and sugar.

Be that as it may,
I must reject the roses that spring
From a dictionary or a *diwan*.
Roses grow on the arms of a peasant, on the fists of a laborer,
Roses grow over the wounds of a warrior
And on the face of a rock.[29]

Darwish's poem, suspended in the tension between the necessity and inevitability of the historical process ("Be that as it may") and his own struggle with it ("I must"), rejects the dictionary definitions and conventions provided by classical Arabic literature ("the roses that spring/from a dictionary or a *diwan*"). The poet asserts rather the new meanings that will emerge out of the popular movement of resistance, from the "arms of a peasant," the "fists of a laborer," and the "wounds of a warrior." Darwish's poetic appeal to the popular struggle enacts what Elias Khouri termed in Palestinian poetry the "approach to the popular song," pointing thereby to the "rhythmical clarity [in poetry] which is capable of playing a special role in political practice." (LM, 230)

Such a clarity, that of popular expression, is all the more necessary given the perceived inadequacy of the rhetorical pretensions of the Arabic language manipulated by demagogic

Arab leaders and the actual historical record. The failure is pointed out by Zohair Sabbagh, a Palestinian writer living in Israel. In his study of the popular, but officially suppressed, Egyptian poet, musician, and sculptor, Ahmad Fuad Negm, Sheikh Imam, and Muhammad Ali, *An Issue and Three Combatants*, Sabbagh condemns the suppression or considered neglect in the Arab world of the works of writers of the revolution, a neglect remarkable even in publications of the Left. The Palestinian critic insists on the significance of the popular acclaim which these artists continue to enjoin:

> Despite the politics of obscurity, oppression, blockade and banishment which followed the Camp David Accords in Egypt and the rest of the Arab regimes, it is clear to us that amongst the people the poems of Ahmad Fuad Negm and the songs of Sheikh Imam Aissa are widely disseminated in Egypt, in our own land and throughout the Arab world of silence.[30]

Palestinian resistance poets and their Arab colleagues are engaged in a conflict not only with Israeli occupation of the land of Palestine, but with traditional social, political, and literary codes as well. This is a struggle which a western perspective has especial, if determined, difficulty in acknowledging, but it is one which the resistance poets and the commandos insist on: it is through the internal contradictions, the conflicts and dynamics within their own social order, as well as through the military and cultural confrontation with the external forces of hegemony which oppress that order, that revolutionary movements and their people discover and manifest their historicity, concretize their demand for access to the world historical order. This failure of the west to learn the limitations of its own learning is decried by Pablo Neruda, writing in solidarity with the Nicaraguan guerrillas. The lines are taken from his "Epic:"

> The lessons were very different,
> in West Point instruction was pure:
> school never taught them
> that those who kill could be killed:
> the Yankees never learned

how we love our poor and dear land
how we'd defend the flags
we'd sewn with so much pain and love.
What they couldn't learn in Philadelphia,
was taught in blood in Nicaragua (NR, 53)

In other words, the First World is being called upon to assume a certain responsibility – a responsibility not for others, for "the other," the "Third World," the "oriental," or however it chooses to designate the unfamiliar, but for the limitations of its own perspective.

The Palestinian Wedding

In *The Palestinian Wedding*, Abdelwahab Elmessiri has collected, translated and assembled a volume of poems representing some of the major speakers of poetry who have emerged from the movement of Palestinian resistance to aggression, displacement and dispossession on the part of Israel and the western powers of imperialism. Like *Nicaragua in Revolution: The Poets Speak* in which the Sandinista revolution is narrated through the writings of its poets, this volume commemorates a historical moment in a national struggle which must in the end discover its significance in the larger confrontation with the forces of repression, both political and cultural, throughout the modern world. It is in reference to this broader context that the poems collected in the volume have been ordered and arranged. The anthology, which is divided into six sections, beginning with "Aesthetics of the revolution," followed by "Elegies," "Love of Palestine," "Steadfastness," "Resistance," and culminating finally in "Victory", contains within its arrangement an implicit narrative, a narrative whose argument is explicitly articulated in Elmessiri's critical introduction to the collection.

> Those who tend, consciously or unconsciously, to think of Palestine only with reference to Zionism view its history as a mere reaction to Zionist settler colonialism. While it is true that the Zionist settlement in Palestine has had a profound and probably lasting impact on Palestinian society, it is also important to

> remember that Palestine, first and foremost, is part of a wider Arab cultural and national formation. Similarly Zionism and the Zionist state itself should be seen as a manifestation of a distinct social and cultural formation, namely, that of nineteenth century Europe with its imperialist onslaught on Africa and Asia and a world outlook assuming rather sharp distinctions between the races. . . . Palestine, and consequently Palestinian poetry, part of a complex cultural configuration, should therefore be seen in a broad pan-Arab context, rather than in the narrow and rather constricted perspective of Zionist settler colonialism. (PW, 1)

Because it is a collection of many poems, by many different poets, and because these poems are furthermore assorted and significantly organized into something more than an anthology, *The Palestinian Wedding* – and here it differs from *Nicaragua in Revolution* or *Thunder from the Mountains* which record an already achieved historical moment – combines at once, in a tense juxtaposition, the transcendence of the symbol with the immanence of narrative. In "On the trunk of an olive tree," Tawfiq Zayyad, the former mayor of Nazareth, removed from his position by the Israeli authorities, and an elected member of Raqah, the Israeli Communist Party, in the Knesset, composes the lines:

> I shall carve the number of each deed
> Of our usurped land,
> The location of my village and its boundaries,
> . . . . . .
> All the chapters of my tragedy,
> And all the stages of the disaster,
> From beginning
> To end,
> On the olive tree
> In the courtyard
> Of the house. (PW, 55–9)

In their struggle with the assaults of history, however, the poets carve not only commemorative verses into the symbols of

Palestine, but proceed like the "flock of canaries" in Salma al-Jayyusi's poem "Dearest love II,"

straying away in flight,
Cutting its path;
Away from old roads, straying away,
Cutting a path. (PW, 79–81)

Palestinian literature, like the literatures of other cultures marginalized within the dominant version of world history, by virtue of its current historical situation and determination, is liable to uncritical consideration and identification, fated either to rejection or admission for the very fact of its being "Palestinian." Hanan Mikhail Ashrawi, head of the English department at Birzeit University in the Occupied West Bank, in an article on "The contemporary Palestinian poetry of occupation," signals the danger that threatens to abort the literary history of Palestine.

> It has become almost imperative for any study of this nature to offer a literary "apology" or "defence" in an attempt to justify any shortcomings or literary defects in the subject at hand. After all, the literature is "Palestinian," and unfortunately this national definition has become the rationalization for the lack of any objective study or criticism of the literature which is in itself a source of national pride, a symbol as well as a means of resistance.

Ashrawi goes on to call for a

> ruthless scrutiny of a field that has long been denied its rights to responsible criticism, like a child or a mentally disturbed person who is not held responsible for his actions. Our literature has the right to demand of its critics responsible analysis and evaluation combined with the essential intellectual integrity that other literatures of the world have "enjoyed."

At the same time, however, the critic insists that

> This is not to say that objectivity means a disregard of the conditions – social, political and cultural – within which this

literature was born and is still growing. Nor does it mean a patronizing condescension to a literature of a developing nation on the basis of the logical fallacy that an underdeveloped nation has a literary output which in itself parallels this underdevelopment. Rather through a study of the objective conditions one can come to a better understanding of – and not an apology for – the literary works of the people who are living in these conditions. The Palestinians have been able to meet many challenges in their struggle for existence and the challenge of an honest and constructive criticism is a mere footnote in their long and arduous struggle.[31]

The challenge is formulated in the poems themselves. Like Mahmud Darwish, who finds that he "must reject the roses that spring/From a dictionary or a *diwan*," the poet, according to Samih al-Qassim, must "dip into the depths of the virgin well," and in so doing he warns of the "Woe to the tumbling ivory towers,/And to the captives of the mimics." ("To Najib Mahfuz") Such are the "Aesthetics of the revolution" as presented among the poems contained in the first section of the volume and which announce the meaninglessness of conventional meanings. In their rejection of conventional meanings and the covenanted interpretations of history, the poets of the Palestinian resistance movement also reformulate the chronicles of events. The massacres of Dayr Yassin and Kafr Qassim, the disaster of 1948, the defeat of June 1967, which serve as nodal points within the poetic configurations and commemorate significant events in recent Palestinian history, betray as well an elegiac nostalgia for the idylls of a time past. Jabra Jabra, in "The mouth of the well," remembers Dayr Yassin and the "Mouth of the well,/Where the hands of playful maidens/Met in friendship, pouring/Spring water into the jugs/Amidst merriment and song." For Rashid Husayn, "Jaffa's heart is silent, locked in stone,/And through the streets of heaven passes the funeral of the moon." ("Jaffa") Mahmud Darwish recalls Kafr Qassim, where "Once the olive trees were green," at a time before "They stopped the workers' trucks at the curve of the road." ("Victim number 18") In commemorating the day of Zionist occupation, Fadwa Tuqan asks, "Can it be true that in the season of harvest,/Grain and fruit have

turned to ashes?" ("My sad city") Tawfiq Sayigh addresses Palestine, the land itself: "Is it true that you were young,/And that your wavy hips/Caused seduction among young men?" ("A national hymn")

In poetizing the June War of 1967, however, Salma al-Jayyusi, turning away from this effort to recuperate the past symbolically, writes that "June extends to her a bridge/As though June were a new book, erasing all books before." ("Dearest love II") These commemorative evocations of a past lost to the present, that is, contain more than the nostalgic laments of destitution. They participate in a re-creation of historical significance. As the narrator of an early story by Ghassan Kanafani, "The owl in a distant room," recalls,

> I don't know what day the incident occurred. Even my father has forgotten, as if the ill-omened day were greater than any name or number could accommodate. It was in itself a sign of the time cast into the course of history, and thus people would say, "That happened a month after the day of the massacre."[32]

Following the section entitled "Elegies" in which these poems of commemoration are placed are the poems grouped under the heading "Love of Palestine." In the section "Steadfastness" (*sumūd*), Mahmud Darwish elaborates, in the two poems "My father" and "Awaiting the return," a classical allusion to the Homeric epic of the *Odyssey*, transforming the Greek legend in such a way that it is now Telemachus, the son who has remained behind, who becomes the hero, and not the wandering Odysseus. "Once upon a dream . . . once upon a death," the same poet writes in "Blessed be that which has not come," the longest of the poems which appear in the next section entitled "Resistance." It is from this poem too that the anthology takes its title:

> This is the wedding without an end,
> In a boundless courtyard,
> This is the Palestinian wedding:
> Never will lover reach lover
> Except as martyr . . . or fugitive.
> – What year did this grief begin?
> – It started in that Palestinian year without end. (PW, 201–3)

The final section, entitled "Victory," contains but two poems, the bleak promise of a future still in the making, a future to which the poetry nonetheless contributes its critical share.

The Palestinian Wedding is dedicated to Ghassan Kanafani, who first distinguished the Palestinian poetry being written in Occupied Palestine as "resistance poetry," an attention and recognition acknowledged by Mahmud Darwish in his introduction to a volume of Kanafani's literary critical studies:

> It was Ghassan Kanafani who directed Arab public opinion to the literature of the occupied land. Whatever the exaggerations and imbalance, these are a matter for those who study the material presented by Ghassan, but the term "resistance" was not associated with the poetry until Ghassan applied it, thereby giving the term its special significance.[33]

The ideological exigencies of this poetry, its contemporary urgency and the demands it makes on the conventions of poetics, pose special, indeed perhaps crucial, problems for the literary critic, problems admitted by Kanafani in his own literary study of the "Poetry of resistance in Occupied Palestine 1948–1966:" "There is no academic objectivity to this research. If anything, the study lacks in 'cold objectivity.'" Kanafani, the critic, then goes on to maintain:

> There are those who can bring to a given topic a completely critical capacity. This is not the case for us, however, who are a part of the very question of resistance. Furthermore, the objective conditions inside the occupied land within which this literature developed are so exceptional and uncommon that they do not yield to measured judgements. (LROP, 12)

Like Hanan Ashrawi after him, Kanafani called here for a criticism that would be equal to the poetry, a criticism which must account not only for the poetic values in the verse but for its historical relevance as well, come to terms not only with its ideological persuasion but with its literary significance also, and with the dynamic impetus of the poetry's engagement, at once immediate and symbolically mediated, with a historical reality.

Palestinian poetry, no less than the Palestinian people themselves, is being challenged by the current of events. In the poem "My father" published by Mahmud Darwish in 1966 while he was still living in Israel, the poet had revelled in the steadfastness of a Telemachus:

My father once said:
He who has no homeland
Has no grave on earth;

. . . .And forbade me to leave! (PW, 149)

Sixteen years later, the same poet saw in the departure of Yasser Arafat and the Palestinian fedayeen from Beirut, following the 1982 Israeli invasion of Lebanon and the summer-long siege of that city, the image of Odysseus leaving the windy city for long trials on the Mediterranean waters after the war with the Trojans: "The Palestinian is a new Ulysses, wandering from the Phoenician coast to the Greek shore, and no Arab port to receive him."[34] The poets have responded and continue to respond to the events of the year 1982. Although it is premature to suggest a new anthology in the making, the poems themselves propose new parameters and directions emerging from within the corpus of Palestinian resistance poetry. Mahmud Darwish and Mu'in Basisu, for example, composed together the long poem "Participation from within the siege: letter to an Israeli soldier." Walid al-Halis, the young poet from Gaza, two weeks after the invasion, wrote a poem, entitled simply "Siege" (*al-Hisar*). Dayr Yassin, Kafr Qassim, 1948, 1967, 1982, Sabra and Shatila are crises that punctuate the historical record. Samih al-Qassim composed "Qatr al-nadi" and wrote there "because your passion reminds him of a language that languages have forgotten." Mahmud Darwish's long "Poem in praise of the tall shadow" appeared in the Lebanese newspaper *al-Safir*.

For the poets of the Palestinian resistance, however, the situation looms critical, warranting a rethinking of poetry's role and relevance in the struggle.[35] In an interview given in Spain where

he was attending a conference on literature, Mahmud Darwish responded to his interlocutor's questions:

> I may be a poet, but the tragedy and the amount of Palestinian blood which has been shed is greater by far than any poem can express or even comprehend. The "final act" of Beirut, the slaughter of the Palestinians, it was television that was the quickest and most effective means, more so than poetry, of recording this. It was television that brought the crime into every home, to such an extent that every European actually felt that the crime was being committed in his own bedroom. What I mean to say here is that the Palestinian tragedy is larger than language, any language, even though there are poets who maintain that the Palestinian poet participates in joining the Palestinian issue with the issue of freedom for the Arab.[36]

The poetry of the Palestinian resistance has long challenged the conventions of criticism and thus it is that there too the critics, no less than the poets, feel the crisis. Elias Khouri, upon his return to Beirut in the fall of 1982, wrote in the newspaper *al-Nada'*:

> The critical priority as I understand it is the attempt to situate the literary text in its temporal context. . . . How do you write criticism in a time of upheaval like the Arab time in Lebanon? This very upheaval is what gives to criticism a new significance, a meaning of search and acceptance of temporal emptiness and the disintegration of standards of measurement.
>
> (November, 1982)

A new corpus

The resistance poets in El Salvador, Palestine, Angola, Mozambique, and South Africa, from Baluchistan to Nicaragua, acclaim and herald the possibilities inherent in the separate and collective liberation struggles for transforming the historical record. What Russell Hamilton referred to as the "mnemonic function" of Mozambican poetry, or the "archival" feature of Mau Mau patriotic songs which is crucial to Maina wa Kinyatti's anthology *Thunder from the Mountains*, is theorized by the poets and critics as

integral to the stratagems of resistance poetry. Ernesto Cardenal has described a critical dimension of his own poetic project as *exteriorismo*, providing, that is, a documentary account of the daily historical and historic details, events, and actors of the revolutionary struggle. This *exteriorismo* of Central American poetry finds an important analogue in what Elias Khouri indicates in Palestinian literature as "documentary or realistic poetry," *shi'r waqi'i*. (LM, 251) Together with a new chronology, a new solidarity of popular heroes is emerging out of the poetry of resistance, produced by the resistance struggle and claiming a history of its own. Thus, Octavio Robleto, a Nicaraguan poet, writes in his "Elegy for the guerrilla fighter,"

> The truth is, we knew so little about you:
> a shy kid, a student who wrote poems,
> and of your poetry what's known is even less!
>
> But word of you, your grip on us,
> will grow
> And your words will spread
> like grain in fertile ground. (NR, 193)

And Tomas Borge, one of the founders of the FSLN, will be the occasion in "To Tomas Borge: gone, ceased to be a dream" for Francisco de Asis Fernandez for

> reinventing
> the least and sweetest meanings of the door,
> of the table, of bread,
> raising a clenched fist of unforgettable words:
> Monimbo, Matagalpa, Subtiava, Esteli,
> brother. (NR, 271)

From out of the fragments of Neruda's "body divided," a history interrupted, a culture disrupted, another literary corpus is in the process of constituting itself. The resistance poems are an important part of such a corpus, part of the Third World's challenge to the propagation of western literary conventions negotiated within and between the academies of the United States and Europe. That corpus is characterized by Victor Jara, the Chilean

poet, composer, and singer, who was active not only in the New Chilean Song Movement but in Salvador Allende's Popular Unity campaign as well:

> The cultural invasion is like a leafy tree which prevents us from seeing our own sun, sky and stars. Therefore in order to be able to see the sky above our heads, our task is to cut this tree off at the roots. US imperialism understands very well the magic of communication through music and persists in filling our young people with all sorts of commercial tripe. With professional expertise they have taken certain measures: first, the commercialisation of so-called "protest music"; second, the creation of "idols" of protest music who obey the same rules and suffer the same constraints as the other idols of the consumer music industry – they last a little while and then disappear. Meanwhile they are useful in neutralising the innate spirit of rebellion of young people. The term "protest song" is no longer valid because it is ambiguous and has been misused. I prefer the term "revolutionary song".[37]

Victor Jara was tortured to death in Santiago's National Stadium following the CIA-assisted military coup in September 1973 which assassinated Allende and overthrew his Popular Unity government. Jara's songs, like those of other resistance poets, continue to animate the resistance struggles and national liberation movements. As the Mozambican poet Mutimati Barnabé João wrote in his epic poem "I, the people," published by FRELIMO after independence in 1975:

> I know that I can't think in just one language. (SH, 104)

iii

Narratives of resistance

Without a drop of blood
the long roads would be featureless.

Mahmud Darwish – "The bottom of the town"

"Apocalypse at Solentiname:" historical consequences

In his short story "Apocalypse at Solentiname,"[1] written in 1976, the Argentinian writer Julio Cortazar recounts his visit, in the company of other Latin American writers, to the peasant community of Solentiname established by Nicaraguan Ernesto Cardenal, a priest, a poet, and a member of the FSLN. Solentiname was founded as a contemplative society, modeled along the lines of Thomas Merton's Trappist community in Gethsemane, Kentucky, where Cardenal had once spent several years, and the Nicaraguan village had become famous not only for the dynamic and revolutionary practice of its religion but for the artistic productions of the peasants, paintings illustrating the gospels and their own lives.[2] As a short story, "Apocalypse at Solentiname" differs from the literary standards conventionally applied to works of fiction and stands rather as a documentary challenge to those very standards. These criteria and conventions are adumbrated in the opening paragraph of the text, only to be subverted by subsequent developments in the narrative and the unfolding within

the text of its larger historical consequences. Cortazar begins his story with a press conference held on his arrival in San José:

> It was one of those hot spells and to make things even worse, it all got started right away, a press conference with the usual business, why don't you live in your own country, why was *Blow Up* so different from your short story, do you think a writer must be involved? With things going like that I can see that my final interview will be at the gates of hell and there're sure to be the same questions, and if by chance it's chez Saint Peter it won't be any different: don't you think that you're writing over the heads of the people down there?
>
> (AS, 119–20)

The questions posed to Cortazar by the journalists, questions informed by the concerns, preoccupations, and expectations of the literary critical establishment, are reworked in the story that follows. Traveling by Piper Aztec, jeep, and outboard, the band of writers reaches Solentiname late at night. They are hosted by the peasants and the next morning attend Sunday mass,

> the Solentiname mass in which the peasants and Ernesto and the visiting friends comment together on a chapter of Scripture which that day was Jesus' arrest in the garden, a theme that the people of Solentiname treated as if they were talking about themselves. (AS, 122)

The visitors are also shown the paintings done by members of the community. Before departing for Havana and thence back to Paris, Cortazar photographs for himself a sequence of these paintings, "centering them so that each painting filled the viewer completely." (AS, 123) "Art thief, image smuggler," Cardenal chides him.

The narrator returns to France where he is met at Orly airport by his wife Claudine. He brings with him the various souvenirs of his trip, clippings, handkerchiefs, books, and the rolls of film which Claudine leaves at a shop in the Latin Quarter to be developed. The writer, at home alone one day, views his reproductions on the slide projector.

> You think what you think, it always gets ahead of you and leaves you so far behind; I stupidly told myself that they must have made a mistake at the camera place and given me some other customer's pictures, but the mass then, the children playing on the grass, how then. Nor did my hand obey when I pushed the button and it was an endless sand flat at noon with two or three rusty-roofed sheds, people gathered on the left looking at the bodies laid out face up, their arms open to a naked grey sky; you had to look closely to make out a uniformed group in the background with their backs turned away, the Jeep waiting at the top of a rise. (AS, 125)

In addition to the pictures disclosing massacre and destruction of Nicaraguan villagers by the National Guard under the orders of the dictator Anastasio Somoza, the writer witnesses, projected on the screen in front of him, scenes of arrest and torture in Argentina and the brutal assassination of the El Salvadoran poet Roque Dalton. "I kept on pressing and pressing through waves of bloody faces and parts of bodies and women running and children on a Bolivian or Guatemalan hillside, suddenly the screen filled with mercury and with nothing." (AS, 126) Claudine, who comes in only at the end of the showing and repeats the sequence of slides for herself, sees nothing of those events which the shocked narrator had discerned in the photographic images. In her "blindness" Claudine may resemble the naive reader for whom there is only the text, but she differs markedly from the Argentinian censor. Cortazar's story was banned in his native Argentina, not, as he says, because there was anything in it "that could directly offend the Argentinian junta, but everything is offensive which tells the truth about what is happening in so many Latin American countries." In this article, "Something more than words," which first appeared in 1978 in *Index on Censorship*, Cortazar goes on to explain the perverse circumstances of the relationship between his story and historical events: "This story was sadly prophetic since a year after I wrote it the troops of the dictator Somoza razed and destroyed this marvellous small Christian community."[3]

Implicit in Cortazar's short text, even at the time of its writing, is the resistance writer's demand for a politicization of interpretation

and artistic production, a demand raised against the interviewers' questions posed at the beginning of the story: do you think a writer must be involved? or again, don't you think you're writing over the heads of the people down there? Cortazar does not answer these questions, but reformulates them instead in his own story. According to that story, neither authorial intention nor limits and definitions of a formal nature are capable of containing the meanings of artistic work and production. The narrative, like the images constructed within the narrative, is embedded in a historical process and ideological development. With that implication of the literary text in the historical process, both as recorder of and influence on that process, the question of closure takes on different consequences. Roque Dalton, assassinated in 1975, had been part of the writers' group which visited Solentiname. Sergio Ramirez, however, author of the novel *To Bury Our Fathers*, and who also participated in the excursion, went on to become in 1979 a member of the governing Sandinista executive in Nicaragua. The critic, the viewer, like the artist, is, as Cortazar's story reveals, necessarily, inescapably involved in the historical process, an involvement exhibited by the dynamics of the works themselves. The narrative works of resistance literature directly confront the critic and the artist with the responsibilities of that involvement.

Narrative, unlike poetry perhaps, provides a more developed historical analysis of the circumstances of economic, political, and cultural domination and repression and through that analysis raises a systematic and concerted challenge to the imposed chronology of what Frederic Jameson has called "master narratives," ideological paradigms which contain within their plots a predetermined ending. The use by Third World resistance writers of the novel form as it has developed within the western literary tradition both appropriates and challenges the historical and historicizing presuppositions, the narrative conclusions, implicated within the western tradition and its development. According to Jameson,

> In its emergent strong form a genre is essentially a socio-symbolic message, or, in other terms, that form is immanently and intrinsically an ideology in its own right. When such forms

> are reappropriated and refashioned in quite different social and cultural contexts, this message persists and must be functionally reckoned into the new form . . . the ideology of the form itself, thus sedimented, persists into the latter, more complex structure, as a generic message which coexists – either as a contradiction or, on the other hand, as a mediatory or harmonizing mechanism – with elements from later stages.
>
> (PU, 141)

The resistance novels seek different historical endings and these endings are already implicit, contained within the narrative analysis and construction of the conditions and problematic of the historical situation itself. Cortazar's storied document of the "apocalypse at Solentiname" thus presents in its reading of the images from Solentiname the necessary conditions for subsequent resistance to the situation of repression and terror exercised by the hegemonic powers of the First World and its collaborators in the Third World. The story is in the end less apocalypse than it is history, a history, however, which must be taken, seized, appropriated on radically altered terms. The image, like the images of Solentiname, requires its own historicization. The necessity of such historicization which would empower the images is only implied in the conclusion to Ernesto Cardenal's poem, "The meaning of Solentiname," written following the destruction in 1977 of the peasants' contemplative community:

> Solentiname
> was like a paradise
> but in Nicaragua
> paradise is not yet possible.
> I have given no thought
> to the reconstruction of our little community
> of Solentiname.
> I think of the far more important task,
> the task for us all:
> the reconstruction of the whole country. (NR, 253)

On 12 October 1977, as part of the FSLN planned attack on National Guard targets, a small group of combatants had left

Cardenal's community to launch an assault on the San Carlos barracks near the Costa Rican border. In the weeks preceding the attack intensive military training had been organized within Solentiname. According to one of the participants, "the Nicaraguan people were involved in a fight against injustice, and to use violence was to be willing to give your life for the liberation of Nicaragua; it was a violence of love. And so, many decided to take up arms."[4]

Cortazar's short story provides a kind of model for the demands made by resistance narratives more generally on their readers, both those readers who belong to the same society which produced the narratives and readers conditioned by a different set of historical circumstances. According to Cortazar,

> It is true that we writers always find a way of writing, and even publishing, but on the other side of the wall there are the readers who cannot read without taking risks; on the other side the people whose only source of information is the official one; on the other side there is a generation of children and adolescents who, as in the case of Chile, are "educated" to become perfect fascists, automatic defenders of the big words that disguise reality: fatherland, national security, discipline.
>
> (SMW, 173)

Essential then to the narratives of resistance is the demand they make on the reader in their historical referencing and the burden of historical knowledge such referencing enjoins.

Each of the novels discussed in this chapter insists on its own historical specificity and the significance of the events which it describes, whether the Soweto riots of 1976, the Lebanese civil war, the Arab-Israeli war of 1948, El Salvador's death squads, or Nicaragua's liberation struggle of fifty years. It is important too that all of these novels, at the time when they were first published, were available only with difficulty to readers who could most identify with the scenario they represented. Many of Ghassan Kanafani's works, for example, are forbidden in the Israeli-occupied territories of the West Bank and Gaza; like "Apocalypse at Solentiname," *To Bury Our Fathers*, *One Day of Life*, and *A Ride on the Whirlwind* were banned in their authors'

own countries; and *Sitt Marie Rose* was written not in Arabic but in French by a Lebanese woman living in Paris. The demand then is not only for access to power, but for the very "permission to narrate," as Edward Said formulated the question in his review of a series of western studies on the Palestine question.[5] The narration, as exhibited in these five novels, is one which requires both historical referencing and a politicized interpretation and reading. It furthermore expands the formal criteria of closure and continuity which characterize the ideology of traditional plots and subjects the images and symbols of tradition to analytical inquiry.

Narrative and symbol

Carlos Fuentes, in his introduction to Omar Cabezas' autobiographical account of his own "making of a Sandinista," *Fire from the Mountain*, signals an important distinction between poetry and narrative as formal and ideological categories when he points out

> the danger [that] is always there, in this portrait as in all portraits, of the revolution and of the *guerrillero* – the danger of the lyrical, the danger of the slogan posing as the lyrical, the danger of the lyrical disguising the historicity of the revolution.[6]

The difference indicated by Fuentes between the poetic and the narrative discourses is one which Mikhail Bakhtin, writing in the Soviet Union in the 1930s, had elaborated in his essay "Discourse in the novel:"

> If the art of poetry, as a utopian philosophy of genres, gives rise to the conception of a purely poetic, extrahistorical language, a language far removed from the petty rounds of everyday life, a language of the gods – then it must be said that the art of prose is close to a conception of language as historically concrete and living things. The prose art presumes a deliberate feeling for the historical and social concreteness of living discourse, as well as its relativity, a feeling for its participation in historical

> becoming and in social struggle; it deals with discourse that is still warm from that struggle and hostility, as yet unresolved and still fraught with hostile intentions and accents; prose art finds discourse in this state and subjects it to the dynamic unity of its own style.[7]

The difference between poetry and narrative will have a significant role to play in the composition of novels and other narrative genres, such as the memoir, by Third World writers of resistance literature. While poetry and the poems of organized resistance movements struggle to preserve and even to redefine for the given historical moment the cultural images which underwrite collective action, military as well as ideological, of a people seeking to liberate themselves from the forces of oppression, narrative by contrast analyzes the past, including the symbolic heritage, in order to open up the possibilities of the future. The Kenyan writer Ngugi wa Thiong'o, for example, uses Mau Mau symbolism and Gikuyu poetry in the construction of his novel *Devil on the Cross* written while he was in prison in 1979.[8] In this novel of neo-colonial Kenya, which was originally composed in Gikuyu and later translated by the author, Ngugi reconstructs the struggle of the past in such a way that it comes again to play a role in the construction of a new Kenya. Gatuiria is a professor of musicology at the university who aspires to compose for his country a new national anthem. That anthem, however, is not, according to the novel, enough. Actions, such as that taken by Wariinga, the novel's heroine and the fiancée of Gatuiria, when at the end she kills the thieves and robbers, the family of Gatuiria, are still necessary.

Both tasks are requisite. As Carlos Fuentes writes, referring specifically to the Nicaraguan revolution but with implications for liberation struggles throughout the world, "We must go forward, because the present is unjust and insufferable, but we cannot kill the past in doing so, for the past is our identity, and without our identity we are nothing." (FFM, ix) Similarly Sarah Graham-Brown, in her photographic essay on the history of the Palestinian people, *Palestinians and Their Society 1880–1946*, reminds the reader of the complicated, even paradoxical, role played by the past in determining conscious resistance strategies for the present and the future.

> Looking at pictures of a society which has since been destroyed or dispersed is liable to enhance the aura of nostalgia which attaches to dusty photographs dug out of trunks and attics. The Palestinians (without the aid of photographs) have tenaciously preserved the memory of that past, which acts as a form of reinforcement in an unenviable present and a strong assertion of national and personal identity.
>
> However, for a historian, however sympathetic, the temptation to both kinds of nostalgia needs to be resisted, because "the past" can then be made to seem like a single unchanging entity instead of a constantly changing succession of events and processes. Furthermore, any kind of nostalgia invites the suspension of critical judgement.[9]

Photographs, like the symbols and images of poetry and lyricism, while they preserve the memories and genealogical existence of a culture and a heritage, nonetheless stop short of disclosing the context within which they are implicated. Like the Solentiname peasants' paintings, the images require their historicizing dimension in order to expose fully the parameters of the resistance struggle. Without that dimension, the symbols themselves are endangered by a fetishizing appropriation of nostalgia and lament seeking to recover a past rather than to prepare a future. Robert Stone, a Jewish writer from New York visiting the Israeli-occupied West Bank, referred to such a phenomenon as the "pornography of symbolism." The reference is reported by Raja Shehadeh, the West Bank lawyer whom Stone visited in the summer of 1980:

> Robert used an analogy with pornography and love to explain what he meant. When you are exiled from your land, he said, you begin like a pornographer, to think about it in symbols. You articulate your love for your land, in its absence, and in the process transform it into something else.
>
> "We Jews had 2,000 years in which to become expert pornographers with a highly symbol-wrought, intellectualized yearning for this land – totally devoid of any memories or images of what it really looks like. And when Jews came to settle here this century, they saw the land through these

symbols. Think of the almost mystical power that names of places here have for many Zionists," Robert said. "As for what it really looked like, they tried to transform it into the kinds of landscape they left in Europe.

"Perhaps second- and third-generation Israeli farmers have lost the pornographer's symbolism," he continued, "but the Gush Emunin people who are spilling on to the West Bank have renewed it – ranting and raving over every stick and stone in a land they never knew. It is like falling in love with an image of a woman, and then, when meeting her, being excited not by what is there but by what her image has come to signify to you. You stare at her, gloating, without really seeing her, let alone loving her."[10]

The tension between symbol and narrative is exhibited again in a poem entitled "The path of affection," included in Elmessiri's anthology *The Palestinian Wedding*. In this poem Layla Allush, a Palestinian poetess, describes the return to Haifa of one of its former inhabitants following twenty years of separation from the city. The return takes place, according to the poem, "Along the amazing road drawn from the throat of recent dates,/And the amazing road drawn from the earrings of the century." (PW, 173–5) Said S., the main character of Ghassan Kanafani's short novel *Return to Haifa*, written in 1969, likewise, upon the opening of the borders in 1967 between Israel and the newly occupied territories, returned to Haifa. Said, however, arrived in the city to find his home now inhabited by Jewish immigrants from Europe and his long-lost son a recruit in the Israeli army. In this, Said, of Kanafani's narrative, differs from the traveller into history of Allush's poem who discovers an essential eternity transcending historical change projected in the city of Haifa.

Everything is Arab despite the change of tongue,
Despite the trucks, the cars and the carlights,
Despite all the hybrid green and blue signs.
All the poplars and my ancestors' solemn orchards
Were, I swear, smiling at me with Arab affection.

The difference between Allush's poem and Kanafani's story is not only a generic one, the literary critical difference between

lyric and narrative. It is ultimately an ideological difference, located here in the contradictory relationships posited in the two works to the demands of historical exigencies. Whereas Allush in her poem seeks recourse in transcendence, the perdurance of a hypothetical eternal, Kanafani elicits from the ineluctable relentlessness of the historical situation the very possibilities immanent in that same situation for change.

If resistance poetry challenged the dominant and hegemonic discourse of an occupying or colonizing power by attacking the symbolic foundations of that power and erecting symbolic structures of its own – the banners of resistance and struggle, for example, such as the ANC flag which waves in Barry Feinberg's poem "Surprisingly singing" – resistance narratives go further still in analyzing the relations of power which sustain the system of domination and exploitation. Where symbols and images often fail to elucidate the implicit power structures of a given historical conjuncture, the discourse of narrative is capable of exposing these structures, even, eventually, of realigning them, of redressing the imbalance. Sarah Graham-Brown reminds the photography connoisseur that "Brecht once pointed out that a photograph of the Krupp works (the vast German steel empire) revealed virtually nothing about its organisation." She goes on to maintain that

> There are certain areas quite basic to historical narrative and interpretation which photographs do not reveal, or reveal only by association. Power relationships, for instance, are only obvious when physical coercion is being used – a father beating his child, an overseer driving slave labourers, a policeman dragging away a demonstrator, a tank being driven through curfewed streets. Otherwise visual evidence of power and authority is largely symbolic. (PTS, 19)

Resistance narratives by contrast display the historical and social context which produced such symbols or images. Their analysis and documentation of the cultural and ideological conditions of their plot, characters, and setting also challenge certain literary conventions which have been sustained through the history of the classical novel. Although, like western modern and

postmodern novelists, the writers of resistance narrative experiment with structures of chronology and temporal continuity, such experimentation is more than formal virtuosity. It is part of their historical challenge, their demand for an access to history which necessitates a radical rewriting of the historiographical version of the past which gives prominence of place to a western calendar of events. It makes less sense, for example, to refer to the post-World War Two Arabic novel than to post-1948 Arabic writing. The *nakbah*, or disaster, of 1948 and the creation of the state of Israel was decisive to Arabic thought and intellectual activity, as was the year 1967 which has been designated the year of the setback, or *naksah*. Historical and political events together with literary periodization are being reworked in these narratives and the formal experimentation which characterizes them, the manipulation of structures of plot, character, and setting, resonate within the social structures of the resistance movements themselves and the collective and popular needs to which they respond. Especially prominent in these works, which combine "fiction" with documentary, are the issues of gender, race, and class and each of the novels discussed here can be seen to locate its social and ideological analysis around one or more of these questions.

On Men and Guns: Palestine

The conventional and stereotyped symbols most commonly associated with Palestinians are those of the UNRWA ration cards (United Nations Relief and Works Agency established in 1950 to aid Palestinian refugees) on the one hand, betokening pathos and helplessness, and Soviet-made Kalashnikov rifles, on the other, emblems of bravado and daring. These icons are submitted to a critical analysis by Ghassan Kanafani in his "Mansur stories," a sequence of four tales, written in 1965 and included in the collection of Kanafani's stories entitled *On Men and Guns*.[11] In the course of the stories, however, Kanafani not only scrutinizes the symbolic sway of the gun, or the *bunduqiyya*, in contemporary Palestinian culture and iconography but challenges as well the conventional narrative paradigm which has long provided a traditional formula for "heroism." Carlos Fuentes locates that

paradigm within the development of the classic bourgeois European novel when he writes that:

> Nothing is more difficult than for a hero to tell of his or her own heroism. The wry and cynical *arrivistes* of social romanticism – Rastignac, Sorel, Becky Sharp – do not pretend to anything more heroical than ambition, quick wit, and an acceptance of egotism. Dostoevsky's nihilistic counterheroes set out to prove that man can be his own worst enemy and that they prefer unhappiness. Kafka and Beckett tell us that now the hero of the bourgeois world is faceless but not dead, and that he deserves compassion and imagination. The revolutionary hero, too often, has simply illustrated the fairy-tale truth of boy-meets-rifle before settling down to the eternal domestic triangle between two Stakhanovites and a tractor. (FFM, xi)

Together with the other stories in the volume, Kanafani's Mansur stories examine the narrative of history implied in the emergence of an organized resistance movement.

The four Mansur stories are joined together only by the presence in each of them of the young boy Mansur, and are otherwise undistinguished as a coherent entity with predetermined beginning and end from the rest of the collection. Each of the tales, "The child borrows his uncle's gun and goes east to Safad," "Doctor Qassim talks to Eva about Mansur who has arrived in Safad," "Abu al-Hassan ambushes an English car," and "The child, his father and the gun go to the citadel at Jaddin," relates the adventures of Mansur and his participation in the first Arab-Israeli war centered around the creation of the Israeli state in 1948. Mansur must find someone from whom he can borrow a gun in order to join the battle being waged by the villagers at Safad. Guns, however, are the possessions of adults, his father, his uncle, the older men of the villages, and Mansur is subject to their authority. Whereas his father is not interested in his ideals of resistance and patriotism, Mansur's uncle, Abu al-Hassan, tells him simply that he is too young, that he is just a child. Eventually, however, Abu al-Hassan relents and with his aged gun Mansur joins the skirmish at Safad. It is then, when Mansur returns the rifle to his uncle, that Abu al-Hassan himself participates in an

attack on a British army vehicle. Later still Mansur will discover his father at the site of the struggle with the Jewish forces over the citadel at Jaddin, where he has gone with a weapon borrowed from Hajj Abbas, who has negotiated a financial deal with the old man. Doctor Qassim, Mansur's older brother, meanwhile is having breakfast with Eva, a Jewish girl in Haifa.

In telling the story of the child Mansur's role in the 1948 struggle, Kanafani narrates the larger political and social conflicts created within the Palestinian society by the political and military pressures from outside. According to Ann Lesch, a political historian of Palestine under the British Mandate,

> The generational differences within the Arab political leadership played an important political role. The older politicians tended to be more conciliatory, more willing to work within legal channels than the young men, [but] the impact of the generational division was reduced by the Arabs' deferential culture. Respect for one's father and for an elder statesman who consulted the other leaders and expressed the general consensus remained powerful forces, drawing together the differing drives of young and old in a politically effective manner.[12]

At the same time, then, that the social order of Palestinian life is being attacked by foreign forces, the traditional structures of authority serve to sustain vital elements of the sense of community and solidarity. The authoritative structures, however, are being radically modified by the forces of circumstance and the political coming of age of the child. When Mansur reaches the citadel at Jaddin, his second expedition following the skirmish at Safad, he finds his father present there in the circle of armed men. In the moment of retreat, however, Abu Qassim is left behind. It is Mansur who returns for him, only to find him fatally wounded.

> Mansur stood in the wet emptiness watching his father slowly dying, impotent and unmoving except for the deep throbbing which shook him. His veins were like taut wires bulging from his hands and extending around the torso of the rifle. Finally

> they all began to blur together: the tree, the man and the rifle, from behind the darkness of the angry rain, and through his tears. They were not together. There was only the quiet corpse. (PC, 61)

In these four stories, which begin with Mansur's surreptitious departure from the family home to join the nascent resistance efforts and conclude with the vision of his dying father, the gun, the *bunduqiyya*, plays a prominently significant role. Indeed the relationship between child and gun, or in Fuentes' words, "boy-meets-rifle," is the structuring model of the stories. Rather than being a symbolic presence, however, an icon of the Palestinian armed struggle endowed with transcendent value, the gun participates in a complicated system of exchange and circulation. That system as it is deployed in the course of events in the stories exhibits not only the hierarchical structures of authority within traditional Palestinian society, between father and son, merchant and peasant, town and village, but their potential transformation as well. With the circulation of guns, for there is more than just one weapon involved, there emerges a collective solidarity, the beginnings of an organized resistance movement, based on bonds of affiliation rather than on the ties of filiation and authority.

The child Mansur, in each of his encounters, challenges the existing sources of authority: his father, his elders, the traditional leadership. By 1948, in fact, after thirty years of repressive British Mandate rule in Palestine and continued Zionist immigration and settlement of the land, that older and established leadership of the *'ayan* or notables, the landholders, merchants, and politicians, had been substantially discredited. Its belief in the possibility of a negotiated solution, diplomacy, and reform had proven to be delusory and a failure. The most significant popular revolt and general strike during that period, while absentee landlords continued to sell their property to Jewish entrepreneurs and settlers, had been led and sustained by peasants and workers from 1936 to 1939.[13] With the violent crushing of that revolt by British forces, followed by World War II and its aftermath, there was little concerted resistance activity from the Arabs in Palestine until the British declared their intention to withdraw from the mandated territories and the United Nations Partition Plan

for the area was announced in November of 1947. Zionist military and terrorist activity, designed to guarantee still more territory for the Israeli state than that actually granted by the UN plan, provoked the still uncoordinated attempts at organized resistance in which Mansur participates at Safad and again at Jaddin.

Mansur's example of resistance is met with violent paternal disapproval when the child returns from his journey to Safad.

> His father shouted: "Turn around and talk to me face to face, you ingrate of a son."
>
> Mansur turned around and looked at his father, directly into his angry eyes. His father came a step forward, and it was clear that he was going to have to use his hands. The next minute the blow which he had been expecting landed, but Mansur didn't move. When his mother moved to block the way between him and his father, he gently pushed her away from in front of him. Abu Qassim shouted again: "Say something."
>
> Mansur licked his lips and felt a sweet warm taste. Nonetheless he didn't raise his hand to his mouth to see whether or not it had begun to bleed, but went on looking his father straight in the eye.
>
> "If you're here and Qassim is in Haifa, one of us three had to go to Safad."
>
> "Are you trying to sell me some kind of patriotism, you son of sin?" (PC, 40)

That disapproval, however, later turns to emulation when Abu Qassim joins the resistance at Jaddin, and the hierarchical father-son relationship is reversed. Nonetheless, Abu Qassim's motives remain questionable within the story's ideological framework. It is from Hajj Abbas that Mansur's father has acquired his gun for one pound a day, and with an additional promise to the lender of a forfeiture of a hundred pounds, payable in olives if necessary, should the gun be lost or damaged. This same Hajj Abbas tells Mansur that his father has joined the fighters only in order to acquire a weapon from the stockpile in the citadel's arsenal, a rifle, that is, which he can give to Mansur on his wedding day. Already Abu Qassim, Mansur's father, had sold some of his olive

trees to finance his oldest son's medical education at the American University of Beirut.

> Just so that people would one day call him "Doctor," his father had sold a section of olive trees and each year set aside a certain number of containers of olive oil which were then sold in order to defray the cost of books and microscopes for Doctor Qassim. (PC, 21)

Those same olive trees, symbols of Palestine, on which Tawfiq Zayyad carved the history of the land in his poem "On the trunk of an olive tree," are here become part of the social analysis of Palestinian culture and traditions and their disintegration. The gun which Abu Qassim thus acquires from Hajj Abbas is shown in the historical narrative of the stories to be part of the dissolution of village and communal structures, even if hierarchical, and the emergence of a nascent capitalism in Palestinian society. The "fairy-tale truth" of "boy-meets-rifle" is relocated within an ideological analysis of the parameters of such an encounter.

Ali Khalili, a Palestinian writer and critic, and editor of *Al-Fajr al-Adabi*, the literary journal of the East Jerusalem newspaper *Al-Fajr*, has insisted on the centrality of the class struggle to the popular Palestinian folktale. In his study, *The Palestinian Hero in the Popular Folktale*, Khalili further insists on the impact of world capitalism on Palestinian society and maintains that

> The Zionist movement, which was allied with other settler-colonial movements, was not concerned merely with establishing economic domination for the sake of general power and acquiring Palestinian raw materials, but aimed to create a Jewish political and national entity in Palestine. It is this fact which gives class relations in Palestine their special historical character.[14]

Kanafani, who was a member of and spokesman for the Marxist-Leninist Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) led by George Habash, presents Mansur's participation in the resistance not only as a national liberation struggle but as a class struggle as well. The gun in these stories, far from being a fetishized or

symbolic object, serves rather as a means to analyze the social relations and structures of power and exploitation, both internal and external, of Palestinian society. It serves too as a means to the transformation of those social relations, from filiation to affiliation. The gun is but a weapon, like the stories themselves, in the historical process which moves through armed struggle for national liberation to social revolution.

To Bury Our Fathers: Nicaragua

The relationship between father and son that figures prominently in Kanafani's Mansur stories and which organizes the transition from a communal village structure based on ties of filiation to a revolutionary order held together by bonds of affiliation is again significant in the novel *To Bury Our Fathers* by the Nicaraguan writer Sergio Ramirez.[15] Like the Mansur stories too, Ramirez' novel, which was written during the novelist's exile in West Berlin from 1973 to 1975 and was first published in Caracas in 1977, insists on its historicity, its place in a specific historical configuration. The novel's series of intersecting and overlapping plots spans the period from the 1920s and 1930s with Sandino's early armed resistance to the Nicaraguan dictatorship and US military intervention in the affairs of that country, up to the events of 1961 just preceding the formal establishment of the FSLN and the beginning of an organized Nicaraguan resistance movement. More even than the poetic practice of *exteriorismo* of Ernesto Cardenal, the novel analyzes the manifold social forces which contributed to the emergence of the resistance movement. Not only documentary evidence, the chronological reconstruction of events to set the historical record straight, but the contentious interplay of political, ideological, social, and personal structures are developed in the novel's complicated narrative.

To Bury Our Fathers consists of six major plot lines which are intermittently but progressively developed in each of the ten chapters of the book, which is further divided into two parts plus an epilogue. The various plots, which are announced at the beginning of the work, represent different historical moments: in one of the story lines, for example, Colonel Catalino Lopez of the National Guard is kidnapped by the three men, Taleno, Jilguero,

and Indio (otherwise known as Lazaro), whereas in another development this same Colonel Lopez recalls his earlier participation in the fight against Sandino. Taleno, from the kidnap story, remembers in still another sequence his childhood spent roaming the countryside with his father and brother and his years in the military academy and as aide to Somoza before defecting and joining the opposition. Jilguero, another of the kidnappers, had once been a member of the musical trio Los Caballeros, and Pastorita and Chepito from La Copacabana, where the group had performed, entertain each other with stories of the trio's members and their activities. Jilguero, meantime pursued in the mountains by the National Guard, recollects the story of his grandfather who was defrauded of his presidential election in the same way that his sister was robbed of her victory in the Miss Nicaragua competition. Both losses came as a result of pressure and machinations from the dictatorship and its lackeys. Finally, Indio's body is brought back from Guatemala to Leon for burial by his son Bolivar. The text of the novel concludes with a brief chronology of some of the major incidents.

With its multiple plots, traversing generations and national boundaries, and its many characters speaking to each other and about themselves and their familial, social, and political situations, Ramirez' novel displays a panoramic vision of the contradictions riddling Nicaraguan society in the first half of this century. The effect of the "polyphonic" diversity is to produce what Bakhtin has called the "decentralizing of the verbal-ideological world that finds expression in the novel [and which] begins by presuming fundamentally differentiated social groups, which exist in an intense and vital interaction with other social groups." According to Bakhtin, furthermore,

> A sealed-off interest group, caste or class, existing within an internally unitary and unchanging core of its own, cannot serve as socially productive soil for the development of the novel unless it becomes riddled with decay or shifted somehow from its state of internal balance and self-sufficiency. (DN, 368)

To Bury Our Fathers exposes the failure of the dictatorship of Somoza, known in the novel only as *el hombre*, that "sealed-off interest group, caste or class," to maintain systematic control

over the popular chorus of oppositional elements within the society, even within Somoza's own National Guard. Both Taleno and Indio, for example, are former members of the military who eventually come to participate in the plot against the government. The necessity of electoral fraud to maintain his presidency furthermore underscores the precariousness of the regime which buttressed itself with US marines and dollars. The authoritarian discourse of the regime is thus revealed as already subverted from within the social order and the disarray of the novel's plots and narrative lines is determined by that very social disorder of Nicaraguan society and the confusion of its members in the decades just preceding organized resistance.

The polyphony of the novel occurs not only between the different voices which speak through the events of the narrative but within a given voice as well, and the psychology of the characters is given a social and political dimension. Raul, for example, one of the members of Los Caballeros, has joined the guerrillas. Following a clash with the National Guard he is taken prisoner and tried by a military tribunal. On the stand he tells two stories for himself and for the reader. Only one of the stories is for the tribunal, the other is the story he would have told had he been able to see his comrades at La Copacabana:

> You want to hear what took place from the moment we were attacked by the Honduran Army in El Chaparral? The prosecutor waves at him impatiently with the legal briefs in his right hand, and begs the defendant to begin his statement without further delay. Raul cups the microphone as though trying to hatch it with the warmth of his hands, and declares that while they were camping on the night of 24 June 1959 in a place known as El Chaparral in Honduras, approximately eight kilometres from the border, the two columns of about thirty men each who at dawn on the following morning were intending to invade Nicaragua, were taken by surprise by the units of the Honduran Army who had surrounded them. They were forced into a gun battle in which they were in a very unfavourable position, so that by daylight both of the columns had been virtually wiped out, with many dead and wounded, and that the survivors had been called upon to surrender.

> And if Pastorita had wanted to know what had been the best time for them in Honduras, he would have replied at once that it was while the Caballeros del Ritmo were playing at the Lincoln Hotel. They were earning well, and got their dinner and even highballs free; Captain Taleno had stood surety on a pair of red dinner jackets with fancy lapels, so they looked like real artistes. (TBOF, 167–8)

The guerrillas of El Chaparral, where an attack and massacre occurred, were precursors of the FSLN which would be formed two years later. The FJD or Democratic Youth Front which trained these fighters included among its members the poet Rigoberto Lopez Perez who in 1956 had assassinated Somoza Garcia. The first guerrilla column of the FSLN was later named after him. The two stories told by Raul, however, merge as one, recounting together his personal history as an active agent within the historical process of Nicaragua's revolution. The most trivial pastimes of people's daily lives are intimately and publicly associated with resistance activities. The narrative style of *To Bury Our Fathers* insists on that interaction again when over a game of checkers the friends at La Copacabana hear the story of Carlos's execution:

> "Why are you laughing?" the colonel asked, getting annoyed; and Raul sweeps all the pieces from the chequerboard. "Because I'm no coward, I'm ready to die," and Carlos walked a few steps toward the hole, still facing the lights; the pit is the table now, and Carlos a token pushed to the edge of the old tattered board where the black and white squares have almost completely faded away. The other prisoners did not move or say a word. The colonel ordered one of the conscripts to step forward out of the darkness, and the soldier lifted his submachine gun to shoot. (TBOF, 76)

Formal experimentation is in fact characteristic of these "resistance narratives." That experimentation, however, proposes an extension of the novelistic concerns beyond the formal limitations of the work itself and imposes historical demands and responsibilities on a reader from which he or she, especially in the United States which could always afford such self-dispensations, had

been excused by various versions of formalist criticism. The value of the New Criticism, for example, has been and continues to be seen by some as a "god-send for classroom purposes: there was no need for background knowledge; one could concentrate on short and therefore manageable texts with the tacit acceptance of the reader's own background as sufficient context."[16] Such a "god-send," however, for the classrooms of the dominant western pedagogical institutions is part of hegemonic cultural practices which deny consequential access to historical development to those parts of the world which the west continues to exploit to its own ends.

The experimentation of resistance novels therefore requires of the readers from both First and Third Worlds a historical background and ideological awareness which certain schools of criticism had thought to have dispensed with. Novels like Fernando Alegria's *The Chilean Spring*,[17] written in 1975 and set in the days immediately leading up to the CIA-sponsored overthrow in 1973 of Chile's Allende government, transform personal history into historical narrative and analysis. Using the documentary evidence provided by the notebooks and letters of the journalist–photographer Christian, Alegria presents his own study of the individual's transformation from a psychological, subjective entity into a historical agent participating in a collective drama. So too the Chilean writer Antonio Skarmeta's novel *The Insurrection*[18] reworks the privatized intimacy of epistolary form to describe the popular solidarity behind the Nicaraguan resistance in Leon. From out of the formal confusion and disarray of *To Bury Our Fathers*, there appears a new historicity, a new Nicaraguan history: that of the Sandinista resistance and the revolution.

The resistance is shown in the novel to be born out of an active engagement with the past: "to bury our fathers." Carlos and Jilguero bury their father, a cancerous old man, himself the son of Rosales who had been cheated of his electoral victory. Taleno, for his part, is disowned by his father, who has become an infatuated sycophant of *el hombre*. And in the end young Bolivar travels to Guatemala to bring back the body of Indio, his father, a member of the resistance who had had his own "saints' calendar" when he named his children: Bolivar, Bardo Ruben Dario, and Heroina Rafaela Herrera. (TBOF, 174–5) *To Bury Our Fathers*

presents the contradictions within Nicaraguan society which were to make possible the creation of a new order, a "new man" in Che Guevara's words. Che's pilot while he was in Africa described that "new man" to Ernesto Cardenal during the poet's visit to Cuba:

> He would say: "Who has said that Marxism has no soul?" The most important thing was the creation of the new man, the man of the twenty-first century. This new man was the man of solidarity, devoted to others. In capitalist society the people disintegrated, then scattered in all directions like fragments of a grenade. The formation of a new conscience in man was for him more important than production. A merely economic socialism, without this new conscience, did not interest him, he said. Markets, money, material interests, these were the categories of the old society. The psychological incentives for production should not be material stimuli but moral stimuli. Labor should not be sold like merchandise but offered as a gift to the community. The happiness of all men was the ideal of the revolutionary. Che was the prototype of this new man. He was very superior to other men but he did not feel himself superior. He thought that everyone was like him, and he was troubled when he saw that they were not. He did not want to have qualities that other people did not have. He had no vanity.[19]

Sergio Ramirez, author of *To Bury Our Fathers*, was included by Cortazar in the group which visited Cardenal's community at Solentiname. In 1977, he was a member of *Los Duce*, the "group of twelve," all prominent professionals and civilians, who announced in the Nicaraguan newspaper *La Prensa* their active support for the FSLN and its struggle against Somoza's dictatorship. In 1978 he returned to Nicaragua from exile and is today a member of the Sandinista government. His novel ends in 1961 with Pastorita announcing: "'Los Caballeros are a thing of the past.' 'That's the way it goes,' Chepito calls back. 'At least they have left you memories.'" The novel itself, however, shows the link between the popular culture of Los Caballeros and the popular resistance of the FSLN. Los Caballeros had prepared the ground for the FSLN, which was founded in 1961 in Tegucigalpa,

capital of Honduras, by Carlos Fonseca Amador, Tomas Borge, and Silvio Mayorga.

One Day of Life: El Salvador

Edward S. Herman, in his report on state terrorism on an international scale, *The Real Terror Network*, cites a study of Ivna Gusmao and Alan Benjamin which found that in the

> *New York Times* 1980 coverage of El Salvador . . . 60% of the attributed sources represented the official government viewpoint, and that, although the majority of the victims of violence in El Salvador have been peasants, the *New York Times* quoted only two peasants in 75 articles on that country.[20]

Resistance narratives, embedded as they are in the historical and material conditions of their production and given furthermore the allegiances and active participation of their authors, often on the front lines, in the political events of their countries, testify to the nature of the struggle for liberation as it is enacted behind the dissembling statistics of western media coverage and official government reports. The polyphony of these novels, Bakhtin's "heteroglossia," betrays their manifold role as historical documents, ideological analyses and visions of future possibilities produced out of the contemporary struggle against oppression. They challenge the very effort to isolate literature and literary works from other "spheres of influence" which has characterized much of western literary criticism and practice. The resistance narrative is not only a document, it is also an indictment.

One Day of Life,[21] written in 1980 (and thus contemporaneous with the seventy-five *New York Times* articles on El Salvador that year) by Manlio Argueta, the El Salvadoran writer living in exile in Costa Rica, presents itself as one woman's story of the death of her husband at the hands of El Salvador's "death squads." Like Kanafani's Mansur stories and *To Bury Our Fathers*, it reworks narrative time and historical determinism in such a way as to present a critique of the social order of terror and repression holding sway in that country. Lupe's story, however, is the story of her people as well, and through her narrative the voices of

other individuals, of children, the wives, even of the authorities, also find expression as the different positions struggle with and against each other. The multiple perspectives in the novel serve both to undermine the conventions of authority and authorship and also to give voice to the people who have long been deprived of the right to speak for themselves.

Guadalupe Fuentes, or Lupe as she is called, is an older woman, an El Salvadoran peasant. Her son-in-law, husband of her daughter Maria Pia, has been "disappeared" by the El Salvadoran authorities. Her granddaughter has joined the demonstrators at the government's Agricultural Development Bank and participated in the occupation of San Salvador's cathedral. Lupe's husband José, who has always told her "that you must give drink to whoever is thirsty," (ODL, 103) has joined the peasant federation and given his support to the rebels who are fighting against the repressive government. He often spends the days in the hills hiding from the soldiers who prowl the countryside in search of rebels and rebel sympathizers. "One day," the day which frames the narrative, Lupe and her granddaughter Adolfina are asked by the soldiers to identify the body of a man which has been found in the road nearby. Knowing all too well the consequences of such an identification, Lupe stares into the one eye left in the bloodied remains of her dying husband's face, and denies to the soldiers that she has ever seen the man.

> I saw there was no other way out. And that's why you opened your eye when I denied you, because I had already done the most difficult thing. I took it as a greeting, as if you were saying, "Thank you, Lupe," with that glance from your coffee-colored eye that had remained shut, shut by the same blood that bathed your head; while your other eye had been put out forever, hanging over your nose. I wondered how you managed to stay conscious. And the two men were holding you by your clothes from behind, as if you were a scarecrow. (ODL, 192)

Lupe and Adolfina, like the other characters in the novel, are participants in a historical process. The one day in her life of which the novel is made contains multiple historical references to the contemporary political situation in El Salvador, the material

and ideological conditions which determine Lupe's choice to deny her husband to the soldiers of the "death squad." "All of a sudden," for example, as Lupe explains,

> the priests began to change. They started getting us into cooperatives. To help each other, to share profits. . . . After a congress was held I don't know where, as we were told by the young priests who began coming to Chalate and who visited our own house, religion was no longer the same. The priests arrived in work pants and we saw that, like us, they were people of flesh and blood – only better dressed and their voices were normal and they didn't go around asking for chickens. (ODL, 23–5)

Nor, when the children died of dehydration, did the new priests attempt to console the parents with the idea that now the child was an angel in heaven. The congress to which Lupe refers is Vatican II, which met in 1964–5. The document which resulted from the congress, *The Church in the World*, contributed significantly to the, now again controversial, revolutionary role of the Church in Latin America. Adolfina's presence at the occupation of San Salvador's cathedral was in fact enabled by Archbishop Oscar Romero who publicly and consistently supported his priests and the people's struggle. Archbishop Romero was himself assassinated in March 1980 while he was saying mass in the same cathedral.

The historical referencing in Argueta's novel, as part of a popular memory, contributes to the provision of new archives, new sources for the historiographers as well as the literary critics, which will reorganize the order and priorities of meaning. The resistance writer, like the guerrilla of the armed liberation struggle, is actively engaged in an urgent historical confrontation. The questions raised by the resistance leaders are the questions faced by the writers as well, questions like that posed by Amilcar Cabral, leader of the PAIGC in Guinea Bissau:

> Another question we can proceed to discuss is the following principle of our Party: *we advance towards the struggle secure in the reality of our land (with our feet planted on the ground)*. This means, as we see it, that it is impossible to wage a struggle

under our conditions, it is impossible to struggle effectively for the independence of a people, it is impossible to establish effective armed struggle such as we have to establish in our land, unless we really know our reality and unless we start out from that reality to wage the struggle.

What is our reality[22]

Resistance in El Salvador had already begun in January 1932 with a popular insurrection against El Salvador's "fourteen families," the oligarchy which controlled the land and wealth of the country. The brutal and massive suppression of that uprising resulted in the *matanza*, the massacre, of thirty thousand people. The FMLN, El Salvador's Farabundo Marti Front for National Liberation founded in November 1980, is named for the leader of that revolt, who was executed by a firing squad on 1 February 1932. Lupe herself remembers the mysterious appearance forty years previously of a dead man in the village. ORDEN, meanwhile, a paramilitary organization which controls the death squads, was established in the 1960s by Roberto D'Abuisson with help of the US government in order to control the spread of popular opposition. In the early months, for example, as many as ten bodies a day were found killed by the death squads. ORDEN, however, and in this it vies with the resistance organization, is active in recruiting supporters from amongst the population. Its recruits are *orejas*, informers, who disclose to the authorities the activities of the resistance.

Before the base communities, before the peasant union FECCAS, before ORDEN, there was everyday life and history. The Lopez family will not talk to the Mejia family because many years ago – when, no one can say for sure – a Mejia got drunk and cut off the hand of a Lopez. And then, there is Don Paco, the chief of the community – at least according to him and his followers. When he walks along the roadway one can see the handle of the automatic pistol protruding from his belt. Don Chepe, his rival, thinks Don Paco is a thief.

Now this history – and the poverty and rage it reveals – has taken a new expression. Don Chepe is a member of FECCAS; Don Paco, a member of ORDEN since he retired from the

National Guard. Both are peasants. Both are poor. And one could say that it is only by accident that they followed different paths.[23]

The conflicting voices in *One Day of Life*, the voices of Lupe and Adolfina and the voice of the authorities, of "them," the soldiers recruited from the ranks of the populace, dramatize the authoritarian manipulation of the same class contradictions in El Salvadoran political and social life that animated Kanafani's analysis of the early Palestinian resistance movement. The question of the relationship between the class struggle and the struggle for national liberation is further complicated in Argueta's novel by the appearance of gender as a determining factor. With the exception of the voices of the authorities, all the narrative voices in the text are female: Lupe, Maria Romelia, Adolfina. Lupe's political consciousness, although derived in part from the influence and practice of her husband José, is nonetheless significant in articulating the transformations wrought by the resistance movement in traditional El Salvadoran peasant society, with all its heritage of machismo and male-dominated social structures. As in other societies involved in national liberation struggles, such as the Palestinian, the absence of men who must hide by day in the hills surrounding Chalate has forced a new responsibility on the El Salvadoran women in *One Day of Life*. More importantly still, the generations of women themselves have independently assumed new roles as part of the resistance struggle. Lupe's act of denial of her husband to the death squads is in fact an act of affirmation; it affirms both the continued existence of the resistance movement and its solidarity and it affirms the new bonds of affiliation which are evolving between men and women as a vital part of that movement.

In a poem entitled "The warrior's rest," Roque Dalton wrote:

The dead are more insolent than ever.
It used to be easy:
we gave them a starched collar a flower
we placed their names on an honor roll:
the length and breadth of our land
the illustrious shades of yesteryear
the monstrous shadow.

The cadaver signed on memory's dotted line
joined the rank and file once more
and marched to the beat of our worn out music.
But what are you gonna do
the dead
just ain't what they used to be.
These days they get ironic
ask questions.
Seems to me they're starting to figure out
that they are the majority.[24]

Manlio Argueta develops in his novel *One Day of Life* the historical and ideological questions that the dead, like José, and the living, like Lupe, are beginning to pose. These questions contest the lies propagated by the authorities, lies like those refuted by Ariel Dorfman in his poem, "Last will and testament."

When they tell you
I'm not a prisoner
don't believe them.
When they tell you
they released me
don't believe them.
They'll have to admit
it's a lie
some day.

. . . .

And finally
when
that day
comes
when they ask you
to identify the body
and you see me
and a voice says
we killed him
the bastard died
he's dead,
when they tell you

that I am
completely absolutely definitely
dead
don't believe them
don't believe them
don't believe them.[25]

A Ride on the Whirlwind: South Africa

When Steve Biko died in detention in September 1977 as a result of tortures inflicted by South African security police during his interrogation, the organizations of black South Africans whose leadership he embodied both grieved and protested his death. His supporters insisted on an official inquest into the causes of his death. The inquest, when it actually took place, lasted thirteen days and concluded that no individual was to be held legally responsible for Steve Biko's murder. The court found that "on the available evidence the death cannot be attributed to any act or omission amounting to a criminal offense on the part of any person."[26] Steve Biko, like dozens of South African blacks, died in a detention center of the South African state prison apparatus. Nelson Mandela, leader of the African National Congress, together with still countless others, remains imprisoned, serving a life sentence on Robben Island. Their legacy of struggle, however, is sustained by the black population, men, women, and children of South Africa who continue to resist white South African apartheid rule. They are supported too in their struggle by the organizations of Indians and Coloreds in South Africa as well as by individuals, like writers Donald Woods and Nadine Gordimer, or MP Helen Suzman, of the minority white population.

Steve Biko had been one of the founding members of SASO, the South African Students Organization, an all-black organization which was founded in 1969. It had been decided by the founders that the National Union of South African Students (NUSAS), a pro-black white youth organization, was not capable finally of speaking on behalf of the black population. SASO sought instead to effect what was called "conscientization" in the black communities, to bring about Black Consciousness, of the very specific

needs of as well as possibilities available to the black people. As Mongane Serote wrote in his poem, "What's in this Black 'shit'?"

> Now I'm talking about this,
> "Shit" you hear an old woman say,
> Right there, squeezed in her little match box
> With her fatness and gigantic life experience,
> Which makes her a child,
> 'Cause the next day she's right there,
> Right there serving tea to the woman
> Who's lying in bed at 10 am sick with wealth,
> Which she's prepared to give her life for
> "Rather than you marry my son or daughter." (PP, 163)

Biko, a spokesman for the Black Consciousness movement, went on to become a leader of the Black Community Program (BCP), a "self-help" organization which managed clinics, daycare centers, and other social institutions. Black Consciousness had emerged as a movement some ten years after the split within the ANC which led to the creation of the Pan-Africanist Congress (PAC) led by Robert Sobukwe, an organization which opposed "multi-racialism." Although Black Consciousness insisted on the specificity of the needs of the black population, its aims, however, were broader. As Tom Lodge points out in his study *Black Politics in South Africa since 1945*:

> In two important respects the SASO generation differed in its analysis from the Africanists. First, while attributing the same value to group assertion as a response to oppression by a homogeneously conceived white community, they were nevertheless prepared to concede there were divisions within the black community; increasingly these were conceptualized in class terms. Secondly, blacks were not defined as such ethnically: from the start the Black Consciousness movement involved Indians and coloureds as well as Africans.[27]

Just a year before Steve Biko's death, in June 1976, there occurred the "children's riots" in Soweto, mass demonstrations led by children protesting the institutionalization of Afrikaans as

the language of instruction in the school system. When several months later the by then large-scale uprising was quelled, official estimates put the casualties at 575 dead and 2389 wounded. Various explanations were suggested by historians and officials to account for the magnitude of the demonstrations: the influence of Black Consciousness ideology; changes in the educational system; African working class militancy; and the "lack of official awareness of the extent of dissatisfaction over the Afrikaans issue and deficiencies in police township intelligence which prevented them from seeing an imminent disruption." (BPSA, 330–2) In contrast to these explanations, Sipho Sepamla's novel *A Ride on the Whirlwind*[28] provides an analysis from within the events themselves of the impetus, obstacles, ideological debates, and personal solidarities which conditioned what have come to be known as the "children's riots."

According to Abdul JanMohamed in his collection of essays on black and white African literature, *Manichean Aesthetics*,

> Even though an African may adopt the formal characteristics of English fiction, his rendition of colonial experience will vary drastically from that of a European, not only because of the actual differences in experience, but also because of his antagonistic attitude toward colonialist literature.[29]

Sepamla's novel contests, through its storied account of the protagonists and antagonists and of the precedents and consequences of the Soweto uprising, the facile and vacuous reports of officialdom and the media, the sort that found "no act or omission amounting to criminal offense" behind Steve Biko's death. Such accounts are present in the novel in the form of newspaper headlines which punctuate the narrative of resistance and struggles, headlines such as:

NEWS ITEM
BOMB BLASTS POLICE STATION: ONE DEAD
ONE INJURED, NO COMMENT SAY THE POLICE (RW, 51)

NEWS ITEM
SOWETO REELS: HIGH SCHOOL LIBRARY GUTTED BY FIRE
NO COMMENT SAYS POLICE SPOKESMAN (RW, 61)

NEWS ITEM
YOUTHS STORM CITY CENTER, WHITES FLEE IN PANIC
SHOT FIRED BY UNKNOWN PERSON, NO COMMENT SAYS
POLICE SPOKESMAN (RW, 81)

NEWS ITEM
POLICE POUNCE ON SOWETO HOUSE: STUDENT
LEADERS HELD (RW, 139)

NEWS ITEM
DETAINEE COMMITS SUICIDE BY HANGING HIMSELF IN
HIS CELL, NOTHING MORE TO SAY, COMMENTS POLICE
SPOKESMAN (RW, 237)

A Ride on the Whirlwind takes over from the police spokesmen and the newspaper reports the charge of exposing the historical reality of the black resistance in South Africa as it unfolded in Soweto in the winter months of 1976.

Soweto is a black South African township located outside Johannesburg. In the novel it functions not only as setting, but as event, idea, and arena of conflict. Together with other such townships throughout South Africa, Soweto had a history of opposition, from the school boycotts in 1955 to the 1960 anti-pass campaign. Like the *madinah*, or Arab quarters, of North African cities, which became a weapon in the hands of the guerrillas in the struggle against French colonialism, the South African township such as Soweto could often serve as a main line of defense against the incursions of the security police. As the driver of a taxi in the novel announced to his passenger:

> "The police waste their time. Soweto is so big – where does one begin to look for a runner-away? I'm sure the police chief must be cursing the man who first thought of building Soweto so huge. It is a monster. It is a wild beast, this Soweto. That is why it growls, it snarls and bares fangs even for its own kind. It is seeking sanity because so much of its personality has been destroyed, so much." (RW, 162)

Or again, as the police themselves comment, "'Sometimes I wish these townships were enclosed in fences like the good old days. It would make our work a lot easier.'" (RW, 177)

As the apartheid government, however, continues its attempts to dismantle these townships by removing their populations to "tribal reserves," the bantustans, they succeed only in further reinforcing the resistance movement itself. From township to township, the struggle grows, as in Mongane Serote's novel of Alexandra, *To Every Birth Its Blood*:

> When the young came home what they asked was about how the battle of Walmanstadt was going on. Their interest was three years old. For three years the people of Walmanstadt, through courts and lawyers they did not trust, had battled with the government to remain there. . . . They were not moving from there. So they battled.[30]

In Soweto, in *A Ride on the Whirlwind*, however, the battle is not only one between the black population and the white government with its legalized racism and security apparatus. Sepamla's novel displays as well the internal contradictions within the black community itself. Mzi, a guerrilla who has been trained in neighboring Botswana in the camps of the resistance organization, has been dispatched on a mission to Soweto to take advantage of the disruptions occurring there. His mission is to execute a black police officer, Warrant Officer Andries Batata of the Special Branch. *A Ride on the Whirlwind*, which opens with the arrival of Mzi in Soweto, contains within its narrative a probing analysis of the generations of resistance in recent South African history. Essential to that analysis is a critical discussion of the various, often contending, strategies of resistance represented within these generations. Mzi's contact in Soweto is Uncle Ribs, who informs the newly arrived commando of the power of what is now happening in the township. Uncle Ribs, an older man, who had earlier worked with Nelson Mandela and the ANC, tells Mzi,

> After you will come hope marching with bitter despair. You see, brother, until the children said "Enough!" many of us despaired. We stood on the sidelines, arms folded. Sometimes we were swept by the waves of moments of crisis. Now the children cried "Enough." So, we have begun to see alternatives;

> we've begun to echo the cries uttered in the middle of the street, at street corners, in church buildings, at night-vigils and in the toilets of school buildings. Something definitive, something positive rings in the shrill voices we raise when we speak. (RW, 26)

The leader of the children's group in Soweto is Mandla, and Uncle Ribs arranges a meeting between Mzi and Mandla. Mandla, often described by the people as "son of Mandela", (RW, 57) becomes a partner in Mzi's assignment. Working with different generations as well as different models of revolutionary activity and organization, represented by Uncle Ribs, Mzi, and Mandla, Sepamla proposes a radical critique of various theories and practices of national liberation and resistance. Vis-à-vis the older generation of Uncle Ribs, which "lost" its power and capacity to act, with the leaders in prison, underground, or in exile, an impotence further underscored when Uncle Ribs is himself obliged to escape to Botswana, the new directions are represented by Mzi, who works alone, and Mandla, who leads the heterogeneous group of children.

Neither of these new directions is without its flaws, weaknesses which threaten the organization itself. Mzi's isolation and independence are shown to lead potentially to an excessive exaltation of the individual at the expense of his necessary relation to the people with whom and on whose behalf he is operating. The advantages of working alone – anonymity and freedom of movement – threaten, however, to erode the mass base of popular support. On the other hand, Mandla, who maintains, even while he remains attached to Mzi, his loyalties to his group of young colleagues, collected together in the home of Sis Ida, stands in danger of the exposure created by the very size and uncontrollability of the group. Once a police informer has noticed the rather unusually large collection of children coming and going in Sis Ida's home, the police of the Security Branch have only to make a surprise raid on the house to destroy the existence of the cell. Sis Ida and the children are arrested and held in indefinite detention. Mandla was not at home when the raid took place. He and Mzi have succeeded in executing Warrant Officer Batata. The novel ends with its major protagonists, Uncle Ribs, Mzi, and Mandla,

in exile in Botswana and Swaziland, while the children and those who have helped in the movement remain in detention, under interrogation. One of them, Roy, has died. The police attributed his death to "suicide by hanging."

The conclusions of the novel's analysis are not, however, those of detention, death, and exile.

> For Mzi the flurry of his exit from the country was in sharp contrast to the quiet dignity of his return many weeks earlier. His hope was embedded deep in his heart because for the exile there is always the eternal light burning for home-coming. For him there would be a second coming. His faith in the thought was enshrined. (RW, 244)

Mzi has escaped to Swaziland with the help of Ann, a white Englishwoman working for a church organization in South Africa and who had consistently aided and abetted Mandla and his group. If *One Day of Life* raised questions of gender within the resistance organization, Sepamla's novel introduced, through the potential, but still problematic, relationship between Mzi and Ann, the problem posed by race in maintaining the solidarity of a resistance movement. It suggests that the revolutionary transition from filiation to affiliation implicit in all these novels will require a new kind of secularism, an analysis of strategic conditions which neither denies nor yet reinforces the differences and specificities of gender, race, and class.

Sitt Marie Rose: Lebanon

Marie Rose Boulos was a Christian Lebanese woman who, following her divorce, began to organize social services among the Palestinian refugee population living in Beirut, some of them since the 1948 exodus from Palestine. The failure of her marriage had been precipitated after the birth of her three children by her husband's disapproval of her return to the university and her growing involvement in public activities such as educational reform, striking workers, and women's liberation. When the Lebanese civil war broke out in 1975, following an attack by Christians on a Palestinian bus at Ain al-Rummaneh which left

thirty dead, Marie Rose Boulos was living in Moslem West Beirut with a Palestinian doctor and directing a school for deaf-mute children in the Christian sector of the city. A woman, a Christian, who had publicly engaged herself in the social service activities of the Palestinian resistance movement, Marie Rose was kidnapped in the midst of the civil war by Christian militias and held in the school of which she was the director. Accused by her kidnappers during the days of custody and interrogation, which were witnessed by the deaf-mute children of the school, of treason and perfidies against her race, her gender, and her class, Marie Rose was executed. She was but one of the many thousands killed on both sides during the two years of unabated hostilities, a battle which, aided by outside intervention, continues a decade later to divide Lebanon against itself.

Etel Adnan's memoir of Marie Rose Boulos, entitled *Sitt Marie Rose*,[31] is called a "novel" by the writer. Like the previous narratives, the text insists on the historical reality and consequences of works of literature and their specific place in the events of the world which they transcribe. And, again as in the other novels, formal experimentation with categories of plot, character, and setting are designed to expose the political and social conditions of the narrative's account. Etel Adnan locates Marie Rose's brutal execution deeply within the context of the confessional strife and traditions of male dominance which prevailed in modern Lebanese society. These conditions had been further exacerbated by the divisions and conflicts in the Arab world created by the presence of the Israeli state with its own religious commitment and internal contradictions. The confluence of these various rifts, from within and without, are made clear by Elias Khouri in his 1979 article, "The lost memory," in which the Lebanese writer pointed to the profound critical impact the civil war and its sources had had on Arab Lebanese society and its cultural production: "Since the June defeat [by Israel in 1967]," Khouri wrote,

> the corrosion has spread into the body of the seat of power. The conflict with the external enemy has revealed its true face. The destruction of society from within is leading to the transformation of the external enemy into an internal factor. The conflicts

between enemies, and the inability to resolve them, are opening the horizons of an extended civil war in the Arab social body. In the face of this new reality, the inheritance of the "Nahdah" [Arab renaissance] is impotent and broken.[32]

This collapse of the cultural heritage and its sustaining traditions, under pressure from within and without, is embodied in *Sitt Marie Rose*. As in *One Day of Life*, many different and conflicting voices echo in its pages, representing in their fragmented appeals, indictments, and reminiscences the civil and religious discord in Lebanon. They speak out of the various vignettes of which the novel is composed. The voice of Marie Rose herself is heard as she is apprehended, challenging her accusers and announcing the linguistic and cultural, as well as political, catastrophe afflicting Lebanese society.

> But they took me, a few meters from the school, on this street where everyone has always seemed to like me, before the eyes of the parents of these children who sit before me now, their eyes open, sending me signs. Nothing moved in the street except my captors. Everything seemed stated including the short flight of a bee from one tree to another. They said: "We've got to talk to you." And I understood that, with those words, I was leaving the world of ordinary speech. (SMR, 32)

Rather than "ordinary speech," Marie Rose Boulos's captors use a language of coercion and violence, a discourse of power which suppresses the voices of its victims. The violence is heard in the voices of the members of the Christian militia who have seized Marie Rose: Mounir, the wealthy young Christian who wants to make a feature film and who had known Marie Rose in high school, has joined the militias to appease his friends; Fouad, one of those friends, takes pleasure in shelling buildings; Tony knows only that his "name is Tony and it will never be Mohammed." (SMR, 36) There are also the soundless voices of the children, the victims, who, although they are deaf and dumb, nonetheless possess the perceptive power to pierce the rhetoric of violence and discern another reality behind it:

> In this classroom, always occupied by the air and the few flies that can survive at the height of this hill, there's US, the

> deaf-mutes. We're here to learn the special languages that will help us communicate with others. We read words on lips whose sounds don't reach us. We utter sounds that make people shudder it seems. We can't hear them. We can use our fingers for an alphabet. But above all else, we can dance. Pressed against radios, our hands recognize the music, and we dance like charmed snakes, the vibrations guiding us.
>
> Because we're deaf, we can forecast earthquakes. Besides, there's one every day in Beirut. (SMR, 29)

These children, like the novel's narrator, recognize Marie Rose's own threatening potential of resistance in her relationship with her captors. "Marie Rose frightens them." It is why Marie Rose must be killed. Her captors betray themselves in the impromptu confessions out of which the short text is constructed: their contempt for women, their religious fanaticism, their hatred of Moslems and Palestinians. In the refugee camps where Marie Rose had worked, the dispossessed people grieve over her disappearance.

The opening scenes of the book, however, which are set just prior to the outbreak of the civil war, examine the sources of strife in a society divided by class, gender, and confession. As the narrative begins, Mounir is showing a short film he has made to the assembled company of Tony, Pierre, and Fouad and their various women.

> Mounir, Tony, and Pierre like to do a little of everything. They dabble. Mounir's family is extremely rich, and he includes Tony and Pierre in his projects and distractions. Fouad is part of the "group." None of them has ever found in a woman the same sensation of power he gets from a car. An auto rally is more significant than a conjugal night, and hunting is better still. There's a hierarchy even in the world of sport. In any case, hunting remains the most noble occupation. It's more wholesome. It's also more intellectual. One leaves Lebanon, and comes to know the neighboring (and enemy) country of Syria. The Syrians are not as rich and well-equipped, and lack the proper style . . . to hunt as well. Before, it was the Europeans with faces like the ones we saw on the screen, who went hunting

> in Syria and Iraq, and elsewhere. Now it's the Christian, modernized Lebanese who go wherever they like with their touristo-military gear. They bring their cameras to film their exploits, their puttees, their shoes, their shorts, their buttons, their zippers, their open shirts and their black hair showing. And these four are particularly pure. They never sleep together.
>
> (SMR, 2–3)

The Lebanese civil war produced various literary accounts which attempted to come to terms with the violent disruption of the already fragile Lebanese social structure represented in the first pages of *Sitt Marie Rose. Death in Beirut*,[33] written by Tawfiq Yusuf Awwad in 1972 in the years just preceding the decisive outbreak of internecine hostilities, is the story of Tamima Nassour, a young Shiite girl who leaves her home in the south of Lebanon to study in Beirut. Her love affair with Hani Raai, the Christian Maronite university student, ends in disaster and tragedy when Tamima's brother seeks to avenge the supposed stain on the family's honor, only to kill instead Mary Abu-Khalil, Tamima's Christian friend and confidante. The novel concludes with Tamima leaving again, this time to join the Palestinian fedayeen. Generically different, Lina Mikdadi Tabbara's personal memoir, *Survival in Beirut: A Diary of the Civil War*,[34] is likewise the story of the author's politicization through the ordeals of the sectarian strife. Both works, for all their differences of style and emphasis, one a conventional novel by a male writer, the other a woman's diary, insist, like *Sitt Marie Rose*, on the significance of women's emergence into political consciousness and the necessity of their active participation in the resistance movement. *Sitt Marie Rose*, at once document, literary text, and self-criticism, combines the force of all these, to challenge the repressive hold maintained by the categories of gender, race, and class, appealing against "tribalism," confessionalism, and sectarianism to a larger secular vision of the future.

The tension between the "sentimental romance," conventional to the development of the bourgeois novel of Europe, and the historical analysis of the emerging resistance movement and organizations is evident in the narrative of *Sitt Marie Rose* as it had been in Sepamla's *A Ride on the Whirlwind*. As the question of father–son

relationships was contested in the Mansur stories and in *To Bury Our Fathers*, the often formally awkward relationships of personal affection in the South African and Lebanese novels disclose nonetheless the continuing private dimension, the psychological needs, of the lives of individuals in the larger historical struggle against the forces of oppression. Mzi's departure with Ann at the end of Sepamla's novel differs radically from the marriages which conventionally concluded many nineteenth-century novels. Whereas Emma's marriage to Mr Knightly at the end of Jane Austen's novel served to reconsolidate the aristocratic conclave against the threatened incursions of gypsies and chicken thieves, Mzi and Ann's exile represents a dismantling of the sectarian structures of race and class within South African society. Similarly, Sitt Marie Rose's death, which engages the entire repressive Lebanese social hierarchy, should be contrasted with such narrative closures as that provided by Emma Bovary's solitary suicide in Flaubert's *Madame Bovary*.

The tension between the personal and the historical generates in these resistance narratives new literary paradigms with consequences and analogues for their contemporary ideological and historical situation. One of Marie Rose's earliest meetings with the Palestinian doctor with whom she eventually came to live took place in the cortège of Ghassan Kanafani's funeral in July 1972. Kanafani had been killed in a car-bomb explosion for which Mossad, the Israeli secret service, later claimed responsibility. In the last article which he wrote before his death, "The case of Abu Hamidu," published posthumously in *Shu'un filastiniyya*,[35] Kanafani had reiterated his appeal for a secular vision within the resistance organization. Abu Hamidu was a Palestinian fedayi in the south of Lebanon who was accused by the villagers of raping one of their daughters. The commando was tried by the resistance organization, found guilty, and sentenced to death. The woman whom he was accused of violating was executed by her brother, to erase the stain she had supposedly brought on the family's honor. In his radical critique of the incident, Kanafani insists on the need for the revolutionary movement to educate its own members to a practice which would transform systems of exploitation, whether based on gender, race, or class, into a collective solidarity, an active alliance with that same population it proposes to "liberate."

Knowledge and power

Resistance narratives, at the same time that they, each in its own way, propose historically specific analyses of the ideological and material conditions out of which they are generated, in Nicaragua, South Africa, El Salvador, Palestine, or elsewhere, contribute to a larger narrative, that of the passage from genealogical or hereditary ties of filiation to the collective bonds of affiliation. The connections between the narratives and the historical dimensions of the resistance movement, like those of the images of the "apocalypse at Solentiname," assert their claim to a role on the historical stage and their own self-critical historicity.

According to Michel Foucault, "we should abandon a whole tradition that allows us to imagine that knowledge can exist only where the power relations are suspended and that knowledge can develop only outside its injunctions, its demands and its interests."[36] The connection between knowledge and power, the awareness of the exploitation of knowledge by the interests of power to create a distorted historical record, is central to resistance narratives. The tradition to which Foucault is referring is a tradition which these narratives seek directly to transform. Within the texts and their analytical representation of the social histories of their characters that tradition is critically examined. The texts themselves, however, are immediate interventions into the historical record, attempting to produce and impart new historical facts and analyses, what Edward Said has referred to as "new objects for a new kind of knowledge."[37] This requires that the historical record and the present agenda be rewritten.

iv

Prison memoirs of political detainees

There are five thousand of us here
in this small part of the city.
We are five thousand
I wonder how many we are in all
in the cities and in the whole country?
Here alone
are ten thousand hands which plant seeds
and make factories run.
How much humanity
exposed to hunger, cold, panic, pain,
moral pressure, terror and insanity?
Six of us were lost
as if into starry space.
One dead, another beaten as I could never have
believed
a human being could be beaten.
The other four wanted to end their terror –
one jumping into nothingness,
another beating his head against a wall,
but all with the fixed stare of death.
What horror the face of fascism creates!
. . . . . .
How hard it is to sing
when I must sing of horror.
Horror which I am living,

horror which I am dying.
To see myself among so much
and so many moments of infinity
in which silence and screams
are the end of my song.
What I see, I have never seen
What I have felt and what I feel
will give birth to the moment.
(Victor Jara – "Chile stadium")

Prison memoirs and the conventions of autobiography

Victor Jara, the popular Chilean musician and singer, composed his last poem in Santiago's National Stadium where he was held with thousands of other Chileans detained during the coup which in September 1973 overthrew Salvador Allende's Popular Unity government. The poem was transmitted orally and memorized by other prisoners in the stadium. Victor Jara died in the National Stadium, but his song was smuggled out by word of mouth by fellow prisoners who survived and were later released. Jara's wife Joan recalls in her memoir the comrades who came to see her with news of Victor, his death, and the lyrics of his last poem. "When later the text of his last poem was brought to me, I knew that Victor wanted to leave his testimony, his only means now of resisting fascism, of fighting for the rights of human beings and for peace."[1]

The importance of these songs, such as Victor Jara's, in sustaining the morale and conviction of political prisoners held in detention, often in solitary confinement and under conditions of extreme physical and psychological brutality, in prisons throughout the world is reiterated by the South African writer and former political prisoner Molefe Pheto. In *And Night Fell*, his prison memoirs, he describes his transfer to another prison, always, as is reported by prisoners, one of the most frightening moments in a prisoner's life.

The night we arrived, the cell reverberated with freedom songs from our eleven throats in the dungeon, towards the other

> sectors of the prison. It was most heartening when cell after cell joined us until I was certain that more than one thousand voices were singing protest songs. Then other non-political songs would answer our songs; songs about the ghetto and sweethearts and our country. We also joined in the other songs.[2]

Molefe Pheto, a Soweto music teacher and founder of MDALI (Music, Drama, Arts, and Literature Institute), was held without trial by South African authorities for nine months in 1977. His prison memoirs, like those of other political detainees from Israel to El Salvador, insist on the collective historical consequences of his own individual experience.

That experience consists not only in sharing songs of protest and of sweethearts, but in organized resistance as well to the prison authorities and the repressive state apparatus which they represent. Political prisoners are detained by governments for their collective work of opposition in the societies in which they live. Like Molefe Pheto, Ngugi wa Thiong'o, for example, had participated in organizing a community theater project in a Kenyan Gikuyu village. Tomas Borge was a member of Nicaragua's FSLN. Raymonda Tawil, a Palestinian journalist in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, was placed under house arrest by the Israeli military government. For her participation in forming the Bolivian miners' Housewives Committee, Domitila Barrios de Chungara was arrested twice by the Bolivian authorities. Their own experience of prison, as recounted in the memoirs of political detainees, is conditioned by the ideal of that larger collective struggle in which they are involved. The nature of that struggle both sustains their resistance in prison and informs the composition and structure of their prison memoirs.

The prison memoirs of Third World political detainees challenge the common presupposition among many western literary critics which is most patently expressed by Thomas Mallon in his presentation of the memoir as a literary activity. In the chapter entitled "Prisoners" of his study, *A Book of One's Own: People and Their Diaries*, Mallon begins with the observation that

> Things are not nearly so bad for us as they were for Oceania's Winston Smith at the beginning and end of the book that

> memorializes his doomed rebellion against Big Brother. We contend more with the electronic explosion of information than its technological suppression.[3]

Mallon's "us" for whom he considers things to be "not nearly so bad" is an exclusive category and eliminates the many writers of the Third World who are denied access first of all to the "explosion of information" generated by a computerized culture and who furthermore often write in situations of extreme "technological suppression."

Writing within the context of a liberation struggle or a resistance movement often entails serious consequences for the writers' very persons and lives, consequences that go well beyond even the issues and penalties of censorship and publication. There are those writers, like Ghassan Kanafani and Amilcar Cabral, who have died violently at the hands of assassins. (Cabral was shot on 20 January 1973, allegedly by dissidents within his own movement supported by the Portuguese regime; Kanafani died on 8 July 1972 in his booby-trapped car outside his home in Beirut.) Others have spent years in prison, condemned as much for their writing as for their political involvements. Many of these writers have composed or compiled memoirs of their prison experience and these texts constitute a special category which has emerged out of the larger framework of resistance literature. Their accounts differ from much other "prison writing" in that these prisoners did not simply "discover" their writing selves while in prison, but rather were often incarcerated because they wrote. These memoirs are to be distinguished too from conventional autobiography inasmuch as the narratives are actively engaged in a re-definition of the self and the individual in terms of a collective enterprise and struggle. The prison memoirs of political detainees are not written for the sake of a "book of one's own," rather they are collective documents, testimonies written by individuals to their common struggle.

Autobiography as a genre in its own right has been acknowledged only recently within the western literary canon. Debates over its status and position, as well as its defining characteristics, still persist. In some cases, formal criteria are invoked, as when Philippe Lejeune describes "le pacte autobiographique" as "the

affirmation in the text of the identity [of author/narrator/main character], which refers as a last resort to the *name* of the author on the cover."[4] More so even than the protest songs and anthems, like "Nkosi Sikelela" sung in Dennis Brutus's "Today in prison," however, the prison memoirs of political detainees narrate the resistance struggles and their separate and combined histories across prison walls and national boundaries. The formal identity of author/narrator/main character which underwrites Lejeune's "autobiographical pact" is rewritten in the prison cell as a political analysis of a larger social body. In literary–historical terms, on the other hand, some genealogists of the form have traced its ancestry as far back as Saint Augustine's *Confessions*. Karl Weintraub, however, insists that "the autobiographic genre took on its full dimension when Western Man acquired a thoroughly historical understanding of his existence,"[5] that is, only in the early eighteenth century in Europe.

In contrast to Weintraub's point of reference in "Western Man," other critics have seen in autobiography a genre especially appropriate to those groups which have historically been denied access to the literary pantheon. Roger Rosenblatt, citing its importance in black literature in the United States, states that "All autobiography is minority autobiography." "Minority autobiography and minority fiction," Rosenblatt goes on,

> deserve that minority status not because of comparative numbers, but because of the presence of a special reality, one provided for the minority by the majority, within which each member of the minority tries to reach an understanding both of himself and the reality into which he has been placed.[6]

The role ascribed by Rosenblatt to autobiography in black literature is paralleled by its place in women's writings, or again in resistance literature. In the prison memoirs of Third World political detainees, the challenge to the literary conventions of autobiography is concomitant with the refusal seen in the resistance narratives of either individual accomplishment or filial ties based exclusively on gender or race, sex or ethnicity. As H. Bruce Franklin concluded in *The Victim as Criminal and*

Artist, a study of prisoners, especially blacks, in United States jails,

> People who have become literary artists because of their imprisonment tend to write in an autobiographical mode. The reason is obvious: it is their own personal experience that has given them both their main message and the motive to communicate it. The works of today's prisoners, though predominantly autobiographical, are rarely intended as a display of individual genius. Whereas the literary criteria dominant on campus exalt what is extraordinary or even unique, with "originality" as the key criterion, most current autobiographical writing from prison intends to show the readers that the author's individual experience is not unique or even extraordinary.[7]

And the same can be said of writers who are imprisoned because they write.

Just as institutions of power (whether those developed within a society or political order or those imposed by external hegemonic practices and domination) are subverted by the demand on the part of dispossessed groups for an access to history, power, and resources, so too are the narrative paradigms and their textual authority transformed by the historical and literary articulation of those demands. In seeking the concept of the individual as the basis and foundation of the autobiographical form, as Weintraub, Mallon, and Lejeune do, critics fail to acknowledge the kind of political strategy that motivates prison memoirs. According to Ngugi, "A narration of prison life is, in fact, nothing more than an account of oppressive measures in varying degrees of intensity and one's individual or collective responses to them."[8] The prison memoirs of Third World political detainees thus challenge even the western Marxist critiques of autobiographical individualism cited by Lejeune, which "situate themselves beyond the confines of [western] civilization [and] are no longer sensitive either to the individualist calls of the siren or to the discreet charm of literature." Contrary to the statement in Renée Balibar's *Les Français fictifs*, cited by Lejeune, that "Biography and autobiography are in fact the general forms of representation in

bourgeois society and constitute the image of man coupled with that of society,"[9] Ngugi proposed in the preface to his own prison diary, *Detained*, another definition of the prison memoir: "I have, therefore, tried to discuss detention not as a personal affair between me and a few individuals, but as a social, political and historical phenomenon." (D, xi)

As a "social, political and historical phenomenon," detention and the literary memoirs which the prison experience generates contest the social order which supports the prison apparatus and its repressive structures. Although the psychology of sadism which induces the individual torturer to victimize physically and mentally other human beings has been investigated by western writers from Sacher-Masoch and the Marquis de Sade to Gilles Deleuze, it is the relationship between the individual and the state machine which employs the torturers that is of consequence in these prison memoirs. Amnesty International, an organization which monitors the abuses of the human rights of prisoners throughout the world, has pointed out that "Torture does not occur simply because individual torturers are sadistic, even if testimonies verify that they are. Torture is usually part of the state-controlled machinery to suppress dissent."[10] The relationship between the torturer and the repressive regime with which he works is examined, for example, in Elvira Orphée's novel *El Angel's Last Conquest*,[11] and in most prison memoirs the complex connections between prisoners and their warders, guards, and interrogators are central to their political analyses of the prison situation. As Massimo Pavarini maintained in his analysis, "The penitentiary as a model for the ideal society," prison "assumes the dimension of an *'organized project for the subaltern social world.'*"[12] Michel Foucault too discussed the techniques and ideology of social control represented in the prison system in *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*, where he examined the connections through modern European history between prison, monastic cell, workshop, and hospital.[13]

Detention is calculated to contain and eliminate organized dissent inside the prison no less than outside its walls and, in addition to an investigation of state apparatuses and their techniques of repression and control such as those provided by Pavarini and Foucault, it is necessary to explore the strategies of

resistance, insubordination, and attack which have evolved on the part of the victims of these apparatuses. That such organization exists on a social and cultural level in United States prisons has been documented in Inez Cardozo-Freeman's study of the linguistic network and hierarchy among inmates in the Walla Walla prison in the state of Washington. In her book, *The Joint: Language and Culture in a Maximum Security Prison*, she demonstrates through the collected stories and interviews with prisoners that language development in the prison is representative of a counter-culture or anti-society. What she furthermore points out is the common "problem in describing a prison culture," which is that "generally the point of view of everyone except the prisoner is presented – prison staff, guards, officials, researchers, and so on."[14]

The prison memoirs of Third World political detainees likewise suggest a counter-hegemonic practice of writing which both organizes and documents the political resistance to a bureaucratization and mechanization of the human and social mind and body which takes place inside the prison institution. Breyten Breytenbach, the Afrikaner writer who spent seven years in a South African prison for his work on behalf of the banned African National Congress, concluded in his *True Confessions of an Albino Terrorist* that "When you are interested in prison accounts as a genre you will soon see that prisons are pretty much the same the world over."[15] What does distinguish the prison memoirs of political detainees, despite the monolithic uniformity of the prison itself, is the historical and cultural specificity of the collective strategies of political resistance of the detainees.

The "power of writing"

In describing the various methods used by the prison authorities in maintaining a regime of discipline among the prisoners, methods such as surveillance, normalization, and examination, Foucault points to what he calls "the power of writing" which was essential to these methods. This power of writing was sustained, according to Foucault, "by a system of intense registration and of

documentary accumulation." What happens as a result of this power is that the

> turning of real lives into writing is no longer a procedure of heroization; it functions as a procedure of objectification and subjection. The carefully collated life of mental patients or delinquents belongs, as did the chronicles of kings or the adventures of the great popular bandits, to a certain political function of writing; but in a quite different technique of power. (DP, 189–92)

This authoritarian control over the "power of writing" is especially evident in the case of political prisoners in the ban on all writing and reading materials which is generally imposed on these detainees. Such a ban, itself provoked by the particular aptitudes of political prisoners, serves to condition in an important way one of the crucial modes of prisoner resistance: writing. These prisoners, many of whom are detained as a result of their literary and cultural activity, present already a serious threat to the authorities' control over the "power of writing."

Not only the memoirs of detention which the writers produce, but all forms of written and oral communication among them while inside the prison, contest that other control. Writing itself, and in particular the writing of a novel, thus forms the organizing motif of Ngugi's *Detained*. The diary proper begins, not with Ngugi's arrest in the middle of the night and the violent search of his library carried out by the police looking for "subversive literature," but in the prison, with his writing of a novel. "I am at the desk, under the full electric glare of a hundred watt naked bulb, scribbling on toilet paper." (D, 3) The very first lines of the text are a quotation from the same novel he is in the process of writing, *Devil on the Cross*, written and first published in Gikuyu and then later in an English translation done by the author. Prison culture, for Ngugi, is become toilet-paper culture.

> Toilet-paper: when in the sixties I first read in Kwame Nkrumah's autobiography, *Ghana*, how he used to hoard toilet-paper in his cell at James Fort Prison to write on, I thought it was romantic and a little unreal despite the photographic evidence reproduced in the book. Writing on toilet-paper?

> Now, I know: paper, any paper, is about the most precious article for a political prisoner, more so for one like me, who was in political detention because of his writing. For the urge to write:
>
> Picking the jagged bits embedded in my mind,
> Partly to wrench some ease for my own mind,
> And partly that some world sometime may know
>
> is almost irresistible to a political prisoner. At Kamiti, virtually all the detainees are writers or composers. . . . Now the same good old toilet-paper – which had been useful to Kwame Nkrumah in James Fort Prison, to Dennis Brutus on Robben Island, to Abdilatif Abdalla in G Block, Kamiti, and to countless other persons with similar urges – has enabled me to defy daily the intended detention of my mind. (D, 5–6)

Through this toilet-paper culture, Ngugi will do more than commemorate his prison experience. His novel in Gikuyu, the language of one of Kenya's peoples, is a challenge to the neocolonial Kenyan regime which had imprisoned him for his efforts in organizing popular Gikuyu culture, his crime that of the defense of national culture.

Ngugi's writing of the novel, which he drafts while in confinement, provides the structure of a frame story for his prison memoirs, which begin and end with citations from that work, *Devil on the Cross*. His prison experience is thus contextualized and made an integral part of his writing practice and the resistance strategy in which that writing participates. Ngugi, who defined detention itself as "the physical removal of patriots from the people's organized struggles," (D, 13) had engaged in those struggles in his function as a writer and the incriminating evidence of that engagement which the police confiscate from his home includes not only "books by Lenin, Marx and Engels," but, Ngugi goes on, "to the list of the Dangerous Three, they now added Kim Chi Ha, and any book that bore the words 'scientific socialism,' plus the twenty-six copies of the offending play, *Ngaahika Ndeenda*." (D, 16) *Ngaahika Ndeenda* (I will marry when I want), the collective theatrical production staged and performed by the villagers at Kamiriithu, has thus been accorded a

special status by the Kenyan authorities among the world's literary and philosophical works of resistance.[16] Its banning and confiscation succeed only temporarily in halting the writer's production.

Molefe Pheto, who had also been involved in organizing the collective cultural activity of a community, in the township of Soweto outside Johannesburg, saw his library suffer the same fate as that of Ngugi. Ngugi's own writings were part of the confiscation conducted by the South African authorities.

> I saw Wole Soyinka thrown head-first into the pillow slip; the Imamu Barakas that had escaped banning by the Publications Board; Chinua Achebe staring at Purple Suit with his strong eyes suffered the fate of Soyinka; Serote, Mtshali, Senghor, Césaire, Okigbo, the two Diops, Mphahlele, E. R. Braithwaite, Ngugi; my own poems and the first manuscript of my novel joining that august company of Black writers going to jail in a pillow case and six big brown South African government-supply envelopes. (ANF, 38)

Pheto, aware of the consequences that threaten the existence of resistance writers and their works, had taken some preliminary precautions.

> I was delighted with myself that, during all the years of compiling my library of Black literature, I had had the wisdom to send the Nyereres, Nkrumahs, Sekou Tourés, Mao Tse-Tungs, Kaundas, Fanons and others to friends all over the country, sometimes to places as far as 400 or more miles away. I had this unrealistic dream that some day it would be possible to read, as well as to have, these books openly in the house. (ANF, 39)

Like Pablo Neruda's "body divided" and scattered to various parts of the country, these works of resistance literature belonging to political detainees are reconstituted through writing and struggle as a new corpus.

Prison writing, whether the literary works composed by detainees during their incarceration or the works because of which they are arrested in the first place, serves as a critical and sustaining link between the prisoners inside and those struggling outside

the prison walls. Writing and communication, however, function just as significantly inside those walls in establishing and maintaining the solidarity amongst the prisoners. A history of the prison and its inmates evolves progressively, with its shared legends, language, and memorials. Prisoners assign names to the guards, as in Pheto's *And Night Fell*: Mother Hen, Purple Suit, Night Pot. "The White one who drove the car I named 'Magosha,' a new word which saw its birth in the ever-growing and developing language of the ghettos, meaning prostitute." (ANF, 30) Days of release, the arrival of new prisoners, deaths, and changes in the regimen are anticipated and commemorated. As Ngugi remarks,

> Strange how a place acquires its own personality, history, even culture and special vocabulary. All those who have been in this compound became part of the spirit of our history as detainees. For those of us who are new, we can never hear enough about the personalities, characters, anecdotes, exploits, words, songs, sayings of those who were here before us and have now left. . . . It is as if we are all part of an undeclared political fraternity. (D, 131)

The political fraternity, its historical record, is in many cases inscribed on the prison walls themselves, which become archives of the resistance. Mu'in Basisu, a Palestinian poet and dramatist, was held in Egyptian jails during the 1950s for his activities in the Communist Party at the time. In his memoirs of that period, *Descent into the Water*, he notes that

> On the walls of the cell the prisoner writes his name. With a shirt button or a nail, he carves it out. That is the first thing he does: writes his name, the day he entered, and the place he came from. And, as a good omen to the son or grandson entering the cell after him, he always writes, before leaving, the date of his release.[17]

The walls record too the struggle within the prison between authorities and detainees. In Ward G of the Military Prison, Basisu remembers that "Once I saw one of the guards wipe his hand on the wall of my cell. He was wiping off the blood of

Farid Abu Warda." (DW, 68–9) The political fraternity Ngugi sees being forged inside the prison is part of the larger struggle against the various repressive regimes, both colonial and neo-colonial, and their prison apparatus.

Essential to the maintenance of political fraternity inside the prison is the dissemination of information from outside. Banned newspapers and magazines become valuable property, property not to be owned but shared and disposed of immediately afterwards. Indres Naidoo spent ten years from 1963 to 1973 on Robben Island, South Africa's most notorious penal institution, for his guerrilla activities as a member of the African National Congress. In his memoirs, written with Albie Sachs on his release, and entitled simply *Robben Island*, he describes the significance of the role played by newspapers amongst the prisoners.

> Even the most trivial item of news was devoured, discussed over and over again, and analysed from every possible angle. "Prince So-and-so in Europe is to marry Princess Such-and-such." We discussed such items with full gravity, arguing about how it would affect our struggle.
>
> Not for one minute did we stop smuggling newspapers and, if the authorities accused us of that offence, we never denied it. In our opinion it was a crime to deny us knowledge of what was happening around the world, not just the political events but the social, cultural, sporting and scientific happenings as well. The intention of the authorities was to cut us off completely from the outside world, to break us down. We, on the other hand, never once gave in. If we spotted a newspaper in the possession of a warder we would be sure to get it into the gaol by hook or by crook within a short time, even if it were locked in a desk or a van.[18]

Radios were similarly vital, but these posed the additional problem of batteries and were more difficult to conceal. Newspapers, however, could be flushed down the toilet, albeit with great difficulty and time-consuming effort and patience. They could even, if necessary, be consumed by the prisoners. These newspapers, or bits of them, were obtained from the Island's rubbish dump or

from sympathetic visitors such as a chaplain. Even recalcitrant guards could occasionally be counted on to relay news, particularly if it was bad, "such as when Bram Fischer [the Afrikaner lawyer who defended political prisoners] was arrested in 1965." (RI, 155)

The information provided by the newspapers served not only to establish the vital connection between the prisoners and the struggle being waged outside, allowing them to pursue the ideological analysis and evaluation of the progress and setbacks of the resistance movement, but also to organize and coordinate their own activities and network within the prison structure. Thus Naidoo describes their collective informational and educational enterprise:

> We got our newspapers to a central point where a group of us would read them and memorize all the articles of interest: political, social, cultural, scientific and sporting, remembering as much as possible of all the details. Each of the readers then transmitted that information to a further small group who in turn disseminated it to another group, and so on.
>
> The beauty of it was how we managed to memorize so much. A newcomer would struggle to remember twenty items, but within a short time he had learnt many ways of doing so. For example, I would first take items dealing with South Africa and count how many articles there were on the subject; then how many articles there were on Africa as a whole; then Europe, Asia, America, and so on. Then, when disseminating the news, I would remember that I had read ten items on South Africa, five on Africa and so many on the rest of the world, which helped in recalling the actual contents. (RI, 155–6)

Similarly, at Kamiti, where Ngugi was imprisoned, "gathering news" became a "psychological imperative." (D, 134) The news, for example, of the death of Jomo Kenyatta, president of Kenya, which came during the period of Ngugi's detention, meant possible early release for the political detainees. In al-Qanatir women's prison, where Nawal al-Saadawi was held in 1981, the news of Sadat's assassination produced a similar effect.[19] For Akhtar Baluch, in a Pakistani prison, it was the announcement of

Bhutto's election which brought hope to the inmates.[20] As Indres Naidoo recalls, even letters from home and loved ones became "prisoners' property," often circulating for months before being eventually returned to their original addressee.

The writer in prison has a special role to play, amongst his fellow detainees as well as in the eyes of the prison authorities. His writing serves to sustain his memory and sense of self and purpose, as Breytenbach records in his *True Confessions of an Albino Terrorist*:

> In the dark I am not in the way. There is nobody to look over my shoulder. I am relieved! Then, like an irrepressible urge, there would be the need to write. In the dark I can just perceive the faintly pale outline of a sheet of paper. And I would start writing. Like launching a black ship on a dark sea. I write: I am the writer. (TCAT, 136)

During his seven and a half years in detention, Breytenbach, like Ngugi with his novel, wrote essays and poems in order to survive in his own way. There were other reasons for writing as well, the question of maintaining the struggle, certainly, but also reasons imposed by other inhabitants of the prison institution. A fellow inmate, for example, tells Ngugi a week after his arrival at Kamiti:

> The other day – in fact a week or so before you came – we were saying that it would be a good thing for Kenya if more intellectuals were imprisoned. First, it would wake most of them from their illusions. And some of them might outlive jail to tell the world. The thing is . . . just watch your mind . . . don't let them break you and you'll be all right even if they keep you for life . . . but you must try . . . you have to, for us, for the ones you left behind. (D, 8)

Breytenbach too was called upon to perform certain functions in his capacity as writer among his companions in detention. "I was the writer, but I was also the scribe. In prison everybody eventually finds his own function in terms of his usefulness to the inmate community. . . . But I was the scribe." (TCAT, 144–5) As

scribe, Breytenbach would compose letters for illiterate prisoners, or "literary" ones for prosaic writers. On still other occasions, he would fashion a plea for mercy for a prisoner whose case was coming up for review, or letters of recommendation for prisoners about to be released, "requests for parole, for release, for transfer, for interviews. You name it. I am the writer. I wrote the personal histories of chaps that they had to submit to their social workers." (TCAT, 147) Another prisoner, a "distinguished multiple murderer," asked the Afrikaner writer to help him finish his "uncompleted manuscript" of a novel, which, it turned out, had been begun and carried on by other "writers" the prisoner had encountered. Breytenbach also wrote for the "boere," the Afrikaner prison authorities – love letters, applications for promotion, even translations.

The writer's power with words, liberating as it might be, can also be used against him, can be misused even by the writer himself who fails to calculate adequately the consequences of that power. Breytenbach, perhaps the most introspective and self-conscious of himself as writer among the political detainees, was tantalized by the "possibility, however faint, of communicating with the outside world." (TCAT, 180) He therefore agreed to be interviewed by Dr Christian Barnard, the South African heart surgeon, for a French television film about South Africa. Only later, after the censored and contrived session, did he realize that the film had in fact been made for the Department of Information, as "part of one of their very aggressive schemes to sell the South African anti-Communist line abroad." (TCAT, 182)

Prisoners' writings, whether letters to family, to lawyers, or the toilet-paper productions of novelists, poets, and essayists of the resistance, are subject to the scrutiny and control of prison authorities. According to Ngugi, who differentiated between two opposing aesthetics in literature – 'the aesthetic of oppression and exploitation and of acquiescence with imperialism; and that of human struggle for total liberation" – there are also two kinds of political prisoner and two kinds of writing. These distinguish themselves from each other according to their use and manipulation of language. There are, for Ngugi, those political prisoners "who finally succumbed and said 'Yes' to an oppressive system; and those that defied and maintained 'Never!'" (D, 81), just as

there are two uses of language: "for masking the truth or for unmasking the truth." (D, 179) In the prison memoirs of political detainees, the "power of writing" is one which seeks to alter the relationships of power which are maintained by coercive, authoritarian systems of state control and domination.

From the women's prison

For women in the Third World, no less than for their male counterparts and *companeros*, imprisonment by the authoritarian states and repressive regimes within which they live and work is a real possibility as the outcome of their private and public struggles. Women's prison writings from the Third World present a twofold challenge to western theoretical developments, both literary-critical and feminist. Political forces and economic pressures are radically altering the structure of women's lives in Third World societies, transforming not only their relationship to men within the family setting but their role in the larger social order as well. Women whose husbands, brothers, sons have been killed or imprisoned as a result of their resistance activities find their political responsibilities reorganized, either by the necessity of their assuming the place of the absent men or by their taking up arms beside them.

Following the departure of the PLO fighters from Beirut after the Israeli invasion of Lebanon in 1982, for example, the Palestinian women, mothers, wives, daughters, and sisters, took over, as they had done before, the supervision and maintenance of many of the social services provided by the resistance organization.[21] In Guinea-Bissau, women were likewise participants in providing for the armed struggle led by Amilcar Cabral which culminated finally in 1974 in liberation from Portuguese imperialism and in national independence. Their role, however, unlike that of Angolan women, was not that of combatants in active fighting, but was developed primarily in areas of service and support. This distinction, according to the leaders of the revolution, was generated less out of a patriarchal system than as a response to the circumstances and conditions of the country itself, its population, the nature of its terrain, and the immediate and long-range needs of the struggle.[22] In South Africa, the mass removals of population

under various apartheid laws, such as the pass laws restricting the freedom of movement and choice of occupation, have succeeded not only in separating families but in politicizing women as well.[23] In *One Day of Life*, Lupe and her granddaughter were enlisted to carry on the political struggle when Lupe's husband José is murdered by Salvadoran death squads.

No less than political repression and popular resistance to it, economic pressures and the consequences of migrant labor, rural–urban migration, and the failures of post-colonial governments are also forcing a reconstruction of traditional female roles and family patterns. Like Wanja in *Petals of Blood*, Ngugi's novel of neo-colonialism in Kenya, African women are leaving the family structure to join forces in the beginnings, not always successful, of a new social order.[24] The absence of men, whether through death, struggle, migration, or imprisonment, is critical to the position of women in many developing countries. Their personal itineraries, which have taken the women too through combat, interrogation, incarceration, and, in many cases, physical torture, are attested to in their own narratives as part of a historical agenda, a collective enterprise, one they share with male political detainees. These texts, which include short story, novel, autobiography, diary, and "testimony," are integral in compiling the chapters of what Gayatri Spivak has designated, in her critique of psychoanalysis and the Third World, as the social and "psychobiographies that constitute the subject effect of these women."[25] From Bessie Head's short story "The collector of treasures," to Nawal al-Saadawi's novelistic testimony *Woman at Point Zero*, followed by her own *Memoirs from the Women's Prison*, to the prison diaries of Akhtar Baluch, "'Sister, are you still here?'," the autobiography *Let Me Speak* of Domitila Barrios de Chungara, and the prison memoirs of Ruth First, *117 Days*, and Raymonda Tawil, *My Home My Prison*, the texts have begun to emerge as a collective corpus, a common statement, which embodies the challenge to authoritarian structures and state apparatuses.[26]

Bessie Head's short stories, assembled in the volume entitled *The Collector of Treasures*, all deal with the situation of women in Botswana, her country of exile from South Africa. The title story of the collection is the account of Dikeledi Mokopi, a woman who

has murdered her husband by stabbing him to death. This husband, who had deserted his family some years earlier, had continued nonetheless on occasion to demand demonstrations of conjugal allegiance from his long abandoned but now independent wife. Like Hosna Bint Mahmoud, one of the female protagonists of Tayeb Salih's novel *Season of Migration to the North*[27] set in a Sudanese village, who first castrates then takes the life of her aged husband Wad Rayyes and immediately afterwards commits suicide, Dikeledi is challenging the social order of her community which has assigned its women a subordinate position under the control of their male partners. Traditionally the role of Tswana women had consisted in acceptance of prolonged and arduous labor, physical deprivation in times of want, submission and passive obedience in marital life, and, finally, the placing of familial or community interest before private concerns.[28]

Dikeledi's murder of her husband consolidates her opposition to that role. Hosna Bint Mahmoud's assault on the social order, while it has very real consequences, is nonetheless conceived and executed as a private vengeance enacted upon the community. Dikeledi's murder of her husband is also the result of a personal, if socially conditioned, decision taken on her own initiative. It is in Bessie Head's narration of the transgression and the punitive reprisal which follows that the larger collective possibilities of the individual act are elaborated. The story, which ends with the brutal assassination of the man, begins with Dikeledi's arrival at the prison where she has been sentenced to a term of life imprisonment. On her entrance and after being recorded in the prison's dossiers, she is greeted by the wardress: "'So, you have killed your husband, have you? You'll be in good company. We have four other women here for the same crime. It's becoming the fashion these days.'" (CT, 88) Dikeledi meets her fellow prisoners and they tell each other the stories of their respective lives and crimes. By thus beginning her story with the judicial and penal reprisal for husband murder, Bessie Head as writer recasts her protagonist's crime in political terms, suggesting the kind of structural and affiliative reorganization, bonding rather than bondage, of male–female relationships necessitated by the cleavages in the traditional social order.

Bessie Head was born in 1937 in South Africa of mixed parentage. Her mother, a white woman, gave birth to her daughter in an insane asylum to which she had been officially confined as the result of her sexual relations with a black man. After attending a mission school and completing her teacher training, the future writer arrived in 1964 in Botswana as a refugee and in 1979 took Botswanan citizenship. Her literary production includes not only the volume of short stories but three novels and a more recent work, *Serowe: Village of the Rain Wind*, which is the social history of an African community based on interviews she herself conducted with the village's inhabitants. The project of this last work of documentary and social record is already contained in her earlier fiction where each of the actions of her individual characters is located in its historical context. Thus Dikeledi's husband in "The collector of treasures" is presented as analyzable "over three time spans:" before the colonial invasion of Africa, during the colonial era and the period of migratory mining labor to South Africa, and in the age of African independence. It is this man who is accused by the writer as being "responsible for the complete breakdown of family life." (CT, 91–2) Dikeledi's husband murder must thus be judged as a historical action, determined by African history as a challenge to that same history.

Although the prison writing of Third World women does not necessarily conform to generic criteria and specifications as formulated by a western critical or literary tradition, ranging as that writing does from short story to autobiographical testimony or political documentary and confounding thereby even the categorical distinction between fiction and nonfiction, it does nonetheless propose alternative parameters for the definition and articulation of literary conventions. Formal criteria are obliged to yield to the insistence of ideological and political exigencies in deciding the ascendancy of form and the alliances amongst texts and writers. Nor are these formal categories, literary or textualized, without a parallel set of distinctions imposed on the prisoners from within the prison system itself. Important among these distinctions concerning the classification of prisoners is that, maintained by the state judicial apparatus and manipulated by the prison authorities, between common law inmates and political detainees, between those serving sentences for criminal

offenses, that is, and those being held on account of their political activities. These activities include the act of writing itself. In Egypt's al-Qanatir prison for women where Nawal al-Saadawi was held, it was "forbidden to speak with politicals." On Robben Island, however, the prison officials began their punitive practice by attempting to use common law prisoners to factionalize and divide the political prisoners amongst themselves. Indres Naidoo describes in *Robben Island* the defeat engineered by the political prisoners of these divisive tactics on the part of the authorities. The common law prisoners ended by being convinced of the political programs of their fellow inmates. So too al-Qanatir's common law prisoners formed alliances, albeit sometimes ambiguous, with the political detainees, even at times acting as conduits for messages and communication to and from the outside world. No more than common law or criminal prisoners can be separated from political detainees can literary genres be isolated from their political and ideological context and consequences.

The authorial distance between Bessie Head and her female character Dikeledi, a distance by means of which the writer is able to interpret the woman's individuality as politically significant, is recast in Nawal al-Saadawi's *Woman at Point Zero*. Like Etel Adnan's *Sitt Marie Rose* which calls itself a "novel" but recounts the actual abduction and execution during the Lebanese civil war of a Christian Lebanese woman by Christian militias, *Woman at Point Zero* merges the requirements of fiction and narrative form with the historical and sociological demands of biography. *Woman at Point Zero* is the story of Firdaus, a former prostitute and female prisoner awaiting execution in al-Qanatir prison for the murder of a wealthy and influential pimp. It is framed by the writer's own story of her encounter with the prisoner. Firdaus's story is the history of an Egyptian peasant girl victimized by the conservative indigenous traditions of her country and exploited by the post-colonial corruption which characterized Egyptian society and government, particularly under Anwar Sadat. Like Maria's Aunt Helen in US activist Agnes Smedley's own autobiographical novel *Daughter of Earth*,[29] Firdaus prefers prostitution to marriage as a way of life, for as a successful prostitute she is independent and self-supporting, free

to choose the men with whom she will associate. She responds to the threat of compromising that independence with murder. In prison, despite sympathetic encouragement from wardresses and the prison doctor, Firdaus remains intransigent, refusing to receive visitors or even to appeal to the higher authority of the Egyptian president to remand her execution order. Her agreement at last to meet with Nawal al-Saadawi and to tell her story signals more importantly, and in contrast to her previous refusals, the permission that will allow her individual act of challenge and defiance to become part of the public record of social opposition to the authoritarian political structures and patriarchal hierarchies of Egyptian society. The peasant-woman prostitute's murder of her rich pimp consciously allies itself here with the task of the woman writer and doctor as part of a collective struggle. Firdaus's personal story ends with her execution in 1974, but the narrative of her life becomes part of a historical agenda.

Nawal al-Saadawi, a leading Egyptian feminist, spokesperson of the left, doctor, and writer, met Firdaus in 1973, when she began research on neurosis in Egyptian women. It was, as it turned out, an opportune moment to embark on the project, because, as she relates in the preface to the English translation of her novel,

> At the end of 1972 the Minister of Health had removed me from my functions as Director of Health Education and Editor-in-Chief of the magazine *Health*. This was one more consequence of the path I had chosen as a feminist author and novelist whose views were viewed unfavourably by the authorities.
>
> (WPZ, i)

The consequences of that path would prove still more extreme and her affiliations with Firdaus would be solidified on other grounds than authorship. Eight years later, in September 1981, Nawal al-Saadawi was herself an inmate, a political detainee, in the al-Qanatir women's prison, imprisoned not for crimes against her husband or a client, but for alleged crimes against the state, against Sadat's Egypt. One month before he was assassinated, on 6 October 1981, by members of an extreme Islamic fundamentalist

organization, Anwar Sadat had ordered the mass arrest without warrant and detention without trial of several thousand Egyptians[30] representing the entire spectrum of political opposition in Egypt, from extreme rightwing religious fundamentalists to members of the left-oriented, Nasserite Progressive Union party. Those arrested included Muslim shaykhs, Coptic priests and veiled women as well as prominent intellectuals and politicians. *Memoirs from the Women's Prison* is al-Saadawi's account of her own experience of incarceration.

The narrative of her months in prison (following Sadat's assassination, his successor Hosni Mubarak began a gradual process of releasing the political detainees) is organized by al-Saadawi on one level around the tension of conflicting personal allegiances and social ties, an ideological conflict brought out most dramatically by the physical impenetrability of the prison walls. Her family, her husband (who himself spent thirteen years in prison, first under King Farouq and then later under Abdel Nasser), her daughter and son, remain at home, in the Giza apartment whose door, as she repeatedly, obsessively, recalls throughout the narrative, was destroyed by the arresting officers. In al-Qanatir, the political feminist shares a cell with other detainees of various persuasions, some of whom are old friends or acquaintances with like sympathies, while others, still veiled, represent Islamic conservatism. The cell-mates are occasionally joined in their hours in the exercise yard by the common law prisoners otherwise kept in separate quarters and forbidden association with the "politicals." Among this latter group of women who have committed criminal offenses, it is Fatiha, the "murderess" who killed her husband with a hoe when she found him raping their daughter, who poses the most serious challenge to the conventional forms of social bonding and relationships. The hoe, the lethal weapon with which she murdered her husband, is also, as an agricultural implement, symbolic of the peasant's vital attachment to the Egyptian land.

At the same time that her attachment to her family has been interrupted, Nawal al-Saadawi's concern for affiliation with her fellow inmates is thwarted by forms of dissension which divide Egyptian social life outside the prison walls and the failure on the part of the women to recognize, within the differences, political,

religious, and civil, which distinguish them, their common cause in opposition to a repressive state apparatus. The day after release into the embrace of her family on 25 November 1981, Nawal al-Saadawi returns with her husband to al-Qanatir prison to visit those women still in detention with packages of food and messages from the outside world. The door to her apartment which the members of Sadat's secret service had smashed remained, even after her release from prison, ajar. Her prison memoirs, which conclude with that return to the prison and her work to secure the release of the other detainees, no less than her story of Firdaus, and like Bessie Head's "Collector of treasures," provide for a secularized re-evaluation of the repressive social structure. Like the charges of "sectarian sedition" which riddled Egyptian society in the last days of the Sadat regime, determinations of gender are recast in each case by being given a role to play in altering the larger political and social order.

The merging of the categories of common law prisoners and political detainees entails as well the emergence of a mutual and reciprocal relationship between writer and character. The distance between the two positions which had been maintained in Bessie Head's story of Dikeledi Mokopi or even in Nawal al-Saadawi's life history of Firdaus is collapsed when writing itself becomes an offense against the state punishable by law and a prison sentence. Nawal al-Saadawi, unlike either Dikeledi or Firdaus, is arrested because she writes and the very act of writing assumes a different, less conventional significance. Writing, on the one hand, no longer distinguishes her from other women in the society, but rather links her to them in their respective opposition to the reprisals of authoritarian structures. On the other hand, it is still through her writing that the isolated acts of violent aggression or vengeance of these women find collective meaning as the expression of a popular struggle.

"'Sister, are you still here?'" is the prison diary of Akhtar Baluch, a Sindhi woman prisoner held in Pakistan jails in 1970 for participation in the agitation and opposition to the repression by the hegemonic Punjabi majority of Pakistan's national minorities. The people of Sindh, like the Baluch and the populations of the North West Frontier Province, all oppose, more or less actively and intensely, the Islamabad regime which has denied

them use of their own languages, excluded them from governmental positions and systematically exploited their territories.[31]

Akhtar Baluch's diary begins with her entry into the central prison on 25 July 1970, and the recollection of her previous sojourn in the same place six months earlier.

> Mingled with enthusiasm and joy, there was [at the time] a little fear as to what it would be like in prison. But today, when I was coming to jail I had no fear or apprehension. I felt as if I was going home.
>
> No sooner had I opened the door of the women's ward than I saw Sister Farooq. For a moment I was overjoyed with the thought that she was there. But when she came running to me and embraced me, I was reminded of the time that had passed between 1969 and 1970 and I asked her in surprise: "Sister, are you still here?" Tears came to my eyes and I noticed that she was also wiping away the tears.
>
> Sister is in jail on the charge of having murdered her husband. (S, 222–3)

During the period of her imprisonment Akhtar Baluch is transferred several times from one prison facility to another. In each of these institutions she, like Dikeledi or Nawal al-Saadawi, forms new friendships and alliances with the women who share her cell. The importance that these bonds assume in her social and political perspective is such that on the occasion of her return to one of these prisons, she will say, as she had said on entering the prison when first arrested, "I was so anxious to get in. I felt as if I had returned home from a foreign land." (S, 241)

Most of the female inmates whom she encounters in these prisons are there on similar charges to the one against Sister Farooq. They are accompanied by their children, many of whom grow up in prison, a testimony to both the repression of women in Pakistani society and their refusal to submit to traditions and conventions. Yet even though filial ties between mothers and children remain strong within and without the prison, the familial basis of the social structure is being challenged by the national, secular movements. "Occasionally," Akhtar Baluch writes in her diary, "I remember my home and family. Otherwise

I feel that ever since I came into the world I have been seeing these women." (S, 241) The letters and visits from her own family, her mother, and her brother, exhort her to steadfastness in her commitment first of all to her political ideals. "One can cure the pains of the nation," her brother reminds her in a letter, "of the oppressed people and of painstricken humanity only if one is able to be indifferent – or, rather, harsh – to oneself and to one's own." (S, 225) Thus, too, her mother writes her, reformulating the conflictive and heartrending demands of filial devotion in terms of the larger shared affiliations of a collective worldwide resistance struggle for liberation:

> I am very proud of you, but I am only worried about your health. Sometimes I fear that your nerves will be shattered. Then I think that the Palestinian Laila also had a mother, and Qurat-al-Ain Tahira also had a mother. The hundreds of Vietnamese also have mothers. The nation whose women and men have courage will live forever; it will never be a slave. This is merely imprisonment, but we won't be shaken up even if they hang you. We all have to die one day. It is a thousand times preferable to die on the battlefield than to die in bed. (S, 240)

Here again, as in "The collector of treasures" and in Nawal al-Saadawi's prison experience, the political detainee discovers her common lot with her fellow prisoners and in her diary rewrites the social order to include a vision of new relational possibilities which transgress ethnic, class, and racial divisions as well as family ties.

The relationship between family and other forms of collectivity remains significant, indeed crucial, in the prison memoirs of political detainees. This effort to reformulate the authoritarian imposition of familial obligations as part of a collective political struggle is furthermore not specific to women's prison narratives. Both Mu'in Basisu and Ngugi recount in their prison diaries the programmatic manipulation by the state prison of the prisoners' family ties and loyalties as a means of coercion. In *Descent into the Water* and *Detained*, Egyptian authorities and their Kenyan counterparts promise the subjugated but still defiant prisoners visits from their wives if they will at least agree to cooperate in

their punishment and the state's investigations. The prisoners' continued refusal to participate in these repressive conventions, however, bespeaks a continued commitment to the reconstruction of the ideological system. According to Althusser, the ideological state apparatuses, such as prisons, the army, the police, and the courts, whether they operate on religious, educational, family, legal, political, trade union, or cultural levels, "may be not only the *stake*, but also the *site* of the class struggle."[32]

Domitila Barrios de Chungara's autobiography, *Let Me Speak*, announces itself not as an autobiography but as a "testimony." Like Saint Augustine's *Confessions*, her life's narrative recounts a conversion and that narrative, like Wordsworth's "Prelude," describes the author's discovery of her identity. Domitila's conversion, however, is not a religious experience but a political process, and the identity which is revealed to her is not that of an artist or poet but the identity of a Bolivian miner's wife who speaks from out of an understanding of her collective self constituted of nationality, class, and gender.

Central to her narrative, which begins with a description of her people and concludes with her participation in the International Women's Tribunal in Mexico City, is her prison experience in Bolivian jails. Twice Domitila was arrested by the Bolivian police for her activities, which included a march on La Paz and a hunger strike, as a leader of the Housewives Committee supporting the miners' demands for improved wages and living and working conditions. During each of her stays in prison the Bolivian miner's wife is brutalized and obliged to make choices contradicting her sense of self both as mother and as woman. The first time she is arrested Domitila is threatened with alleged danger to her children and then asked by the DIC, the Bolivian Intelligence Agency, to sign the children over to the Miners' Council for safe custody. Domitila refuses to submit and capitulate, responding to the female representatives who have visited her:

> "Look, señora," I said. "My children are my property, not the state's. And so if the state has now decided to murder my children in that underground room where you say they are, well then, let them murder them. I think that will weigh on their consciences, because I won't be guilty of their crime." (LMS, 127–8)

When she is released, Domitila discovers that her children had not even been imprisoned. The second time that she is arrested, however, Domitila is pregnant and nearing the time of her delivery. At one point the colonel's son enters the cell in order to abuse her physically and to force her psychological resistance. Domitila protects herself and her unborn child from the man's brutality by biting him until the skin is torn from his hand. Her child, however, does not survive its birth in her isolation cell:

> Finally I was able to find the body and I tried giving it warmth from my body. I took it and wrapped it up in my dress. I had it on my stomach, covering it to give it warmth, even though it was very little I could give. Its little head was like a bag of bones that sounded "poc, poc, poc." I touched its whole body and found out it was a little boy.
>
> And I passed out again. (LMS, 149)

Following her release from her second term in prison, Domitila is exiled with her family to the mountain region of Los Yungas. The result, however, of combined prison experience and the assault on her personal identity leaves more than physical scars. In Los Yungas, she reads the books sent her by her father, and, she says, "I identified fully with what I read about Marxism." She then continues:

> That gave me strength to go on struggling. I thought, I've dreamed about this since I was little and now I have to work and begin to uphold this doctrine in order to go on, no?
>
> Also, with everything I'd suffered in the arrests, in jail, and in Los Yungas, I'd acquired a political consciousness. In other words, I'd found myself. (LMS, 160)

In 1963 the South African government passed the "Ninety Day" law. According to this law, any commissioned officer was authorized to "arrest and detain in custody any person whom he suspected of having committed or intending to commit offenses under the Suppression of Communism Act, Unlawful Organizations Act, or Sabotage Act, or possessing information relating to such offenses." During the prisoner's detention there were no

visits allowed, except from a magistrate who was obliged to visit once a week. The ninety-day periods were renewable at the discretion of the officer until the detainee was considered to have satisfactorily answered all questions put to him or her.[33] Although the law was suspended in 1964, it was not rescinded. Detention without trial is still part of South Africa's legal apparatus. The title of Ruth First's prison memoirs, *117 Days*, derives from this law. Arrested for an initial period of ninety days, Ruth First was immediately re-arrested as she stepped into the street from the police station following her release. Twenty-seven days later she was returned, without explanation, to her home, her mother, and her children. "When they left me in my own house at last I was convinced that it was not the end, that they would come again." (*Days*, 142) In 1982 Ruth First was assassinated by a letter bomb.

Her arrest under the Ninety Day law was not Ruth First's first experience with the police apparatus of the South African state. Earlier, bans had already prohibited her from continuing her journalistic work and she had turned from writing to research, and the cataloging and classification of books. She was arrested for active membership in the African National Congress as she was leaving the main reading room of the university library. Detained in the same period were many other leaders of the movement, including Nelson Mandela and Dennis Brutus. Like the memoirs of Nawal al-Saadawi and Akhtar Baluch, Ruth First's narrative is more than a testimony to her personal suffering in a South African jail. Her own experience is again contextualized within a social analysis of the structure of the prison system. Her text moves from descriptions of her own experience to accounts of the arrest and torture of other political detainees whose stories have reached her. Critical to her own private ordeal is the program of collective solidarity which sustained the individual prisoners and her greatest fear and point of vulnerability was this, that the interrogators would persuade her comrades to believe that she had betrayed them.

The very resistance of the prisoners, as she recounts it, led the prison authorities of apartheid to abandon their habitual and systematic discrimination between male and female, white and black.

> At first torture was reserved for Africans alone. But Ninety Day detention had not been in force 14 months when torture was turned against the whites, even though one of the most sacred laws of apartheid had been, up to then, that whites, all whites, any whites, are different from Africans, and must be handled apart, even in jails. (*Days*, 133)

Nor was the sanctity of the white woman any longer to be protected indiscriminately and wives were locked up to pressure their husbands. The solidarity of the African National Congress had not been established on principles of race or gender, but on the basis of collective opposition to apartheid rule, and the prison authorities and state legal system were obliged finally to submit to this collectivity.

The prison service itself, on the other hand, was organized by contrast, a contrast Ruth First insists on, around familial ties and built on the arbitrary loyalties such ties engender. Many of the wardresses, for example, encountered by First during her 117 days incarceration, were "police widows," women, that is, who had been compensated for their husbands' deaths with employment in the prison. Prison service, she observes, seems "to run in families and a policeman's daughter becomes a wardress to keep the service in the family." (*Days*, 67) *117 Days* is thus the account not only of the detainee's sustained commitment to the struggle against apartheid, but also a critique of the prison system based on a cooptation of family loyalties, implicating as well determinations of gender, race, and class, and in the service of a repressive political order. The critical distinction between "filiation" and "affiliation" also distinguishes between the reactionary state apparatus and the progressive struggle against racism and sexual or religious discrimination. "To criticize the racial nature of the law," Ruth First comments early in her narrative, "or the use of police to enforce it is to insult a policeman's mother or his religion." Summoning filial pieties to their side, "the dingy police stations keep the sacred flame of racism burning in countless outposts throughout the country." (*Days*, 30)

For Domitila Barrios de Chungara, prison experience was the turning point in her life history and it divides her narrative in half. Ruth First's memoirs are calculated on the 117 days she

spent in prison under the Ninety Day detention law. *My Home My Prison*, the autobiography of Raymonda Tawil, a Palestinian woman living under Israeli occupation, is in turn framed by her period in custody, under house arrest, a punishment imposed by the Israeli occupation authorities for her outspoken resistance to the injustices of military occupation against the Palestinian population. According to the conditions of house arrest, the prisoner is kept under constant surveillance and is not allowed to leave his or her residence. Although at the beginning of her confinement Raymonda Tawil was permitted to receive telephone calls and visitors, these too were soon restricted when it became clear that her case was acquiring an effective notoriety. Within this narrative framework, then, and restricted to her home, Raymonda Tawil recounts her life story. It is a story structured by flight (*hurūb*), exile (*ghurbah*), loss, struggle, and steadfastness (*sumūd*), a personal story which is presented as indissociable from the collective history of the Palestinian people. The events of her private life are insistently juxtaposed throughout her narrative with significant moments in Palestinian history: the birth of one of her children and the June war of 1967, or her arrest and the fall of the Tal al-Zaatar refugee camp in Lebanon to the Phalange forces in 1976. Her struggle furthermore is waged against both the patriarchal structure of traditional Palestinian society and the repressive force of the Israeli state and the occupation authorities. In order to travel, for example, she must secure not only the Israeli government's permission but her husband's acquiescence as well. The polyvalence of the title of her memoirs, *My Home My Prison*, is critical then to the liberation agenda, the vision of a new secularism, which these women, Akhtar Baluch, Ruth First, Domitila Barrios de Chungara, Bessie Head, and Nawal al-Saadawi, like Raymonda Tawil, are in the process of elaborating.

For many Third World women, feminism means women's liberation, and women's liberation is seen as part of a popular struggle against forces of oppression. Such a struggle must have its roots in the material conditions of the people themselves, but must also contain the possibilities for a larger collective vision. The active role of women in the national liberation struggles and resistance movements of the Third World has contributed significantly to an

articulation of political ideology in their countries which transcends the distinctions of gender, race, and ethnicity. According to Samora Machel, for example, late president of Mozambique, in his essay "The liberation of women is a fundamental necessity for the revolution,"

> The antagonistic contradiction is not between women and men, but between women and the social order, between all exploited people, both men and women, and the social order. . . . Therefore, just as there can be no revolution without the liberation of men, the struggle for women's emancipation cannot succeed without the victory of the revolution.[34]

The forbidden use of "we"

Although it would be dangerously distortive to deny or suppress the historical specificity of each of these memoirs, their embeddedness in the particular conditions of the social and political structures within which they are produced, the prison memoirs of Third World political detainees do suggest a collective history and a self-consciousness about that literary and ideological solidarity. Ngugi, for example, sees himself writing already within a tradition and cites exemplary predecessors, from Kenya as in the case of J. M. Kariuki's *Mau Mau Detainee*,[35] from Africa with Nigerian Wole Soyinka's *The Man Died*,[36] and elsewhere when he opens his diary with a quotation from the Palestinian poet Mahmud Darwish.

> O you with bloodshot eyes and bloody hands,
> Night is short-lived,
> The detention room lasts not forever,
> Nor yet the links of chains.[37]

Molefe Pheto and Breytenbach likewise refer in their memoirs to former and contemporary victims of state authority, as does Mu'in Basisu who keeps company with other writers in detention. The narratives of detention, however, form more than a literary sodality or coterie and describe as well the various strategies within the prison framework for establishing new modes of affiliation.

The very fact of physical communication and contact assumes crucial significance inside penitentiaries where prisoners are routinely subjected to extreme brutal treatment and in many cases torture. The UN Declaration against Torture, which was adopted on 9 December 1975, defines torture in the following way (although the last clause, as Amnesty International has asserted, seriously impedes its effectiveness):

> For the purpose of this Declaration, torture means any act by which severe pain or suffering, whether physical or mental, is intentionally inflicted by or at the instigation of a public official on a person for such purposes as obtaining from him or a third person information or confession, punishing him for an act he has committed, or intimidating him or other persons. It does not include pain or suffering arising only from, inherent in or incidental to, lawful sanctions to the extent consistent with the Standard Minimum Rules for the Treatment of Prisoners.
>
> (TE, 13)

Jacobo Timerman, an Argentinian journalist, imprisoned by the state for his public criticisms of "disappearances" and other human rights abuses in Argentina, was detained, held in solitary confinement, and tortured in 1977. His memoirs, *Prisoner without a Name, Cell without a Number*, open with his sudden transfer to a new cell. As he is adjusting to the dampness and closeness and regretting the luxury of his former cell with at least its "hole in the ground in which to urinate and defecate," he notices that the peephole in his door has been left ajar. These observation holes, common to all prisons, usually open only to allow the guards to monitor the cell's occupant. What Timerman then describes is the contact established and developed with the prisoner in the cell across the hall. Only his eye is visible:

> And now I must talk about you, about that long night we spent together, during which you were my brother, my father, my son, my friend. Or, are you a woman? If so, we passed that night as lovers. You were merely an eye, yet you too remember that night, don't you? Later, I was told that you'd died, that you had a weak heart and couldn't survive the "machine," but they

> didn't mention whether you were a man or a woman. How can you have died, considering that night we conquered death?

The long passage of the memoir which follows articulates the mute gestures of a relationship which then occur. The eye winks. It disappears and is replaced by a nose. A finger caresses the nose. Then the cheek. And so on.[38] The fragmented parts of the individual tortured body are reconstituted through this social drama which defies the prison's walls and structured regimen of punishment.

It is significant that the UN Declaration against Torture includes in its definition of torture not only physical pain or suffering but mental as well. The deleterious effects, often causing permanent psychological damage, of solitary confinement have been well established and documented by examining physicians, psychologists, and human rights activists. (TE, 18–26) Isolation is also central to the prison memoirs. Ruth First, for example, begins her narrative with a description of how "For the first fifty-six days of my detention in solitary I changed from a mainly vertical to a mainly horizontal creature". (*Days*, 7) Molefe Pheto too presents an account of how prison-imposed isolation assaults the prisoner's own sense of identity:

> Detention in South Africa is incommunicado. There is no habeas corpus. No lawyer, no member of one's family, no doctor and no priest is allowed to see detainees. Detainees live and survive on suspension, tension and hope. The cut-off is complete as a black night. Many break down not out of cowardice, but out of concern for their loved ones left to fend for themselves. (ANF, 18)

The techniques of control, developed and refined to ever greater degrees of precision and effectiveness,[39] engender in turn specific forms of resistance and subversion amongst the prisoners. The one-way observational control of the Benthamite panopticon which had served in the nineteenth century as a model for prisons and factories alike,[40] and whose modern counterpart is the "peephole," was undermined, for example, in the meaningful exchange between Timerman and his fellow inmate.

Solitary confinement, however, has served multiple functions in the history of the penal institution. Whereas it was once enforced for "corrective" purposes by allowing the prisoner to look into himself, to introspect and meditate on the nature of his crime and eventually be guided to the right ways, it is also employed to destroy the psychological integrity of the isolated prisoner. There is also the further authoritarian effect, which Pavarini points out, that of the "destruction through solitary confinement of every *parallel* relation (between prisoner-workers, between 'equals'); the emphasis through discipline, on *vertical* relations alone (between superior–inferior, between different kinds of people)."[41] Critical to the ideology of the prison apparatus is the elimination of any collective or relational sense on the part of its victims, a sense which the political prisoners struggle to maintain as part of their strategy of resistance. As Indres Naidoo points out, on Robben Island

> Every warder and officer would tell us that prison regulations forbade us to use the word "we," that we were in prison as individuals and not as a group, but we would persist in saying "we" and "us" when speaking to those in charge, however high their rank. (RI, 241)

This resistance project is again evident in Pheto's maneuver which seeks to thwart the presumed invulnerability of the authorities and their collaborators:

> One of my major preoccupations in prison was planning how effectively I could pass on the little I had learned, seen and observed during interrogation, the goings on of informers there, and who they were. How could I disseminate information that would keep our surveillance at its sharpest? (ANF, 92)

Such a strategy contributes to the elaboration of a new tradition and chain of transmission, a prison culture of political opposition and resistance.

The effectiveness of political detainees in obstructing the procedures and system of discipline within the prison that Naidoo

and Pheto presented in their memoirs is again represented in Sherif Hetata's novelistic reconstruction of the years he spent in Egyptian prisons, *The Eye with an Iron Lid*.[42] The imposition of schedule and routine inside the prison, together with the unpredictable and arbitrary disruptions and distortions of the schedule, is, like solitary confinement, highly effective in depriving the prisoner of a grasp of his place and disposition in time and space – and thereby of his historical existence as well. When warder Abdel Ghaffar is transferred from his charge in the criminal section of the prison to that of the political detainees with directions from above to restore order, rules, regulations, and discipline amongst them, the detainees retaliate and succeed in reasserting their collective sway. By insisting that ordinances be followed precisely, and yet slowing the process of implementation to an impossible degree, they maneuver themselves into a negotiating position with the jailor who must maintain his reputation and job with his own superiors, the prison authorities. The prisoners will do what is required for his position if Abdel Ghaffar will allow them certain liberties, such as free access to each other's cells, newspapers, writing materials, etc. Thus the vertical, hierarchical relations on which the prison system depends are shown to be vulnerable, even on their own terms, and are broken down. A gradual process of collective awareness and activity emerges.

This strategic alliance involves not only interactions between prisoners and warders, but amongst criminals and political detainees as well. The problematic distinction, the arbitrariness of which is so evident in the women's prison memoirs, is one that the state finds it necessary to maintain if it is to perpetuate its own authority. Indeed, as Angela Davis points out in *If They Come in the Morning*, it often happens that "A political event is reduced to a criminal event in order to affirm the absolute invulnerability of the existing order."[43] There is this difference, however, as Herbert Marcuse maintains, that "The robber and murderer leave the head that can punish them intact and thus give punishment its chance; but rebellion 'attacks punishment itself' and thereby not just disparate portions of the existing order, but this order itself."[44] What happens in Manuel Puig's novel of prison, *Kiss of the Spider Woman*,[45] which takes place in an Argentinian prison,

in a cell occupied by a Communist activist and a homosexual hairdresser manipulated as an informer by the prison officials against his cellmate, is the gradual destruction of the state's authority and the growing solidarity between the two prisoners. Just as Molina comes to see his homosexuality as having social and political consequences, so do the Israeli criminal prisoners find common cause with the Palestinian political detainees in Uri Barbash's film *Beyond the Walls*. Collectively the two groups initiate a hunger strike against the prison administration and its policy of racial and religious segregation.

The forbidden use of "we," in prison discipline as in the conventions of autobiography, is challenged by the writing of the prison memoirs of political detainees. One of the most extreme examples of this challenge is to be found in *Carlos, the Dawn is No Longer Beyond Our Reach*, by Tomas Borgè, Sandinista guerrilla and now Nicaragua's Minister of Interior. Carlos Fonseca, together with Borge and Silvio Mayorga, was one of the three original founders of the FSLN. Borge's memoir of Carlos Fonseca was written in prison, where the guerrilla first heard the news of Fonseca's death.

> The commander at the Tipitapa prison came to my small cell, jubilant, with a copy of *Novedades* in his hands. He gave me the news: "Carlos Fonseca is dead," he said. After a few moments of silence, I answered: "You're wrong, colonel. Carlos Fonseca is one of the dead who never die." The colonel said, "You guys are something else."[46]

V

Commitment to the future: utopia, dystopia, and post-independence developments

Two facts stand out as one looks at the history of the Third World since World War II. On the one hand, the countries of these regions have gone from political success to political success; successes located individually in the rise of various independence and nationalist movements and in the achievement of their goals against often fierce resistance by colonial or imperial powers, and located collectively in such expressions as the psychological shock of the Bandung Conference of the 1950s, the flourishing of the non-aligned movement of the 1960s, the power of OPEC in the 1970s. On the other hand, despite all these political successes, despite all the revolutions, despite the defeats suffered by the United States, and Western Europe, the economic situation in these countries taken as a whole is distinctly worse in the 1980s than it was in the 1950s. The gap has widened. At the very best, the governments in a few countries, through herculean effort, have managed to prevent too much deterioration in overall revenues and internal social differentiation.

Immanuel Wallerstein – "Crisis as transition"

Utopian vision and dystopian reality

In his contribution to the volume *Dynamics of Global Crisis*, co-authored in 1982 with Samir Amin, Giovanni Arrighi, and

Andre Gunder Frank, the economist and historian of world systems theory Immanuel Wallerstein pointed to a "pattern of apparent political success and economic disaster" in Third World nations.[1] The contradictions between the utopian goals and visions once expressed by the leaders, ideologues, even the participants, in the national liberation movements and resistance organizations of the previous decades and their ultimate failure of realization on the achievement of independence were manifest in the social discontent and economic disorder of the various new nations. Failure took different forms, often according to the means by which independence had been gained.

Egypt, where the Free Officers had overthrown the monarchy in a military coup in 1952, experimented first with Nasser's socialism and then with Sadat's capitalism, while the population increased and the disparities between rich and poor intensified. Cuba, however, set an example for other Third World countries in 1959 when the oppressive Batista regime was toppled in the popular revolution led by Fidel Castro, but its economy continues to suffer under pressure and boycotts from a United States fearful of its influence in the region. In 1960, two years after Achebe published his novel *Things Fall Apart*, Nigeria was granted its independence by Britain. Six years later, he wrote *Man of the People*,[2] exposing the decadence and corruption of the new regime and its bureaucrats. Algeria's successful but bloody liberation struggle begun in 1954 against French colonization culminated in 1962 with Ben Bella's attempt at a socialist government, which was met three years later, in 1965, with what some considered a counter-revolution when Boumedienne and the army stepped in. Even the Arabization program in education and government in Algeria was stalled when it was found that the French had, over a period of 150 years, effectively eliminated competent literary users of the language except in the religious domain. Together with Algeria, in 1962, and following a protracted and violent war, Kenya too had achieved independence. But the subsequent ideological contest as to who could claim responsibility and credit for independence, the Mau Mau movement or Kenya's new president Jomo Kenyatta, severely divided the country. As in Nigeria, corruption and repression characterized the new government under both Kenyatta and his successor

Daniel Arap Moi. The former Portuguese colonies of Mozambique, Angola, and Guinea-Bissau, were likewise liberated in 1974–5. As is the case with Nicaragua, however, which was finally able to overthrow the Somoza regime in July 1979, their efforts at national reconstruction have been seriously obstructed by persistent efforts on the part of hegemonic powers, from the United States to South Africa, to destabilize their governments. In the passage, whether violent and revolutionary or gradual and reformist, from national liberation to national reconstruction, these nations which have emerged out of organized resistance movements confront the "problem of the leap between theory and practice which haunts all utopias."[3]

Ghana, in 1957, was the first African country to win its independence. Already in 1951 the opposition, led by Kwame Nkrumah, to British rule in the country, known then as the Gold Coast, had succeeded in securing constitutional independence. It was, however, nominal independence only, "primary decolonization," and left the British bureaucratic and institutional structure of control intact. When political independence did come in 1957, the effects of this compromise were such as to ensure the continuation of British influence through those Ghanaian politicians and functionaries who had participated in the interim government. In 1966, Nkrumah, president of independent Ghana, was deposed in a military *coup d'état*. Two years later, Ayi Kwei Armah's first novel appeared, entitled *The Beautyful Ones Are Not Yet Born*.[4] The novel's title betrays the sense of historical failure and lack of fulfillment which attaches to post-independence Ghana and which the novel examines in its story of an unnamed clerk in the national railroad office at the time of Nkrumah's overthrow.

"The man," as he is referred to throughout the novel, is distinguished for his incorruptibility in a society which is portrayed as surviving on nothing but the offal of its own corruption. He refuses, for example, to accept a bribe from the lumber contractor who visits the office one evening after hours attempting to secure space on the freight train for his felled timber lying rotting in the forest. The next morning the man arrives in the office to find the booking clerk accepting the money and arranging the necessary space. In the meantime, however, the man's wife has berated him

for his scruples, calling him a "chichidodo." "The chichidodo is a bird," she says. "The chichidodo hates excrement with all its soul. But the chichidodo only feeds on maggots, and you know that maggots grow best inside the lavatory." (BOANYB, 45) Not even the teacher, the man's confidant and moral refuge, whom he visits later that evening, is able to condemn the woman's demands that her husband profit as do his friends and colleagues from the system in which he lives and works. "You have not done what everybody is doing . . . and in this world that is one of the crimes. You have always known that." (BOANYB, 54)

The man's former schoolfriend, by contrast, Koomson, has succeeded well as a minister in the government and is able to offer the man's wife and her mother the opportunity to participate in a deal on a fishing boat which he plans to purchase. What he needs, however, is a name, the name of some one of the "people," under which the boat can be registered. The negotiations with his family are completed, much to the man's disgust and revulsion, and, in return for their name, the woman and her mother receive occasional fresh fish for dinner. Later, with the change of government, the same Koomson, now panic-stricken and in fear for his life, is obliged to seek help from his friend, who secretes him to safety through the hole in the outdoor latrine behind his house, the ironic revenge perhaps of the chichidodo bird. But not even the *coup d'état* promises redemption for the man in the novel. Returning home after seeing Koomson safely out to sea on his fishing boat now put to other uses, he must pass a roadblock set up outside the city. He watches as a small bus successfully bribes its way through the police barrier and disappears up the road. "Behind it, the green paint was brightened with an inscription carefully lettered to form an oval shape:

> THE BEAUTYFUL ONES
> ARE NOT YET BORN." (BOANYB, 183)

Armah's first novel has received considerable critical attention since it was published and, as Robert Fraser points out in his review of the criticism, it is especially Armah's "wholesale disgust at the antics of African politicians [that] has been noticed by everybody."[5] The political parable in the novel is patent: Nkrumah is

referred to explicitly by the name he arrogated to himself, Osagyefo, "victor in war," as the six o'clock news comes over the radio into the man's home. "Osagyefo the President bla bla, Osagyefo the President bla bla bla, Osagyefo the President bla bla bla bla." (BOANYB, 127) Koomson's pedigree too, which takes him back to the pre-constitution dockers' strike, identifies him clearly as one of the functionaries who have profited from the political compromises of the early 1950s. And downtown, in front of the "Atlantic-Caprice Hotel," there passes a "procession of gleaming cars reminding the watcher of long lines of OAU men in American vehicles." (BOANYB, 100)

The Beautyful Ones Are Not Yet Born, however, is concerned with more than a universal or categorical parable, or even a negative futurology of a world into which the "beautyful ones" might yet be born. The surface viscosity of the novel, which excretes spittle, vomit, phlegm, and excrement, only barely overlays the historical conditions which produced the contemporary putrefaction. The cedi notes, for example, which have purchased passage for the early morning commuters and which the bus conductor sniffs as he counts his proceeds have absorbed the bodily odors, and more, of the persons through whose hands they have passed.

> Fascinated, he breathed it slowly into his lungs. It was a most unexpected smell for something so new to have; it was a very old smell, very strong and so very rotten that the stench itself came with a curious satisfying pleasure. Strange that a man could have so many cedis pass through his hands and yet not really know their smell. (BOANYB, 3)

The trash receptacles on the streets of the city which had been part of a major public campaign proclaimed in order to beautify the area have not been emptied since they were put in place. The garbage mounts around each container, but "as yet the box was still visible above it all, though the writing upon it could no longer be read." (BOANYB, 8) It is the palimpsestic wooden banister, however, which accompanies the cement stairs leading to the man's office in the building inscribed with the words RAILWAY & HARBOUR ADMINISTRATION BLOCK MCMXXVII (BOANYB, 11) which

most palpably secretes the years of handling behind its present condition:

> The sight was like that of a very long piece of diseased skin. The banister had originally been a wooden one, and to this time it was still possible to see, in the deepest of the cracks between the swellings of other matter, a dubious piece of deeply aged brown wood. And there were many cracks, though most of them did not reach all the way down to the wood underneath. They were no longer sharp, the cracks, but all rounded out and smoothed, consumed by some soft, gentle process of decay. In places the wood seemed to have been painted over, but that must have been long ago indeed. For a long time only polish, different kinds of wood and floor polish, had been used. It would be impossible to calculate how much polish on how many rags the wood on the stair banister had seen, but there was certainly enough Ronuk and Mansion splashed there to give the place its now indelible reek of putrid turpentine. What had been going on there and was going on now and would go on and on through all the years ahead was a species of war carried on in the silence of long ages, a struggle in which only the keen, uncanny eyes and ears of lunatic seers could detect the deceiving, easy breathing of the strugglers. (BOANYB, 12)

For Frantz Fanon, writing "On national culture" in *The Wretched of the Earth*,

> The problem is to get to know what these men mean to give their people, the kind of social relations that they decide to set up and the conception that they have of the future of humanity. It is this that counts; everything else is mystification, signifying nothing.[6]

Kwame Nkrumah, who led Ghana through its tortured agreements and confrontations with the British colonial authorities, has been called among African leaders the "visionary Pan-Africanist."[7] His plans for Ghana were part of his utopian view that the future of Africa was both cultural and political and he called on the collective African peoples to assert their common

cause and their common identity against the economic and political hegemony of the western powers over Africa.

Nkrumah, whose early education was in Ghana, had continued his university studies in the United States, where he was much influenced by the thinking of W. E. B. DuBois. He returned to Ghana in 1947 after spending two years in London, where he made the acquaintance of George Padmore and C. L. R. James from the West Indies, became active in the West African Students' Union, and participated in the Sixth Pan-African Congress which met at the end of 1945. His return to Ghana was at the invitation of the United Gold Coast Convention (UGCC) who asked him to become general secretary of the new nationalist party. Nkrumah agreed, but with reservations, for the leaders of the UGCC were largely businessmen, lawyers, and "men of substance."[8] When Nkrumah was dismissed from the UGCC for political differences he was joined by other younger members of the convention and they formed the Convention People's Party (CPP), which was based on the premise of a broad base of mass support.

These political differences, evident in Armah's novel, between the bourgeois nationalist interests of the leadership of the UGCC and the socialist aspirations of Nkrumah and the CPP continued through the period of constitutional independence and into political independence, and certainly contributed to the popular, as well as establishment, dissatisfaction which led to his overthrow. But there were other, equally ideological, criticisms of Nkrumah, such as the personality cult which he himself encouraged that grew up around him, the Osagyefo image which appears in *The Beautyful Ones*. As his pan-Africanism grew, it seemed that his commitment to Ghana and its immediate problems diminished. He was acknowledged as playing a crucial role in the establishment of the Organization of African Unity (OAU) in 1963, but in Ghana his one-party system and the increasing economic chaos were producing social and political unrest. The contradictions, however, were not unique to Ghana. As Munira, the school teacher in Ngugi's novel *Petals of Blood*, says with regard to government construction projects in post-colonial Kenya: "Why, I asked myself, had they not built smaller serviceable roads before thinking of international highways?"[9] When the coup in

Ghana took place which replaced him with a military government, Nkrumah was on OAU business in Peking and planning to travel on to Hanoi. He died in exile in a Roumanian hospital in 1972.

In his lifetime Nkrumah had magnificently captured the imagination and committed support of Third World leaders and peoples alike. His personal and political failures then forced a critical re-evaluation not only of the ideological bases of his political philosophy, but also of the man himself and the relationship between political figures and their historical situations. For Basil Davidson, the British historian of Africa, the issue lay less in the question of Nkrumah's personal integrity and commitment, or even in his political vision, than in the particular historical situation within which Nkrumah worked. He concludes his study of the statesman, *Black Star: a View of the Life and Times of Kwame Nkrumah*, written shortly after Nkrumah's death, by claiming that

> The struggle for liberation has to be understood for what experience has amply shown it to be: a difficult choice between possible alternatives, none of which can offer a "pure" gain, but only, at the best, a greater gain than loss. (BS, 212)

C. L. R. James, who had been one of Nkrumah's earliest supporters, was similarly interested in the co-implication of the revolutionary leader and the liberation struggle. In the 1963 introduction to his study of Toussaint l'Ouverture and the San Domingo revolution, *The Black Jacobins*, written some thirty years earlier, James had raised at length the problem of this co-implication and its consequences for historiography and analytical narrative:

> The writing of history becomes ever more difficult. The power of God or the weakness of man, Christianity or the divine right of kings to govern wrong, can easily be made responsible for the downfall of states and the birth of new societies. Such elementary conceptions lend themselves willingly to narrative treatment and from Tacitus to Macaulay, from Thucydides to Green, the traditionally famous historians have been more

> artist than scientist. They wrote so well because they saw so little. Today by a natural reaction we tend to a personification of the social forces, great men being merely or nearly instruments in the hands of economic destiny. As so often the truth does not lie in between. Great men make history, but only such history as it is possible for them to make. Their freedom of achievement is limited by the necessities of their environment. To portray the limits of those necessities and the realisation, complete or partial, of all possibilities, that is the true business of the historian.[10]

James's later study of Nkrumah, *Nkrumah and the Ghana Revolution*, was divided on the problem. The first part, and by far the larger part, of the book ends its narrative with Ghana's independence in 1957. The second part consists of a series of critical letters written to Nkrumah during his presidency by the author and two essays on the politics of government and the political situation in Africa. The longer of them is entitled "Lenin and the problem" and presents Lenin's critique of the three major enemies then (in 1921) confronting Soviet Russia: communist vanity, illiteracy, and bribery. (NGR, 199) Thirty years later, James implies, the same enemies were besieging from within their own system the newly independent nations of Africa.

Armah's novel *The Beautyful Ones are Not Yet Born* is part of this historiographical intervention into the record of promise and failure, of utopian vision and dystopian reality, in modern Ghana. The man's long discursive meditation in chapter six on Ghana's historical past and his own personal participation in it, which interrupts the narrative of bleak excretions, introduces an analytic dimension into the storied parable. The man here rehearses his childhood, his schooling, and the picture of the "old manchild" in the book of freaks and oddities which a classmate had brought in; he reflects on war and violence, and his experiments smoking *wee* and Kofi Billy's suicide, and the Teacher. "How long," he asks, "will Africa be cursed with its leaders?" (BOANYB, 80) Like the wood of the banister in the railway building beneath the accretions of wax, polish, and grime and eroded by cracks, the discursive analysis, as Robert Fraser points out in his study of Armah's novels, offers nothing but itself. (NAKA, 27–9)

Even the historical dimension which has been opened up in the reflexive meditation seems to present no promise, project no change. The novel's title also provides its concluding statement. Nonetheless Armah as writer and critic has written into his dystopian representation of independent Ghana the immanent historical consciousness which counters the absolutism of political parable.

Commitment and alienation

The psychological and internalized tension experienced by the man in Armah's novel between his commitment to the ideals of social justice, equity, and the once promised revolutionary transformation of Africa on the one hand and his present alienation from the degraded Ghanaian society on the other is a historical tension, one which has its sources in the larger political and cultural development of Third World nations within the global dynamics of the twentieth century and their background in nineteenth century imperialism and colonialism. That tension embodied in the man's personal predicament can be found again in the literary history of Egypt in the two decades following the Free Officers revolution in 1952 in which a group of young army officers led by Gamal Abdel Nasser seized power in the country, forcing King Farouq to flee abroad.

As the Egyptian critic Sabri Hafez has pointed out in his article "The Egyptian novel in the sixties," the characteristic feature of Egyptian novel writing during the fifties was its "realism," that it dealt with "problems of a patriotic nature." "The social, intellectual, economic or political themes," Hafez writes,

> interweave, somehow, with the national cause, and contribute to its development. Patriotic concerns provide the focal point in most novels, and the writer's attitudes are perpetually directed against his country's enemies and the obstacles which stand in the way of Egypt's progress. The typical hero in these novels engages all his intellectual and physical activities in the task of transforming external reality.[11]

The sense of commitment, "engagement," *iltizām*, which pervaded the narratives in a determinate way, yielded, however,

in the following decade, the second and, as it turned out, final decade of the rule of Nasser, who was succeeded by Anwar Sadat when he died in 1970, to stories that were characterized by alienation: personal, political, and economic *ightirāb*.[12]

The main character of Sonallah Ibrahim's short novel, written in 1964 and entitled *The Smell of It*[13] (a title that itself evokes the physical atmosphere of Armah's *The Beautyful Ones are Not Yet Born*), exemplifies this alienation. Like the work's author, who in 1964 was released from detention in Egyptian penitentiaries after serving five years for political activities, this character has just been released from prison. The story opens with the bureaucratic details of his deliverance:

> "What's your address?" said the officer.
> "I haven't got one," I said.
> "Where, then, are you off to? Where are you going to stay?" He looked at me in amazement.
> "I don't know," I said. "I have no one."
> "I can't let you go off just like that," said the officer.
> "I used to live on my own," I said.
> "We have to know your whereabouts," he said, "so we can come and see you each evening. A policeman will be going with you." (SI, 1)

The bureaucracy will relentlessly pursue the man throughout the story as he makes his way aimlessly about the streets of Cairo. The only aim available to him is that he be at home when the officer arrives to check on his presence and have him sign the register proving his orderly whereabouts. After all, as one policeman efficiently informs him while the authorities attempt to find some regular place to deposit him on his release, "'You're a real problem and we can't just let you be.'" (SI, 2) The irony of the policeman's statement is that the former detainee's own sense of who or what he might ever be, were the officials to "just let him be," is already wholly undermined and highly suspect even to himself.

Sonallah Ibrahim, today a member of one of Egypt's leading opposition parties, the Nasserist Hizb al-Tagammu' or the Progressive Union Party, belonged to that group of Egyptian writers

who referred to themselves at the time as the "younger generation" or the "generation of the sixties." All leftist intellectuals, these writers were characterized by self-examination and disillusionment. They professed scorn for past literary and cultural achievements and tended to reject the cultural domination of the traditional classical forms. It was a generation which declared itself a "fatherless generation."[14] The sense of orphanhood, dramatized already in the opening lines of Ibrahim's novel where the protagonist insists that he has no address, is further thematized in the subsequent narrative. His brother refuses to take him in and his friend has his sister staying with him. His father had died earlier after divorcing his mother and, when, in the novel, he finally finds his mother's house, she too had died. This orphanhood, or bereftness, however, is not reducible to the existential anguish of the absurd, of the sort, for example, that has been so systematically attributed to Meursault in Camus's *L'Étranger*. Estrangement and alienation, even if essential in some way to the "human condition," figure just as critically in the dialectics of the historical condition and are conditioned as much by material conditions as by individual or collective psychologies. In the case of Meursault, for example, to read his predicament as "absurd" is to deny the historical consequences of his murder of the Arab whom Camus himself refused to name. The Algerians would later hold him responsible, as Ahmed Taleb had done in his open letter written to Camus in 1959 from a French prison.

Although existentialism enjoyed a certain vogue in Arab intellectual circles, it soon revealed to many its limitations in responding to the urgent social and political demands of the contemporary Arab world. Sahar Khalifeh, a Palestinian novelist from the West Bank, described in an interview her own move from existentialism to Marxism:

> You see, being a Marxist you have to sacrifice certain things; as a privileged individual related to the privileged class, the luxury of having thoughts and not having to carry them into reality. A characteristic of the individualists, of the existentialists, is that when trying to solve problems, they go ahead and then when they face a very, very big problem, which needs a lot of effort not for the individual himself, but for a community,

> a communal effort, they stop and cannot continue. They make instead this spiritual leap: they either solve it by going back to religion, the supernatural, or find it absurd. They are aware that the individual, if he is a genius, can solve many problems; but as an individual he cannot solve big, big social problems.[15]

More decisive even than the philosophical debate over existentialism for this "younger generation" of the Egyptian sixties was the massive defeat inflicted on the Egyptian army by Israel in the June war of 1967, now commemorated as the *naksah* or "setback."

Already in 1964, however, when Sonallah Ibrahim wrote his short novel, the popular and intellectual disaffection was palpable. The Nasser revolution had produced, in addition to its immediate successes in liberating Egypt from colonial occupation, introducing considerable land reform measures and nationalizing the Suez Canal, what Raymond Baker has called a "bureaucratic feudalism" which combined an enormous state machinery and administrative apparatus with personalized power.[16] Furthermore, if Nkrumah had been the exemplar of pan-Africanism, Nasser was the hero of pan-Arabism. By 1964, however, Egypt's attempted union with Syria, the United Arab Republic, initiated in 1958, had collapsed and in 1961 Nasser had committed Egyptian troops to a disastrous war in Yemen. More so even than Ghana's independence which in its early phases had been sustained by broad-based popular support, Egypt's liberation always retained some of the problematic qualities of a revolution "from above." In the decade of the sixties, the contradictions between the utopian projections and their actual implementations were many and drastic. As Sabri Hafez makes clear in his essay on the Egyptian novel:

> The sixties was indeed a decade of confusion, a decade of numerous huge projects and the abolition of almost all political activities; massive industrialization and the absolute absence of freedom; the construction of the High Dam and the destruction of the spirit of opposition; the expansion of free education and the collective arrest of the intellectuals; the reclamation of thousands of acres and the catastrophic detachment of the Sinai

> peninsula from Egyptian territory in the defeat of 1967; severe censorship and the emergence of evasive jargon among the intellectuals; the deformation of social values and the pervasive growth of corruption. During this decade, there was no public activity not subject to official control, everywhere one encountered not living but official beings concealing their individual personalities beneath a carapace of conformity, people who acted out social roles and repeated, automatically, slogans that were often contrary to their real hidden fortunes. (ENS, 171)

The main character of *The Smell of It*, an aspiring writer newly released from prison and still unfamiliar with the "strange" world of Cairene daily life and customs, takes on something of the character of the voyager in classical utopian literature who comments on the marvels and peculiarities of this eccentric land into which he has by chance or fate arrived. This device of "revisiting" one's country following a significant absence or a crucial political event plays an important role in contemporary Arabic literature which must come to terms with the radical, sometimes catastrophic, changes taking place on the national landscapes. The Egyptian writer Gamal al-Ghitani, for example, in his collection of vignettes entitled *The Book of Revelations* portrays a visit made by the deceased Abdel Nasser to the city of Cairo following the conclusion of the Camp David Accords.[17] In Palestinian literature too, the celebrated "return" to the homeland often occurs as a temporary visit made to former residences across the border and the narratives, such as Ghassan Kanafani's "Return to Haifa" or Emile Habibi's "Ikhtayyah,"[18] are concerned to show the combined dismay, horror, accommodation, and resistance felt by the visitors at the alterations wreaked in their land.

In the Egypt of *The Smell of It*, in direct contradiction to Nasser's professed socialism, it is consumerism, western-style, which has pervaded the traditional social organization.

> My sister's fiancé said that he had been looking at a heater. He had bought a fridge.
> "Does anyone know someone who's going abroad who could bring me back a tape-recorder?" he said.

> Husniyya's uncle came along and took them all off to the cinema. (SI, 20)

Or again:

> Adil said that the chauffeur of his uncle Fahmi Bey didn't get up before ten in the morning, while Fahmi Bey himself was up at dawn.
> "I'll show you the best place to buy a soap-dish."
> My sister said that she needed a servant, but where could she get one from?
> Her fiancé said he's asked someone coming from Beirut to bring him a Ronson lighter. (SI, 27)

And again:

> Husniyya's fiancé came along. He said he'd arranged his desk at the Ministry marvellously. He'd got a large sheet of thick glass covering it. On the right was a fine desk diary he'd got from abroad, while in the center was an ivory ink-stand the likes of which were no longer to be had. (SI, 31)

Like the wife of the man in Armah's *The Beautyful Ones are Not Yet Born* who wants a wig of her own like that of Koomson's wife but is instead obliged for want of money to straighten her hair herself, these Cairo consumers find their current inspiration in the neo-colonial culture of western capital.

In his children's story, *Locusts in the City*, the Syrian Zakariya Tamer found a traditional image, the locusts, to describe the new forms of occupation experienced by the Arab Middle East.[19] For Sonallah Ibrahim, however, the images are taken from the cultural production of the west, from Albert Camus to Alfred Hitchcock. While the young man attempts to persuade his friend Samiyya that she ought to read *The Plague* (SI, 17), his sister invites him to see a film: "'Let's go to the cinema,' said my sister, and off we went. It was a film about birds that grew in number and size until they became savage, chasing people and attacking children." (SI, 6) The blight that has fallen on the land results, in part, from its own internal contradictions, but it is exacerbated by

a conflict still imposed, even after national liberation, from without. The disoriented traveller here is a stranger in his own land, and the utopian discoveries are perceptions of dystopian failures. The commitment of the past has become the alienation of the present. Geopolitical dislocations combine with historical contradictions to ensure that his release from prison is not a moment of liberation or even of escape. There is, it seems, no place for him to go, but he must nevertheless be there when the policeman comes for him to sign the book. The short novel concludes:

> I looked at my watch. It was getting near to the time for my appointment with the policeman. I got to my feet.
> "I must go now," I said.
> I said good-bye to them and went down the stairs and out of the house. I crossed the side roads until I came to Ramses Square, then I turned off in the direction of the Metro tram stop.
>
> (SI, 56)

The Smell of It's claustrophobic oppressiveness is manifest even in the text's use of language, as in these sentences, which is almost entirely devoid of all adjectives, the qualifiers which would transform the brute fact of reality into possibility and change. Unlike the narratives of resistance, with their open-ended histories and critical elaboration of new social and political formations, the dystopian visions of neo-colonialism suggest instead historical foreclosure and cultural bankruptcy. "'There's the smell of kaka,'" the small child says disingenuously in Sonallah Ibrahim's novel to the young man who "affected to pass it over." (SI, 16)

"Return to Haifa"

In their discussion of the "critical" and "constructive" modes of utopianism in the study *The Politics of Utopia: a Study in Theory and Practice*, Barbara Goodwin and Keith Taylor maintain that "The basis of utopia's claim to be taken seriously as political theory is its critical analysis of socio-political reality, as much as its ideal vision." (POU, 17) The form of the utopian work, of course, varies historically, in significant part according to the

literary and ideological protocols dominant in the age in which the work is produced, from political tract to philosophical treatise to didactic novel. While the narratives of resistance, such as *To Bury Our Fathers* or *A Ride on the Whirlwind*, do present the "critical analysis of socio-political reality" that Goodwin and Taylor acknowledge as a crucial part of utopia's contribution to political theory, their vision of the future social order is not always decisively elaborated. In such novels, it is rather out of a dialectical interaction with the material and historical conditions of the world in which they intervene and in which they are co-implicated that the ideological contours of the order they project are to be inferred. The journey made by Said S. and his wife Safiya back through historical time and across national and ideological borders in Ghassan Kanafani's short novel "Return to Haifa" brings the Palestinian couple to confront the failure of their own anachronistic ideals. The narrative itself draws out of that confrontation the projection of future possibilities as they are found and analyzed in the present circumstances. As such the novel participates in the theoretical and practical debate within the resistance organization as to not only the goals but also the strategies relevant at a given historical moment to attaining those goals.

In the fall of 1982, following the Israeli invasion of Lebanon in June of that year, the departure of the PLO fedayeen from Beirut in August, and Israel's subsequent military occupation of a large part of the Shuf mountains and southern Lebanon, the Israeli authorities opened the borders between southern Lebanon and Galilee, allowing free passage to visitors wishing to cross the frontier in either direction. Palestinians who had lived as refugees in Lebanon since their flight from Palestine during the first Arab-Israeli war in 1948, or who had come later as a result of the June war of 1967, were thus permitted, many for the first time since leaving, to visit the homes and families they had left behind in northern Galilee. Their visit, however, was precisely that, a visit, temporary and strictly delimited, not the long anticipated "return," or *auda*, to the homeland which for many, refugees, combatants, and ideologues alike, has become consecrated as the vision of the future of Palestine.

"Return to Haifa," which was written in 1969, is set fifteen years prior to the 1982 invasion of Lebanon, in the days immediately

following the June war of 1967. As they were later to do again in Lebanon, the Israelis had just opened the border, the famous "green line," between Israel and what had become, as a result of the war, the Occupied Territories: Gaza, which until then had been administered by Egypt, and the west bank of the Jordan River, under Jordanian rule since its annexation by the Hashemite kingdom in 1950. The novella tells the story of Said S. and his wife Safiya, a Palestinian couple living in the West Bank town of Ramallah, and their "return to Haifa" after the border is opened to them.

It is 30 June 1967, nearly twenty years since that Wednesday morning, the twenty-first of April 1948, when the young couple had fled by sea from the fighting in the streets of Haifa. Haifa was just then about to fall to the attacking Jewish forces of the Haganah who, with the help of the British Mandate troops, were seeking to secure by force what further areas of Palestine they could appropriate before the United Nations Partition Plan, decided on in November 1947, went into effect on 15 May 1948, upon the termination of the British Mandate and the withdrawal from Palestine of the British occupying forces. "'They opened the borders right away all of a sudden as soon as they put an end to the occupation,'" Said tells his wife as they enter in June 1967 the still familiar outskirts of the city.

> "You remember the disaster that happened in April 1948? And now? After all, why? Because of the blackness of your eyes and mine? No, that's part of the war. They tell us: you'll be glad to see how much we've improved your lot. You just have to accept that you're going to have to serve us, and admire us for it. But you'll see for yourself. Nothing's changed. . . . It's just that we can make it a whole lot better." (PC, 101)

The decision to visit Haifa did not come easily to Said and Safiya, who, during the several weeks following the war, had struggled with the trauma of defeat and their fear of confronting the past, the nightmare hidden in their memories. Finally one morning Said said to his wife:

> "In Jerusalem and Nablus and here the people talk every day about their visits to Jaffa and Acre and Tel Aviv and Haifa and

> Safad and the villages of Galilee and all that area. They all say the same thing and it seems they all thought it would be better than what they saw there with their own eyes. All of them returned carrying with them a huge defeat. The miracle the Jews talk about is nothing but a delusion. In the country here ugliness is the work of evil. It's the contrary of what they wanted when they opened their borders to us. That's why I'm afraid, Safiya, that they're going to cancel this decision very soon. So I said to myself, why don't we take advantage of the opportunity and go." (PC, 109–10)

The historical situation and circumstances of Kanafani's novel, the immediate aftermath of the June war of 1967 in which the Israeli army had inflicted a massive defeat not only on the Egyptian military forces but also on the very ideals of pan-Arabism on which the Palestinian aspirations for deliverance and a victorious return to their homeland had largely been based, are critical to the political and psychological journey made by Said and Safiya from Ramallah to Haifa and back to Ramallah again. It was a moment of intense self-criticism. This self-criticism, so apparent in the "dystopian fables" of post- and neo-colonialism, figures critically in the "utopian projects" of resistance movements.

In "Return to Haifa" historical and narrative time are conflated. The journey made by Said S. and his wife through Jerusalem's now open Mandelbaum Gate, the scene of years of anguished separations, leave-takings, and frustrated encounters,[20] and across the border takes place over a period of just twenty-four hours, from 30 June to 1 July 1967, the date of their return. The husband and wife are returning now to look for their son, Khaldun, left behind twenty years earlier when they fled Haifa in the midst of confusion, terror, and panic,[21] and to revisit the house they had all once lived in. From this conflation of historical and narrative time, and the confrontation of two peoples such a conflation brings about, a future possibility emerges. Said S. and Safiya find their former home inhabited by Mariam, the widow of Evrat Kushen, themselves both refugees from Nazi-occupied Poland, who had arrived in Palestine in March of 1948. The Jewish Agency, which had sponsored their immigration to Palestine, and the Bureau of Absentee Property

which was disposing of the lands and homes of the Palestinians who had fled during the hostilities, had given them a place to live. That place turned out to be the home of Said and Safiya, and with the home the Kushens received a child as well, the five-month-old infant, abandoned in the turmoil, of the Palestinian couple. This son, adopted by Evrat and Mariam, and who has been renamed Dov, is now a recruit in the Israeli army.

"Return to Haifa" represents Kanafani's effort to project in literature the vision of a "democratic solution" for the future of Palestine. "'When we came here,'" Said says to Mariam at the conclusion of their meeting,

> "we were going against history. And also, I admit to you, when we left Haifa. But all of this is temporary. Do you know something, madam? It seems to me that every Palestinian will pay a price. I know many who have paid with their sons. I know because I too in a strange way have paid with my son. But I paid with him at a cost. . . . This was my first lesson and it's a difficult one to explain." (PC, 137–8)

It is, however, a lesson which Kanafani, as writer, critic, and active participant in the Palestinian resistance movement, attempted to elaborate, contributing significantly to the ideological and tactical debates within the resistance organizations.

The confrontation that takes place between Said and Safiya, the Palestinian couple, and Mariam, the Israeli widow, whether or not this is the first fully developed representation of the Israeli in Palestinian literature, as has been claimed, proposes a radical formulation of the basis to a solution of the Palestinian issue, that of the "democratic secular state." In 1969, when Kanafani wrote his short novel, Palestinian literature, like Arabic literature in general, had for the most part paid but little attention to developing any complex portrayal of the situation of Israeli Jews living now on the land of Palestine. Several years earlier, in 1966, Kanafani had presented a literary critical study of Zionist literature which concentrated on European or United States works such as Leon Uris's *Exodus* or Arthur Koestler's *Thieves in the Night*, examining in them the representation of the Arab and the ideological bases revealed in the literature for the foundations of

the Zionist state.[22] Koestler's novel, for example, is mentioned again in "Return to Haifa" as one of Evrat Kushen's few sources of information concerning the land to which he was emmigrating.

> When he was in Milan, he had read a novel *Thieves in the Night*, by Arthur Koestler. It was about a man coming from England to supervise the immigration operations. This man lived in these Galilean hills which Koestler had made the setting for his story. At that time [Evrat] really didn't know much at all about Palestine. (PC, 116)

Arthur Koestler's *Thieves in the Night*[23] was published in 1946, two years after the conclusion of World War II, and describes the Zionist experiment in socialism, the kibbutzim, in the 1930s in Palestine. Here too the problems confronted by the social experiment are represented as both internal to the utopian settlement, the contradictions, that is, between individualistic ambitions and desires on the one hand and the demands of collective endeavor on the other, and external, the need to maintain the sectarian integrity of the community against incursions from without. The hostile antagonism between the religiously and ethnically identified Zionist settlements and the Arab population of Palestine which is described in Koestler's novel provides the historical background and conditioning for the meeting thirty years later between Said S. and Mariam Kushen.

In "Return to Haifa", it is Dov himself, their lost son, who confronts his natural parents with their self-deception. "'I didn't know,'" he tells Said, his father,

> "that Mariam and Evrat were not my parents until three or four years ago. Ever since I was a child, I've been Jewish. I went to the synagogue and to the Jewish school. I ate kosher food and studied Hebrew. When they told me that I wasn't their son, nothing changed. And when they told me after that that my original parents were Arab, still nothing changed. Nothing at all. That much is certain. . . . In the end, it's man who is the issue." (PC, 131)[24]

Khaldun is now serving his term of duty in the Israeli army. "'I'm in the army reserves,'" he goes on.

> "And until now I haven't been in a real battle, so I can't describe my feelings to you. But perhaps sometime in the future I can reassure you once again of what I am going to tell you now: I trace my origins to here, to this place. This woman is my mother. You two, I don't know you, and standing face to face with you, I don't feel any special feelings." (PC, 132)

Aloud, Said asks himself in response to Dov/Khaldun's statement:

> "What is the homeland? Is it these two chairs which have been in this home for twenty years? The table? The peacock feathers? The picture of Jerusalem on the wall? The copper door bolt? The oak tree? The balcony? What is the homeland? Khaldun? Our dreams about him? Parents? Children? What is the homeland?" (PC, 134)

Implied in this meeting between father and son is Kanafani's controversial critique of the formula of a democratic secular state, a critique directed toward the Palestinian resistance movement itself. The basis of this critique, as deployed by Kanafani in the novel and elsewhere in his theoretical and political writings,[25] is that any vision of a democratic secular state as the future of Palestine, "Palestine tomorrow" as it is referred to in the 1971 seminal article by Nabil Shaath,[26] one of the proposal's original spokesmen and theoreticians, must be developed and implemented by a progressive and democratic revolutionary movement. Implicit, of course, in such a position is the rejection on ideological grounds of the so-called "two-state solution" to the Israeli–Palestinian question. Such a solution, that there be a Palestinian state established in the West Bank and Gaza Strip which would co-exist alongside the Israeli state within its pre-1967 borders, seen at least from the radical perspective of Kanafani and the Marxist-Leninist PFLP, represents, at best, the bourgeois nationalism of al-Fatah, or, at worst, the racist version of Zionist ideology.

The goal of the Palestinian resistance movement of a "democratic secular state" in all of Palestine for Muslims, Christians, and Jews alike had been subjected to substantial debate since it was formally introduced by al-Fatah when it took control of the PLO in 1968. In August of 1973, at the eleventh meeting of the Palestine National Council (PNC), the Palestinian parliament-in-exile, the possibility of a Palestinian state alongside Israel was raised as part of the organization's agenda. When the PNC met in Cairo for the twelfth time in June 1974, it was agreed to alter the immediate goal to that of establishing a Palestinian state "in any part of Palestine from which Israel will withdraw or which will be liberated." The vision of a "democratic secular state" was officially retained only as a future ideal, the vision of a long-term goal.[27] The vision, however, continues to animate Palestinian literature of resistance.

Fictions of the future

Among the undertakings designed to facilitate trained understanding and constructive global policy-making which have been initiated by the recently established United Nations University is a series of major regional research projects in the Third World. The volume *Images of the Arab Future*, by a research team headed by the Egyptian sociologist Ismail-Sabri Abdalla, is the written result of the first of these projects which was entitled "Arab alternative futures." The researchers' task was to investigate current socio-economic conditions in the Arab world, their internal and local dimensions, and the specific relation of these to the more generalized conditions of the world situation, in order to propose strategies for future Arab development. For the researchers, it was clear that in order to

> avoid the illusions, fallacies and pitfalls of technological forecasting, [it is necessary to] elaborate a theory of development which gives reciprocal relations and effects (between technological change on the one hand and the political–economic–social order in its entirety on the other) their due.[28]

In discussing the bases of their own methodology and critical perspective, they insist on the further need to distinguish between

"long-term planning" and "prophecy." Long-term planning, they maintain, represents a "conscious intervention to re-shape socio-economic structures through a set of integrated policies formulated by a central authority which disposes of the means to pursue and follow up these policies and to create the objective conditions necessary for their implementation." Prophecy, by contrast, is "based on the naive notion that the future is predetermined and that all we can do is to reveal that future." (IAF, 15)

For the theoreticians and political strategists of resistance organizations and national liberation movements, however, what is necessary is an ideological "projective narrative"[29] which would combine these two modes of elaborating the future, long-term planning and prophecy. Long-term planning alone is unavailable to the immediate struggle of the resistance organizations in that they do not control the central authority or all the material and technical means necessary to effective implementation. The long-term vision thus also contains some element of the prophetic in that that vision insists on the eventual historical necessity of victory. Such prophecy speaks in the imperative slogans of the resistance movements, such as the Palestinian *thaura hata nasr*, "revolution until victory," or the chants, for example, that interrupt the poetry of Angolan Helder Neto: MPLA AVAAAAANCAAA!, or even the Nicaraguan *El pueblo unido jamás sera vencido!*, "the people united will never be defeated."

Nadine Gordimer's novel *July's People*,[30] which was published in 1981, extrapolates from the contemporary situation in South Africa a prophetic vision of what one future scenario for that country might be. Unlike Armah's *The Beautyful Ones are Not Yet Born* or Sonallah Ibrahim's *The Smell of It*, which are unrelenting critiques of their respective socio-political situations of post-colonialism, or unlike even Kanafani's "Return to Haifa", which for all its future trajectory remains deeply implicated in the contradictions of the present political moment, *July's People* attempts a dramatic, almost futurological, leap into the future. The novel tells the story of what might happen to a white middle class couple from Johannesburg, Maureen and Bam Smales, and their two children, should the black population of South Africa one

day succeed in wresting control of the country out of the hands of the white population and installing majority rule.

Maureen and Bam and their nuclear family are saved in the novel by their black servant July who takes them 600 kilometers overland by truck, the small yellow truck Bam had bought for himself for his pleasure/hunting trips, to his farm in his village. Bam and Maureen in these changed circumstances must attempt to adapt their "enlightened liberalism" to the altered relations of power in which, according to the novel's representation, they are now in the hands, if not at the mercy, of their former servant. The novel examines not only the interaction of black and white when confronted with this radical political transformation, but also the respective social structures of the interpersonal relationships of the Smales on the one hand and the collective, extended family of July's people on the other, and their possible coordination.

July's People presents only a partial scenario of this hypothetical revolutionary transformation, the suspended moment of transition that immediately follows when blacks assume power. The change in the political structure of South Africa as it is imagined by Gordimer in 1981 is seen as violent and destructive and is set in the historical context of the series of previous disturbances and social upheaval: the pass-burnings of the fifties, Sharpeville, Soweto '76, Elsie's River 1980. (JP, 8) This context conditions significantly the subsequent narrative of tension, antagonism, and failed understanding which culminates in Maureen's mad dash into the bush at the novel's conclusion:

> She runs: trusting herself with all the suppressed trust of a lifetime, alert, like a solitary animal at the season when animals neither seek a mate nor take care of the young, existing only for their lone survival, the enemy of all that would make claims of responsibility. She can still hear the beat, beyond those trees and those, and she runs towards it. She runs. (JP, 160)

Is her abrupt and unexplained departure to be interpreted as an existentialist escape into individualism or as a political intervention into a new collectivity in the making? *July's People*, which fails to account for its own outcome, is simultaneously utopian and dystopian, combining the hope that springs from the prospects

of revolutionary change with the fear of the consequences of such change, a fear conditioned by the hostilities and exploitative relations of power of the contemporary situation in South Africa.

The journey in the truck from a Johannesburg suburb to July's people is one which leads Maureen to feel that she has been "jolted out of chronology" (JP, 4) and left bereft of the support of history. The structural ambivalences of the narrative bespeak the problematic personal and historical situation of the author herself. Like Ann in Sipho Sepamla's *A Ride on the Whirlwind*, who contributes economic and material aid to the children's organization in Soweto but whose liberal scruples often conflict with the children's different sense of urgency and tactics, Nadine Gordimer's relation to organized resistance activity in South Africa is complicated by the exigencies of the particular moment and place in which she writes. As she presented the situation in the *New York Times Magazine* on 8 September 1985, in an article entitled "Guarding 'the gates of paradise:' a letter from Johannesburg," "We whites in South Africa present an updated version of the tale of the emperor's clothes; we are not aware of our nakedness – ethical, moral and fatal – clothed as we are in our own skin."[31]

July's People proposes, in the story it tells of the journey from present into future, a discursive relocation of those historical determinations and coordinates built into the characters' genealogical and ideological heritage as well as those embedded in the political and racial dynamics constitutive of South Africa's past and present. In *July's People*, written by a white woman who has refused to leave South Africa, the conflict is that between the reality of the present and the reconstruction of the future as these are defined and limited by the conflict between white and black, male and female, exploiter and exploited. According to Abdul JanMohamed,

> Nadine Gordimer finds that her skin color implies that she is an oppressor of blacks, yet her liberal, often radical, views make the whites see her as a traitor; she is caught between a perverse desire to leave South Africa, thereby avoiding the whole dilemma of racism, and a terrible, obstinate, and fearful desire to stay.[32]

In this Gordimer and the heroine of *July's People* differ from Ruth First as much as they resemble Sepamla's Ann. First, a white South African arrested by Pretoria for her active participation in the operations of the ANC, expressed in her prison memoirs the intense anxiety she felt during her detention that the prison authorities and examining magistrates would manipulate and misrepresent to her fellow inmates and "co-conspirators" the record of her interrogation.

> The Security Branch was beyond doubt planning an act of character assassination against me; I would not give them information out of loyalty to my friends, but they would break me finally with some carefully introduced indication that my friends had abandoned me because I had betrayed them, or so the Security Branch could arrange for the version to be told. This abandonment I would not be able to face; and even until it happened I did not have the strength to survive. There was only one way out, before I drove myself mad, and as the truest indication to anyone interested that I had not let the Security Branch have it all their own way. (*Days*, 128)

First's attempt at suicide fails and she eventually comes to the understanding that "the longer I stayed 'inside' the more certain my friends would be that I had not capitulated. There would be security in detention!" (*Days*, 130)

Women, liberation, and autobiography

During the residence of Maureen and Bam Smales among July's people in the projected aftermath of a social revolution in South Africa, July admonishes Maureen not to speak to his wife. By contrast, it is the Smales' daughter Gina who alone, and against the wishes of her parents, is able to learn the language and ways of the children of July's people, and who becomes an interacting part of her new community. The "problem of the leap between theory and practice which haunts all utopias" is addressed differently in the various utopian and dystopian critiques of the programs and agendas of resistance organizations both before and after liberation. The negative fictions such as *The Beautyful Ones* which point

to the failure of the leap are only partially mitigated by the ambivalences of a *July's People* which exhibits the personal and political contradictions obstructing such a leap. What allows, for example, Gina the ability to learn this new language among her new comrades? Even the aggressive self-analysis contained in Kanafani's "Return to Haifa" defers temporarily the question of political change in its allusion to armed struggle and Said's hope that his second son Khaled will have left home to join the fedayeen. The role of the armed struggle and the organized resistance movement in preparing the ideological transformation necessary for a popular-based social revolution emerges in very specific ways in the autobiographies of women activists in these movements. Like Gina of *July's People* and her playmate Nkiyo, the women are singled out by the radical changes in their social positions and relations, and their life histories recount not only their personal itinerary but also the historical agenda in which they participate.

In their article, "The British women's movement," part of a debate in the pages of *New Left Review* on the relationship between Marxism and feminism, Angela Weir and Elizabeth Wilson analyze the historical development and the present situation of the women's movement in Britain. The co-authors begin by pointing to the change in designation from "women's liberation movement" to "feminism" as significant in revealing divergent ideological tendencies within the various organizations constituting the contemporary movement. The term "women's liberation," they remind the reader, had earlier demonstrated an important and two-fold gesture, first, towards the sexual liberation of the sixties and then, at least as importantly, in the direction of the national liberation movements in other parts of the world. Whereas this latter gesture signalled a commitment to the "common revolutionary struggle of men and women," Weir and Wilson see the application of "feminism," especially in terms of radical feminism but also within socialist feminism, as perhaps "more restricted, more 'realistic,' less 'revolutionary.'"[33]

The autobiographies of Third World women, which range from the oral narratives of illiterate peasant women to the memoirs of the educated classes, include the narratives of women commandos and organizers in the resistance movements, such as *My People Shall Live* by the Palestinian Leila Khaled, Nicaraguan

Doris Tijerino's *Inside the Nicaraguan Revolution*, and *I . . . Rigoberta Menchu* by the Guatemalan Indian Rigoberta Menchu.[34] These texts constitute a new social history as well as a new literary corpus and as such they reopen the question, both theoretical and practical, of the relationship between the status and position of women in a given society and the revolutionary program of national liberation. They suggest a redefinition of the conceptual apparatus, whether Marxism or feminism, deployed in locating and orienting the question of "women" in specific contexts. In these autobiographical texts, context assumes a vital significance.

The issues of women and women's writing are, like the resistance organizations themselves, products of specific material historical and intellectual processes within specific societies and these processes must be integrated into any theoretical construction of the cross-cultural situation of women and the literary as well as political agenda which such a construction entails. Elizabeth Fernea, in the introduction to her anthology *Women and Family in the Middle East: New Voices of Change*, describes the women's writings in the volume as different to a large degree from the writings of western women:

> It seems to be that Middle Eastern women do not see the existing problems as exclusive to themselves. Over and over again, they say in different ways that the "feminine condition" cannot be separated from that of men, the family and the wider society. Self-identity is becoming important, but identity is still contextual.[35]

Insisting again on the need to anchor theoretical constructions of generalized problems in the historical specificity which informs a given experience, Domitila Barrios de Chungara, in her autobiography *Let Me Speak*, recounts her disappointment at the first United Nations-sponsored International Women's Tribunal which she attended in Mexico City in 1974. Urged there by western feminists to abandon her role in the "Housewives' Committee" and participate in their "sisterhood," Domitila writes in response, "For us the first and main task isn't to fight against our *companeros*, but with them to change the system we live in for

another." (LMS, 199) A similar appeal is again expressed by Ellen Musialela of the SWAPO Women's Council, in reference to the second United Nations women's conference held five years later:

> When we went to the United Nations Women's Conference in Copenhagen (1980), we were very disappointed by the women from the West. I don't mean the solidarity committees although it's up to them to put pressure to understand that it's we who feel the pinch. These women from Britain, West Germany and America were trying to force us to restrict ourselves to equality, development and peace, on grounds that if we went outside these topics we would be trying to bring in politics. But we can't see how we can otherwise talk about equality, because in Namibia both women and men are oppressed as people . . . we can't talk of peace because our country is at war. All these things have to be understood, so that women in the West appreciate the importance of solidarity with the women in the liberation movements and in the struggle.[36]

So too, like Gayatri Spivak who signals the "inbuilt colonialism of First World feminism toward the Third,"[37] Hazel Carby in her essay "White woman listen!" criticizes the tendency of western feminists to participate in the self-proclaimed "civilizing mission" of European and United States colonialism and imperialism:

> The feminist version of this ideology [of arranged marriages] presents Asian women as being in need of liberation, not in terms of their own herstory and needs, but *into* the "progressive" social mores and customs of the metropolitan West. The actual struggles the Asian women are involved in are ignored in favor of applying theories from the point of view of a more "advanced," more "progressive" outside observer.[38]

Leila Khaled became a commando in the PFLP, or Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine, after a series of affiliations with various Palestinian organizations in the early days of the resistance movement. As a student at the American University of Beirut, she had participated in the early sixties in the Arab Nationalist Movement (ANM) and then later, while a teacher in Kuwait, she was involved in the organization of al-Fatah.

In 1969 she was one of two fedayeen who hijacked the Tel Aviv bound TWA flight 840 from Rome, or, as Khaled formulates it in her autobiography, "expropriated an imperialist plane." (MPSL, 22) In that autobiography, the hijacker reports her conversation, en route to Rome to begin the operation, with a "clean-cut sociable American on his way to New York" who was in the seat next to her. It is a typical plane conversation between two travelers: where are you going? what are you going to do there? but Leila Khaled is disconcerted and hastily devises an answer. "'I am going to meet my fiancé who is coming from London to meet me in Rome in a few days.'"

The conversation goes on and the man asks her how it could be that an Arab girl would get married in Rome on her own, to which she answers that they are "modern, not traditional Arabs." Finally, the exchange concludes as they land in Rome with the man's ultimate question that comes in response to Leila Khaled's statement that, rather than spend her honeymoon on a Mediterranean cruise, as he had suggested, she would prefer to "be among people." "'Are you going to marry the people?'" he then asked. (MPSL, 130–2) The PFLP commando might well have answered "yes." Her autobiography, entitled *My People Shall Live*, which climaxes in the two hijackings in which Leila Khaled participated (the first ended in Damascus with the release of all the passengers, the second culminated in Britain in 1970 with Leila's arrest after Israeli security forces on the El Al plane killed the second hijacker), revolves to a certain extent around a juxtaposition of bourgeois and traditional marriages on the one hand and revolutionary organization on the other. Leila's orders to report for active duty had come while she was attending a wedding celebration with the squad commander, Bassim. "All was joy, all was fun. Bassim and I were beginning to fall in love. But before we could share in the pleasure of the occasion a messenger suddenly rushed in and handed me a two-word note: return immediately." (MPSL, 123)

Women participate in the militant and social activities of the resistance movements in various ways, from cadres to fundraisers, depending on the immediate needs of the organization as well as on the social and political structure within the movement's hierarchy. The continuing question of the form the

participation of women will take is furthermore central to the internal debates of the resistance movement, and involves, beyond the immediate tactical and strategic needs, the long-term vision of social revolution. In one of the major contributions to this debate within the PLO, published in 1977 in *Shu'un filastiniyya*, the journal of the PLO, Munir Shafiq[39] recognizes the traditionally submissive role of women in Palestinian society and the need for the revolution to transform that subservience into equal participation. He also claims, however, that the liberation of women can take place only through national liberation and must be seen within that context. Samora Machel, leader of Mozambique's FRELIMO, struck a different emphasis when he stated in 1973 that "the liberation of women is a fundamental necessity for the revolution, a guarantee for its continuity and a precondition for its victory."[40] For Leila Khaled, "If a woman decided to commit herself to this phase of the revolution [guerrilla activity] it meant the final break with the past and relegating her private life and desires to a secondary position." (MPSL, 118–19) When Leila and Bassim did eventually decide to get married, his family sent his sister Samirah from Baghdad to ascertain to their satisfaction that their son's bride was acceptable to the family. "Bassim and I," she writes, "had got engaged earlier with the approval of the Front. Neither family was consulted before the announcement." (MPSL, 169)

The decisive connection between personal liberation and Palestinian national liberation is integral to the structure of Leila Khaled's narrative of her life history. The written story begins with her origins in Haifa and her first conscious discovery that she has "historic roots, that [her] people have a history of struggle." (MPSL, 22) It concludes open-endedly, following her release from British custody after the second hijacking, with her marriage, suggesting that in fact, as the man on TWA flight 840 had asked only a year earlier, she would "marry the people."

> For the next few weeks, I spent most of my time giving press interviews and preparing to marry a fellow fighter, Bassim, an Iraqi Arab revolutionary. We got married on November 26, 1970, spent a week together and then returned to our separate tasks. (MPSL, 206)

In one of the earliest modern studies of Palestinian women, written in 1936 by Mrs Matiel E. T. Mogannem, a Palestinian woman from Jerusalem, the connection between the women's question and the national question is already foregrounded. Entitled *The Arab Woman and the Palestine Problem*, the book announces for itself a two-fold aim: "to present a faithful picture of the Arab woman and to explain the true facts of the Arab cause in Palestine."[41] The two questions, however, so intimately associated in Leila Khaled's memoir three decades later, are treated separately in Mogannem's early study. The constructive and materially transforming role of the organized resistance movement has in the intervening years again placed the question of the liberation of women centrally within the larger struggle for social revolution, not only in the Palestinian case but elsewhere throughout the world. In examining the role of "women in national liberation movements" in Africa, for example, Stephanie Urdang claims that

> Particularly important is the insistence that their fight stretches beyond victory on the battlefield to the more fundamental question of establishing a new and just society in each of their countries, one that brings to an end all forms of exploitation. Within this context, the liberation movements have all – in varying degrees – emphasized the liberation of women.
>
> (WNLM, 157)

The ideological developments which bring together in a collective agenda the two dimensions of personal narrative and historical project in Leila Khaled's memoir inform as well Doris Tijerino's autobiography, *Inside the Nicaraguan Revolution*. Unlike Leila Khaled, who grew up after 1948 as a refugee in Lebanon, Doris Tijerino came from the relatively settled and comfortable background of a prosperous farm in northern Nicaragua. In her narrative, and in contrast to her bourgeois background, the question of marriage plays a minimal role, almost disappearing into the larger account of her initiation into the ranks of the resistance organization. Her marriage takes place while Tijerino is studying in the Soviet Union and receives but short mention in a single paragraph inserted into that educational

process. "I married in the Soviet Union in 1964 – an Ecuadorian comrade studying agronomy but who preferred literature – a poet. In 1965 my first child was born and I immediately went back to my country. Later, in 1967, I separated from this comrade." (INR, 65)

The autobiographies of Third World women in general, but more particularly of those women who have been active participants in the national liberation movements in their countries, provide, as do the prison memoirs of political detainees, a striking contrast to the conventional, more "traditional" protocols of women's autobiography in the west. According to Estelle C. Jelinek in her introductory essay to the critical anthology, *Women's Autobiography*, women's autobiographies "emphasize to a much lesser extent the public aspects of their lives, the affairs of the world, or even their careers, and concentrate instead on their personal lives – domestic details, family difficulties, close friends and especially people who influenced them."[42] While these elements do not disappear from the autobiographies of women of the resistance, they are relocated in the context of the public and historic struggle of their people.

The recent collection of Winnie Mandela's memoirs, edited by Anne Benjamin and entitled *Part of My Soul Went with Him*,[43] tells, for example, the story of enforced separation of husband and wife in South Africa and the transformation of private life into political activism. Winnie Mandela married Nelson Mandela, leader of the ANC, in 1958, six years before he was sentenced to life imprisonment by the South African government. Since then she herself has spent most of her own life under various banning orders and restrictions imposed by the same state apparatus which sentenced her husband. *Part of My Soul Went with Him* is only the latest of this collection of autobiographies by women who have been and continue to be active members of national liberation organizations and resistance movements. Unlike the rather patronizing representations of such movements and their participants in recent works of fiction such as Doris Lessing's *The Good Terrorist*, John Le Carré's *The Little Drummer Girl*, or even Marge Piercy's *Vida*, all of which tend to romanticize the attractions of male commandos and the seductive power of their revolutionary bravado and prowess while de-emphasizing the contributions of

the women, the autobiographies investigate the personal tensions as well as the social and political contradictions which condition the women's involvement in the resistance struggle. Their role in the program of radical social change is elaborated in the course of that struggle.

Doris Tijerino's autobiography takes place "inside the Nicaraguan revolution." More significant to her story than marriage relations is the relationship between mothers and daughters, which changed radically, first under pressure from the Somoza regime and then through the influence of the liberation movement. In the title to Margaret Randall's collection of interviews and conversations with Sandinista women, *Sandino's Daughters*, the evolving social patterns are already suggested. One of the chapters in that collection, which treats explicitly the topic of "mothers and daughters," makes it clear that,

> In Nicaragua this tradition has been challenged as more and more daughters assume leadership roles outside *and* with their mothers. In countless cases mothers began participating in the struggle as a result of their children's attitudes and activities. Of course it is not unheard of for the mother to be the first to become politically active. And then there are cases in which mother and daughter become active independently of one another. The specifics are always different but each of the mothers and daughters I talked with described a dramatic shift away from the traditional mother–daughter relationship.[44]

In Tijerino's case, it was her mother who found ways for her daughter to attend political meetings, devising pretexts of evening visits to friends which allowed the two women to leave home for the evening. Finally, after much conflict, the older woman is obliged to separate from her husband, "mainly," as Doris Tijerino writes, "because of his negative attitude to my militant activity." (INR, 117) Like Doña Santos, the mother of Julio Buitrago, a comrade who was killed in combat, (INR, 115–17) Doris's mother too contributed her support to the struggle. This transformation in the traditional patriarchal family structure was much debated within the resistance organization when one of its female comrades became pregnant after being raped in prison.

Lesbia Lopez was one of the women interviewed by Margaret Randall:

> Lesbia is now eighteen. Her elder daughter, Maura, is two years old. She was conceived when Lesbia was raped by a guard who tortured her in prison. I knew of Lesbia's rape and subsequent pregnancy, and of the discussion it provoked within the revolutionary movement. There were those who thought she should abort the child, as if paternity was the only issue. Another group, mostly women, took the opposite view: that the child would be the mother's and the baby a symbol of struggle and resistance, proof of women's capacity no matter what the risks or consequences. (SD, 193)

The combined exigencies of the liberation struggle and the revolutionary program of social change demand such a restructuring of personal and political relationships. As in Nicaragua in the 1970s and 1980s, it was necessary twenty years earlier in Kenya for the Mau Mau independence movement to reconsider the relevance of traditional women's roles. Karari Njama, who fought with Mau Mau, describes some of those changes:

> The primary aim was to establish more realistic rules and norms of conduct between the sexes and thereby reduce the possibilities of friction and conflict. To ensure the permanence of forest liaisons, "marriages" were to be publicly announced and registered, and leaders were not to interfere in the women's selection of spouses. Again, acknowledging a shift in the role of many women, the latter were to be issued ranks up to that of colonel on the basis of their abilities as warriors – which they were henceforward to be considered, along with the men.[45]

The social transformation in Nicaragua also transforms the narrative paradigms which reconstruct the accounts of individual and collective change. Doris Tijerino's autobiography begins with a recounting of significant moments in her personal development: her "first act of conspiracy," when as a child she smuggled a gun out of the town (INR, 46), her "first steps as a militant," (INR, 52) or the "first time the guard beat [her]." (INR, 58) Soon,

however, in the course of the narrative the significant moments become those of the FSLN itself: "the first street demonstrations of the popular liberation movement" on 23 July 1959 (INR, 61), and in 1963 the "first 'expropriation' in a Bank of America branch." (INR, 64) In 1966, Doris Tijerino herself received a new name from the Sandinista Front, that of Conchita Alday, who had been a part of Sandino's struggle and was killed in 1926. The concluding pages of *Inside the Nicaraguan Revolution* are punctuated with the names of the many guerrillas killed during the contemporary liberation struggle: the poet Leonel Rugama, her own comrade, comrades 2, 8, and 15, and Luisa Amanda Espinosa, the first Nicaraguan woman of the FSLN to die in combat and who gave her name to the Nicaraguan Women's Association.

Insisting on her own name, the Guatemalan political organizer begins her story:

> My name is Rigoberta Menchu. I am twenty-three years old. This is my testimony. I didn't learn it from a book and I didn't learn it alone. I'd like to stress that it's not only *my* life, it's also the testimony of my people. It's hard for me to remember everything that's happened to me in my life since there have been many very bad times but, yes, moments of joy as well. The important thing is that what has happened to me has happened to many other people too: My story is the story of all poor Guatemalans. My personal experience is the reality of a whole people. (IRM, 1)

The full Spanish title to Rigoberta Menchu's autobiography suggests the historical consequences of her personal itinerary. *Me Llamo Rigoberta Menchu y Asi Me Nacio la Conscienca* (My name is Rigoberto Menchu and this is how my consciousness was born) recounts the process whereby the Guatemalan Indian peasant girl became a national leader in her people's continuing struggle for human and civil rights. The text, which is arranged in part by Elizabeth Burgos-Debray, the anthropologist who recorded Rigoberta's story, begins ethnographically with a description of the traditions of the Guatemalan Indian community into which the Quiché woman was born and there follows a series of chapters on the family, birth ceremonies, the *nahual*, and life in the

finca where the peasants did seasonal work. The narrative itself thus represents a critical tension between the politically informed social scientific interest and the personal commitment to popular struggle of the two women involved in the autobiographical redaction.

The same dynamic which structured the narratives of *My People Shall Live* and *Inside the Nicaraguan Revolution* is evident in *I . . . Rigoberta Menchu*, which narrates simultaneously the social transformation of traditional family structure into a political organization and the personal transformation of the daughter into a political organizer. The assault from the system on the family unit is manifold: Rigoberta's brothers and sisters die of malnutrition and her father, mother, and brother are all three killed brutally in the struggle. Her father died during the occupation of the Spanish Embassy in the capital in 1979 and her mother and brother are tortured to death by Guatemalan army officers. In response to this systematic oppression the family and the traditional village community are obliged to restructure themselves. That restructuring occurs in the narrative in terms of its intervention at a given historical moment through the dispersal of the family members into different parts of the country, both for reasons of safety and in order to carry on the political tasks of organizing and education. The nature and conditions of the struggle itself are thus shown to play a critical role in determining future forms of organization.

For Rigoberta Menchu, the political struggle already enjoins rigorous personal demands, requiring her, as she sees it, to "renounce marriage and motherhood." (IRM, 225–6) Just as her gender role undergoes important alterations, so too is her ethnic and linguistic identity reshaped through her political activities. In order to communicate with the *ladino* population of Guatemala, she learns Spanish, for example, which had formerly been anathema to the Indian peasants. Already as a child her father had refused to send her to school, a decision which he came to regret later: "But he always said: 'Unfortunately, if I put you in a school, they'll make you forget your class, they'll turn you into a *ladino*. I don't want that for you and that's why I don't send you.'" (IRM, 190) The Indians learn Christianity too and assimilate it as an additional weapon in their struggle to their own

beliefs and rituals. In the end, however, Rigoberta Menchu concludes her narrative: "Nevertheless, I'm still keeping my Indian identity a secret. I'm still keeping secret what I think no one should know. Not even anthropologists or intellectuals, no matter how many books they have, can find all our secrets." (IRM, 247)

As part of her emerging consciousness of the "historical roots" of her people's struggle, Leila Khaled describes the moment in her childhood when her mother reminded her that there are

> three historic days of betrayal that every Palestinian should remember: the Balfour Declaration of November 2, 1917; the partition of Palestine, November 29, 1947; and the proclamation of the state of Israel, May 15, 1948. Ever since, these dates have become a vital and integral part of my life.
>
> (MPSL, 31–2)

Rigoberta Menchu exhibits a similar demand for the historical rights of her struggle when she describes the "day of Tecun Uman."

> Tecun Uman is the Quiché hero who is said to have fought the Spanish and then been killed by them. Well, there is a fiesta each year in the schools. They commemorate the day of Tecun Uman as the national hero of the Quichés. But we don't celebrate it, primarily because our parents say that this hero is not dead. So we don't celebrate. It's the *ladinos* in the schools who celebrate it. For us it would be rejecting him to say that he *was* a hero, that he fought and died, because that is talking about him in the past. His birthday is commemorated as something which represented the struggle of those times. But for us the struggle still goes on today, and our suffering more than ever. We don't want it said that all that happened in the past, but that it exists today, and so our parents don't let us celebrate it. We know this is our reality even though the *ladinos* tell it as if it were history.
>
> (IRM, 204)

In each case, the engagement with history and the historical record is critically evident.

The same historical blindness which Cornel West sees in the "European Enlightenment legacy – the inability to believe in the capacities of oppressed people to create cultural products of value and oppositional groups of value"[46] characterizes, in contrast to Khaled and Menchu's historical perceptions, such theoretical appreciations of women's strategies of liberation as that of Julia Kristeva in her article "Women's time." One of the moments of "women's time" which she analyzes is that moment when women's "anger" and demand for access to power is expressed in their adherence to what Kristeva refers to as "terrorist groups," giving three examples of such groups: Palestinian commandos, the Baader-Meinhof Gang, and the Red Brigades.[47] This assemblage and its conflation of First and Third Worlds betrays an uncritical failure to come to terms with history, circumstance, and context. As Miriam Galdemez asserted in her description of women migrant laborers in El Salvador,

> I think this is the hardest life of all: when she has to travel, caring for her children all the while, from the cotton harvest down on the coast to the coffee harvest up near the volcanoes of the central plateau. It's a terrible life and it's getting worse because there's less and less work available as agriculture gets more mechanized with so-called development. I think this is one of the reasons why women are getting more politicized and joining one of the popular organizations or the guerrillas.[48]

For many Third World women, feminism means women's liberation and women's liberation is seen as part of a popular struggle against forces of oppression. Such a struggle must necessarily have its roots in the material conditions of the people themselves, but must also contain the possibilities for a larger collective vision. Um Saad is a woman living in the Burj al-Barajnah Palestinian refugee camp outside Beirut. She is also the model for a series of stories, named for her, by Kanafani.[49] In one of these stories, Um Saad has taken a job as a cleaning lady in a large Lebanese-owned Beirut apartment building for LL5 a day. One day, while working, she is visited by a Lebanese woman who accuses Um Saad of causing her to lose her job. Um Saad, in consternation, denies this. When the Lebanese woman explains

to her that she had previously been employed at the same scullery work for LL7, Um Saad confronts the landlord and resigns her job.

Petals of Blood

Wanja, one of the main characters in Ngugi's novel *Petals of Blood*, arrived in Ilmorog at nearly the same time as the village's new schoolmaster, Munira. That was twelve years prior to the events which open the novel, which Ngugi completed in 1975. The arrival of the two outsiders in Ilmorog thus coincides closely with Kenya's independence in 1962 and Ngugi's narrative can be construed as a critique of post-colonial, what he would call neo-colonial, Kenyan society and politics.

When Munira and Wanja first come to Ilmorog, it is a small and much neglected village connected to the nearest town only by a barely passable dusty road and rarely visited by anyone from the town. During the twelve years that have elapsed from the time of their arrival, however, Ilmorog has become a feature on the Kenyan map. A transnational highway linking together the many parts of Africa has been built through its midst, bringing with it not only a renewed interest in the village on the part of politicians, but surveyors, overseers, and officials in jeeps and airplanes as well. Then one day one of these planes crashed in a field just outside Ilmorog and killed the donkey belonging to Abdulla the storekeeper, the donkey which had earlier carried a delegation of villagers to the capital to seek government aid against the ravages of drought in the village. The villagers, frightened at first by the terrible crash, quickly recover and "take the plane captive." (PB, 257) In time, a popular cult develops around the machine. As one newspaper reported in a feature article, commenting on the massive number of sightseers attracted to the area by the incident,

> "For it is now the subject of a cult. The cult is connected with a rumoured mythological animal of the earth. The animal, it is said, will bring power and light to the area. It was the animal, they say, which really brought down the plane." (PB, 258)

The cult grows until it becomes a national phenomenon, attracting the further interest of developers, contractors and speculators, who in turn begin appropriating the village land purchased, through a new financial scheme and land redistribution plan, by its village owners through bank loans which they are no longer able to pay back. Wanja is able to secure her grandmother's home, but only by reverting to her former profession of prostitution. Notable among her many clients are Mzigo, Chui, and Kimeria, three prominent national politicians who are all killed together in a fire at her place one night.

Ngugi's novel opens with the arrest of Wanja, Munira, Abdulla, and Karega following the fire, on the police's suspicion of their involvement in the incident. Like the other three, Karega is a "newcomer" to the village, where he taught for a short while in Munira's school before leaving to become active in trade union work in the country. With its multiple voices in all grammatical persons, its generic diversity combining oral tales and songs with elaborate confessional disquisitions, dramatic dialogue and multilingual passages, as well as its temporal experimentation, Ngugi's novel is itself an attempt to answer the question posed in the novel: "How does one tell of murder in a New Town?" (PB, 45) In an essay written in 1975, the same year as *Petals of Blood*, Ngugi reflected back on the hopes he had held for writing in Kenya in 1962. What difference would independence make?

> I myself can remember writing in 1962 how I looked forward to the day when all the preoccupation of African writers with colonial problems and politics would be over and we would all sit back and poke sophisticated irony at one another and laugh at ourselves whatever that was supposed to mean; we would then indulge in the luxury of comedies of social manners (what a philistine hollow ideal!) or explore the anguished world of lonely individuals abstracted from time and actual circumstances. (WP, 78)

Two years later, and only a few months after *Petals of Blood* was published in Africa, Ngugi was arrested by the Kenyatta regime and held for a year in detention.

Critical to the multiple narratives and styles in the novel is the cultural struggle Ngugi witnesses in Kenya between the people and the government officials and bureaucrats, a struggle which climaxes in the plane crash and the popular cult which develops around the fallen idol. The conflict, however, had begun some years earlier with the mass invitations to attend "high tea" issued by the newly established Kiama-Kamwene Cultural Organization, the KCO, which, according to the messenger sent with invitations to Ilmorog,

> would bring unity between the rich and poor and bring cultural harmony to all regions. . . . He explained that all the people from the Central Province were going to sing and drink tea. Just like 1952, he hinted and talked vaguely but with suggestive variation of voice, of a new cultural movement: Let he who had ears hear. (PB, 85)

1952: the year that Mau Mau had begun its struggle for independence. But now the invited villagers are being asked to contribute twelve shillings and fifty cents and the villagers respond by chasing the government messengers from their land, refusing to take the oath of belonging to the new cultural organization. What even the villagers recognize is that the scheme is an attempt on the part of the post-colonial government to appropriate for itself the popular Mau Mau heritage of national liberation struggle with its two oaths: the first, the oath of unity, and the second, the warrior or Batuni oath.

The debate over Mau Mau in Kenya is an important one, involving as it does the need of the government in power to legitimate itself in the eyes of the population. As in Somoza's Nicaragua where one could be arrested for mentioning the name of Sandino,[50] the conflict in Kenya has had various consequences and can result in suppression of all traces of the Mau Mau legacy as well as in official appropriation of its culture. Somoza himself had written a book about Sandino. Maina wa Kinyatti, a historian at the Kenyatta University College and translator and editor of *Thunder from the Mountains: Mau Mau Patriotic Songs*, for example, is currently under detention for his cultural activity in Kenya. To the proverbial question of the villagers who ask "what's in a

name?'' (PB, 61) Ngugi answered in his essay ''Mau Mau is coming back,'' written in London in 1982, the thirtieth anniversary of the beginning of the national liberation struggle: ''Kenyatta Day or Mau Mau Freedom Fighters Day! What's in a name? Everything, especially if it has to do with the *past*, that is with *history*.''[51]

''The aesthetic clash,'' as Michael Wilding says in his study *Political Fictions*, ''carries the force of ideological clash: class struggle.''[52] *Petals of Blood* ends its extensive critical analysis of post-independence Kenya with the abrupt superimposition of two unresolved and incomplete narrative paradigms: the one of romantic love and the other of popular struggle. On the last page of the novel, an anonymous young woman visits Karega, the trade union organizer, in prison where he is being held for suspected complicity in the fire which killed the politicians. The two of them exchange greetings, messages from comrades, and news of events in the city. The woman finally speaks the next to the last words in the novel: '' 'You'll come back,' she said again in a quiet affirmation of faith in eventual triumph.'' Karega answers her: '' 'Tomorrow . . . tomorrow . . .' he murmured to himself. 'Tomorrow . . .' and he knew he was no longer alone.'' The inconclusive imposition of the ending betrays the aesthetic and ideological clash of the Kenyan novelist, but it is the question now critical to resistance literature itself: ''How do you write about murder in a New Town?''

Epilogue

let's all brandish our heart

The poem, "Until we're free," by Gioconda Belli, which speaks of the ravages of the Nicaraguan countryside and the commitment to resistance of the country's people during their struggle against the Somoza dictatorship, is divided in two by the lines

let's all brandish our heart
never fearing that it will burst
for a heart the size of ours
resists the cruelest tortures
and nothing can placate its devastating love
which grows
beat by beat
stronger,
stronger,
stronger.

(NR, 233)

Gioconda Belli was living in exile in Costa Rica when the Sandinista revolution came to power in 1979. In the following year she returned to Nicaragua, where she still lives, to assist in the National Reconstruction. Like the many other writers who once fought with the FSLN and who are now full-time members of the Nicaraguan government, Gioconda Belli must contend with the physical and logistical displacement of writing by administrative

work. Much of Ernesto Cardenal's effort as Minister of Culture has been channeled into the literacy campaign, poetry workshops, popular theater and museums, as well as the task in 1983, when a United States invasion seemed imminent, of "storing underground the nation's entire cultural patrimony." (RSA, 108) For others, like Sergio Ramirez, novelist and member of the Sandinista executive, the "luxury of literature" must be temporarily deferred for the more immediate tasks of reconstruction. "My head," he says,

> is always full of literary temptations, of projects . . . novels and stories. I have a book of short stories planned, even down to the title and the subject matter of some of the pieces. I could easily write two or three more novels without having to look for a new theme. That is to say, if by magic I could sit down in front of a typewriter tomorrow, with ten hours a day guaranteed for work, I could begin to write again without any problem at all. So I always feel like a writer on loan to the revolution. And I think that it's a much more serious road than that of the politician on loan to literature; they've never made very good writers. (RSA, 38–9)

These writers are struggling now to make the difference between utopia and dystopia. Much as Kanafani, Leila Khaled, or Doris Tijerino were inspired by the promise of the success of the resistance struggle, much as Armah, Ngugi, or Sonallah Ibrahim were critical of its failures, the Sandinistas are aware of the dangers that continue to beset the new governments of the Third World.

René Descartes, credited in European thought with a radical critique of the self, chose, when it came to examining his own heart in part five of the *Discourse on Method*, to dissect the heart of an animal rather than risk such an operation on himself. For Frantz Fanon, however,

> The native intellectual who takes up arms to defend his nation's legitimacy and who wants to bring proofs to bear out that legitimacy, who is willing to strip himself naked to study the history of his body, is obliged to dissect the heart of his people. (WE, 170)

This, perhaps, is the heart that is brandished in Belli's poem. Resistance literature, as this study has attempted to show, has in the past played a vital role in the historical struggle of the resistance movements in the context of which it was written. That same literature continues to enlist readers and critics in the First as in the Third Worlds in the active reconstruction of interrupted histories. Omar Cabezas, former FSLN guerrilla and author of *The Mountain is Something More than a Great Expanse of Green* (published in English as *Fire from the Mountain*), and now head of the Nicaraguan Ministry of the Interior's Political Section, still maintains that:

> To have participated as a guerrilla, to have written this book, son of a bitch: it's dealt a real blow to the enemy. You feel like you could die after something like that. After that book and one more. Or that book and two more. Or that book and five more. Or just that book. What I want to say is it's dealt a blow to imperialism. I saw a photo, once, of a dead guerrilla in a Latin American country, and they showed everything he had in his knapsack: his plate, his spoon, his bedroll, his change of clothing, and *The Mountain is Something More than a Great Expanse of Green*. And I think back to when I was a guerrilla; when a guerrilla carries a book in his knapsack, it really means something. (RSA, 133)

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Resistance Literature introduces the western reader to one of the most subversive influences for political and cultural change today: the role of literature in contemporary Third World liberation movements. As such, Barbara Harlow considers a body of writing largely ignored in the west. Although the book is organized according to generic topics – poetry, narrative, prison memoirs – thematic topics, and the specific historical conditions that have influenced the cultural and political strategies of various resistance struggles, including those of Palestine, Nicaragua and South Africa, are foregrounded. Among the questions raised are: the role of Third World women; communication in circumstances of extreme atomization; literature versus propaganda; censorship; and the problem of adopting literary forms identified with the oppressor culture.

This powerfully argued and controversial critique develops an approach to literature which is essentially political. It will engage any student or teacher of literature, literary theory or Third World studies, who is prepared for the traditional categories and models of current western critical practice to be challenged.

Barbara Harlow is an Assistant Professor in English at the University of Texas at Austin.

The cover illustration shows a wall mural in Managua, painted in 1980 by Alejandro Canales in support of the Nicaraguan government literacy campaign.
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